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The Atlantic
EST. 1857

America's Best

Free Bread

*By Caity
Weaver*



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HEALTH CARE PROFESSIONALS AGREE Clinicians Can Help Prevent Youth Firearm Injuries

Too many young people are dying as a result of firearm injuries. In fact, firearm injuries have been the leading cause of death for children and teens in the U.S. for the last four years¹. But this doesn't have to be the reality, and we all have a role to play in addressing this urgent crisis. As clinicians and health care leaders, we care for the wellbeing of our patients and it's time we start prioritizing firearm injury prevention conversations as a routine part of care—the same way we do for topics like nutrition, helmet safety and other day-to-day concerns.

“It's time we start prioritizing firearm injury prevention conversations as a routine part of care”

Research shows a clear gap in care with 86% of adults reporting having never been asked about firearms in the home by a health care professional². But research also shows when these conversations happen, they work and families are more likely to adopt secure storage practices because of them³. This type of approach is a proven way for clinicians to reach people where they are and move the needle on key health issues, the way we have for years on other topics like seat belt use, smoking prevention and physical health.

Preventing firearm injuries starts with a conversation. That's why we have partnered with the Ad Council on “Agree to Agree,” a national initiative offering practical tools, resources and conversation guides—developed by HCPs for HCPs—to support these lifesaving conversations. You can find them at AgreeToAgree.org/HealthCare.

“86% of adults report having never been asked about firearms in the home by a health care professional”

Addressing firearm injuries among youth requires collective action—big and small. Today, 16 hospitals and health care organizations are uniting to show how collaboration and common ground can make our homes and communities safer for children and teens. We truly believe there is a future where no child dies from a preventable firearm injury—and clinicians, communities, gun owners and non-gun owners alike all have a role to play.

¹Johns Hopkins Center for Gun Violence Solutions

²KFF

³American Academy of Pediatrics

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Behind the Cover: In this month's cover story, "I Found It: The Best Free Restaurant Bread in America" (p. 24), Caity Weaver travels across the country to determine which establishment—from strip-mall chains to upscale brasseries—offers its customers the greatest complimentary bread. Armed with more than 500 nominations, Weaver

eventually crowned just one loaf champion. To accompany the story, we gathered 18 of the breads Weaver sampled for a photo shoot. On the cover are slices of a rustic country loaf from the three-Michelin-star Joël Robuchon at the MGM Grand in Las Vegas. (This is not the best free restaurant bread in America.) — Bifen Xu, *Senior Photo Editor*

THE

Accommodation Nation

In the January issue, Rose Horowitch reported on American colleges' extra-time-on-tests problem.

Letters

A

As a teacher and an administrator with more than 40 years of experience providing special-education services in public schools, I have watched the evolution of awareness and

support that Rose Horowitch describes. The Americans With Disabilities Act was meant to level the playing field by removing obstacles to publicly funded services for anyone identified as disabled. It was not enacted to provide advantages. But that has begun to change.

The root of the abuses, I think, is in the language of the law. The vagueness of crucial terms allows for easy manipulation of the eligibility process. The determination of a disability has become more subjective. Compassionate educators and invested parents can easily over-identify disabilities. I have seen students who perform extremely well on psychoeducational assessments and meet or exceed all grade-level standards put on an accommodation plan based on mild distractibility or slow written output.

Thanks to the ADA, many students who need support are seeing futures that otherwise would not have been possible. Yet the disproportionate number of "disabled" but high-achieving students at secondary schools reflects the pressure that students and their anxious parents feel to find any edge in a society where young adults face shrinking opportunities for gainful employment, secure incomes, and stable communities. These circumstances have turned a well-intentioned law into a ticket for advantages.

Patty Bell
Deerfield, Mass.

I recently graduated from law school in Canada, where the accommodations framework is very similar to that of the United States. I can confirm that the issue is quietly but

frequently discussed among students. Because many law schools apply a curved grading system, students without time-based accommodations sometimes feel that attaining an A is virtually impossible. Numerous students conveyed to me a sense of disillusionment: No matter how diligently they prepare, they may still receive a B+ simply because the A-range grades have been taken by those who had twice the time to complete the assessment.

In response, some of my peers sought accommodations themselves—sometimes out of legitimate need, but sometimes because of the competitive pressure created by the system. This situation warrants careful reexamination. Short of eliminating accommodations—which would be contrary to human-rights principles and entirely inappropriate—the most constructive solution may be to reconsider the role of time limits in assessments altogether. Providing all students with a reasonable and uniform time-frame in which to demonstrate their knowledge, without excessive time pressure, may help restore both fairness and clarity in evaluation.

David Kantrovitz
Maple, Ontario, Canada

I am a former college disability-services professional who worked for more than 24 years in both two- and four-year institutions. Before entering the field professionally, I myself was a student who used accommodations in the early



and mid-1990s. Although it is absolutely correct that the 2008 ADA amendments, the expanded assessment guidance, and the dramatic rise in ADHD, anxiety, and depression diagnoses among young people have all contributed to the increase in students receiving accommodations, so, too, has the corporatization of higher education.

Today, universities treat their students as customers. Rising tuition costs have forced administrators to adopt a customer-service model, which in turn has heightened pressure on staff to keep students and their families satisfied. Academic accommodations are often folded into the model, and disability-services providers are encouraged to waive or dilute documentation standards. This can improve access for students who lack financial resources, but my experience has been that the students who benefit the most are those with means. Demanding parents expect institutions to remove every obstacle to their children's ideal college experience. This environment makes it extremely difficult for disability-services professionals to apply consistent standards or to make thoughtful, evidence-based decisions about which academic adjustments are genuinely warranted and which are simply desired.

Chris Kinney
Crozet, Va.

I was born with optic atrophy and am just blind enough to be designated "legally blind." In 1961, I was completing a master's degree at the University of Chicago; I needed only to pass a language exam to graduate. These exams were given in a huge room in an old stone building with little windows up near high ceilings. I didn't have enough light to read. I failed. I went from one office to another requesting permission to take the test again with a lamp. No one seemed to have the authority to grant my "outrageous" request. I finally found a dean who laughed with me at the absurdity. He arranged for me to retake the exam with a good reading lamp. I thanked him. I took the exam again, and I passed.

Naomi Woronov
New York, N.Y.

I am a professor at a non-selective public university who attended an elite university with accommodations for both physical and learning disabilities. I have students who would really benefit from accommodations but do not seek them. Many of these students have been raised in households and

communities that stigmatize disability or seeking help.

The Americans With Disabilities Act exists in an inequitable context—so of course economic inequality can hamper its application. But making accommodations harder to obtain is the wrong solution. Perhaps we ought to consider a more radical approach: rethinking pedagogies to be more inclusive so that accommodations are rendered moot. Unless the learning objective of a course is specifically to do something quickly, wouldn't it be better if everyone had the time and means to demonstrate their mastery of a new concept or skill? We don't lower academic rigor by making accommodations universal—we give students the ability to fully demonstrate what they've learned.

Miranda Worthen
Professor, San José State University
San José, Calif.

Why not allow extended time for all students? In a world where AI encourages quick fixes and discourages independent thinking, aren't critical and deep thinking exactly what we want to cultivate at a university? My guess is that most students will

not stay one minute more than they have to in an exam room.

Julie F. Skolnick
Potomac, Md.

ROSE HOROWITCH REPLIES:

Thank you for engaging with my article so thoughtfully. A perfect structure would allow accommodations for every student who needs them while preventing students who don't from gaining an unfair advantage. But I understand that the same factors that allow more privileged students to access accommodations—wealth, cultural capital—can prevent others from getting the support they need. The suggestion to remove time limits is an interesting one. Some professors I spoke with said that they, too, favored this solution—they didn't see any pedagogical need for their students to complete tests in a certain amount of time. The idea would create new demands at universities for physical space and proctors, but it could be worth exploring.

To respond to *Atlantic* articles or submit author questions to The Commons, please email letters@theatlantic.com. Include your full name, city, and state.

Corrections: "The Women of Avenger Field" (April) stated that Patricia Perry moved two hours southeast to study political science at UC Berkeley and that she arrived in Sweetwater, Texas, on July 5, 1943. In fact, she moved two hours southwest, and she began training in Sweetwater on that date. The article also included a quote attributed to a base commander that was in fact a quote from another source paraphrasing his remarks, and used an incorrect verb tense in a quote from Pete Hegseth. "The Secrets of Indigenous Art" (March) stated that a traveling exhibition of Native abstraction was organized by Jeffrey Gibson. In fact, it was co-organized by Gibson and Jenelle Porter. "How America Got So Sick" (March) implied that tuberculosis was among the diseases covered by the national vaccine schedule for which cases are surging. In fact, the United States does not routinely vaccinate for tuberculosis.

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DISPATCHES

OPENING ARGUMENT

A FINE COUNTRY FOR OLD MEN

*Geriatric Americans are
hoarding wealth and power.*

BY IDREES KAHLOON

Gerontocracy has always thrived in undemocratic places—Communist people’s republics, Gulf monarchies—where only death could pry power from the ruling elders. American gerontocracy is exceptional for being freely elected. Donald Trump will soon be an octogenarian, and is president in part because the preceding octogenarian, Joe Biden, did not want to admit his senescence. The median senator is 65, and the oldest, 92-year-old Chuck Grassley, has not ruled out running for reelection in 2028. The typical general-election voter is a spry 52, but in primary elections, which decide the majority of

political contests, that number rises to 59. Half of all the money donated to political campaigns comes from Americans age 66 and older.

Although political gerontocracy has operated overtly, the rising economic power of the elderly has escaped much notice. Over the past 40 or so years, American wealth has grown ever more concentrated among the oldest generations. In 1989, Americans over age 55 held 56 percent of it; today they hold 74 percent. During that same period, the share of wealth held by Americans under 40 has shrunk by nearly half, from 12 to 6.6 percent. The color of money is now gray.

Much of this shift is the result of demographic change: 18 percent of Americans are senior citizens today, up from 13 percent in 1990. But even at the household level, Americans over 55 have accrued wealth more rapidly than those who are younger. Among those 75 and older, the numbers are particularly striking. In 1983, their household net worth was only slightly above the national average; by 2022, it was 55 percent higher.

For nearly a century, some of the central debates in American politics have been over inequalities—between rich and poor, male and female, Black and white. When the Baby Boomers were children, older Americans were widely viewed as vulnerable. “Fifty percent of the elderly exist below minimum standards of decency, and this is a figure much higher than that for any other age group,” Michael Harrington wrote in his 1962 book *The Other America*, often credited with inspiring the War on Poverty. “This is no country for old men.”

Three years later, in 1965, Medicare was created. A major expansion of Social Security followed in 1972. These changes were remarkably effective: The share of elderly people living in poverty dropped by more than one-third within a decade. But because these programs are broad-based entitlements, they have transferred huge sums to the prosperous,

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too. The portfolios of that latter group, meanwhile, have been swelled by a rising stock market and rising home values, outcomes that may not be entirely replicable for younger generations. As a result of all of these factors, intergenerational inequality between old and young has not merely reversed. It has accelerated.

Most current Social Security and Medicare beneficiaries will receive more from the program over their lifetime than they paid in taxes, and the extra money will necessarily come from the pockets of younger generations. The two programs now pay out more than \$2 trillion a year, more than one-third of all federal expenditures. Their sustainability was a subject of major debate during the Obama

years, when the national debt was much lower than it is today and interest rates on that debt were close to zero. Financially, the matter is more urgent now. The trust funds for Social Security benefits and Medicare’s hospital insurance are projected to become insolvent in roughly seven years.

Yet even noticing the looming threats has become taboo for the two major political parties. One of Trump’s shrewdest political realizations was that entitlement reform—once a priority for fiscal conservatives—was a losing issue. Instead, he has pledged not to touch entitlement spending and lavished seniors with even more government money. His One Big Beautiful Bill Act created a special \$6,000 tax deduction for seniors, which will cost taxpayers \$91 billion over the next four years. The same bill cuts \$1 trillion in spending on Medicaid, which is expected to leave some 5 million working-age Americans uninsured.

This bodes poorly for intergenerational peace. Respect for elders is being replaced by resentment of elders. A majority of young Americans no longer believe in the American dream. Many Millennials and Gen Zers expressly blame the Boomers for that, accusing them of hoarding wealth, jobs, and power. Many of these accusations are inchoate, but they are not entirely baseless.

THE BEST REBUTTAL to the gerontocratic critique is that young Americans do not appreciate how good they have it. Although people of working age possess a smaller share of the national wealth, they are richer in absolute terms than Boomers were at their age. The

median 35-year-old Millennial earns 38 percent more in post-tax, inflation-adjusted income than the typical Boomer did at the same age, according to research by the economist Kevin Corinth. Gen Zers have only begun their careers, but so far they are earning more than their Millennial predecessors. This trend shows up in wealth statistics, too. When Boomers were between the ages of 25 and 43, they had a median net worth of \$58,000 (in 2022 dollars); Millennials at the same stage of life had a net worth of \$85,000. So why are young Americans so depressed about their economic future?

The pathologies of the housing market are one reason. The typical home today costs five times the median annual income, up from 3.5 times the median annual income in 1984. Boomers got lucky: When they were young, they could afford to buy houses that then appreciated fantastically in value. But that luck was arguably manufactured by Washington, which engineered the rise of 30-year, fixed-rate mortgages and created tax deductions for mortgage interest and property taxes.

These government subsidies still exist today. But even with them, younger Americans cannot buy houses at the same rate that Boomers did. In a paper titled “Giving Up,” the economists Seung Hyeon Lee and Younggeun Yoo predicted that Millennials will enter retirement with much lower homeownership rates than the generations before them—74 percent compared with 84 percent for Boomers. Some 15 percent of Millennials, they noted, had already given up on homeownership by age 30. These Millennials,

they found, work less, spend more on credit, and are more likely to buy cryptocurrency or make other risky investments. Feeling locked out of owning a house casts a malaise—one made worse by the anxiety that the welfare state they currently support will become stingier when they eventually need it.

Older generations used the levers of government to create

this situation. In high-cost cities, the building of new homes and apartment complexes is often derailed in local planning and zoning-board meetings. In 2019, the political scientists Katherine Levine Einstein, Maxwell Palmer, and David Glick published a study examining who attended such meetings in the Boston area. The attendees, they

found, were likely to be longtime homeowners who oppose new development. Preventing construction kept the value of their assets high—at the expense of younger, prospective homeowners.

Homeowner preferences hard-coded into state constitutions decades ago now further sustain the gerontocracy. In 1978, Californians voted

by referendum for Proposition 13, which severely limited the property taxes that existing homeowners would have to pay—so long as they remained in place. In one study, the law was estimated to have caused a 15 percent increase in California housing prices all by itself. As longtime homeowners profited, the lost tax revenue forced reductions in school spending,



California is not unique, and housing is not the only means by which the older generations have effectively pulled up the ladder behind them. Preferences for the elderly over the young are a fixture of public budgets nationwide. Across all government programs—federal, state, and local—\$2 are now spent on seniors for every \$1 spent on children.

ACCORDING TO Tim Vlandas, an Oxford political economist, advanced democracies around the world are reaching the point of “gerontonomia”—his term for a stagnating political economy set up to prioritize elderly citizens. These citizens punish their elected governments for inflation, which lessens the value of savings and pension payments. They are much more tolerant of unemployment, because they no longer work; slow growth, because their wealth has already accumulated; and high public debt, because their descendants will pay it. The result, Vlandas argues, is lower wage growth for those still working, and also worse outcomes for their children, as a result of lower social investment over the course of their lives.

Graying democracies everywhere have made generous pension commitments that they are struggling to maintain. In the United Kingdom, the “triple lock,” a rule that in most years mandates that state pension payments increase more than inflation, seems politically impossible to change. In France, people protested for months against Emmanuel Macron in 2023 over the raising of the retirement age from 62 to 64.

Yet these challenges are especially acute in America. Because Social Security still

has a trust fund to draw on, voters may not realize that benefits already exceed contributions. But this fund, which stood at \$2.9 trillion in 2021, is on pace to dwindle to zero by about 2033. The Trump administration’s immigration crackdown will hasten the

ACROSS ALL
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arrival of exhaustion day by cutting the number of tax-paying workers who support retirees’ benefits. Once that trust fund is gone—absent a tax increase on current workers or some other change—beneficiaries would suffer an immediate 23 percent cut in payments. A similar process would leave the Medicare Part A program, which covers hospital stays for the elderly, insolvent at about the same time.

The national debt will by then be gargantuan. Previously unthinkable ideas—such as means-tested Social Security benefits, confiscatory wealth taxes, even health-care rationing—might be contemplated. The bill coming due for the senior welfare state might

not trouble this president, but it could well be the defining problem for the next one.

SOME PEOPLE WOULD like to start the fight over how to resolve it now. Among them are radical thinkers who contend that in order to defeat economic gerontocracy, Americans must first defang the elderly ruling class. In his forthcoming book, *Gerontocracy in America*, the 54-year-old Yale law and history professor Samuel Moyn calls for destroying this “tyranny of the minority,” set up by “old people with enormous private power who hold society in chains.” Power, he argues, needs to be seized back, leaving “the elderly divested of political power, wealth, and property.”

Moyn wants to create mandatory retirement ages, perhaps starting as low as 65, for elected officials and people with some desirable private-sector jobs. Then he would come for the money, increasing taxes on both income and accumulated assets to dilute the share of elderly wealth. Most astonishingly, he proposes diluting older Americans’ political power too, by literally valuing the votes of young people more, on the theory that the latter will suffer the consequences of political decisions for much longer. (This proposed social engineering is both harsh and vanishingly improbable. The modern legal principle of “one person, one vote” exists for good reason.)

Still, Moyn’s ideas underscore the need for an equitable post-Boomer settlement, one that will be easier to find if we start the search sooner rather than later. In the 20th century, the United States realized it was too rich and too decent a country to allow its elderly

citizens to live in penury. And it made an enduring commitment to address that problem, one that has unequivocally succeeded: There has never been a better time to be a senior citizen in America. And yet the U.S. has made no comparable commitment to working families, who are stymied not only by expensive housing but also by child-care and higher-education bills. Child poverty in America persists at levels alarmingly higher than in other advanced democracies.

Initiatives such as Franklin D. Roosevelt’s New Deal and Lyndon B. Johnson’s Great Society established what current workers in a decent country owed to retirees. A new social contract can be struck that would deliver at least some optimism for today’s workers. Curing gerontonomia would require redirecting some public funds from programs aimed at the elderly, such as Social Security, to family benefits, education, and infrastructure. But an intergenerational recalibration can come about in gentler ways than Moyn’s: The wealthiest Social Security recipients, for instance, could forgo some of their scheduled benefits, which could instead be contributed annually to “baby bond” accounts for America’s children, a source of capital to be used in adulthood.

And not every solution rests with the welfare state. Cutting through housing restrictions would generate enormous social benefit, if America’s elderly ruling class were to allow such a feat. Today’s gerontocrats will eventually die. But their legacy will be a mess to sort out. *A*

Idrees Kahloon is a staff writer at The Atlantic.



THE MOTION

By Christopher Chen
Directed by Hana S. Sharif

MAY 6 – JUNE 14

Who gets to decide?

What begins as a debate between four scholars quickly transitions into a real-life experiment—where the scientists become the subjects.

Basic human rights come into question.

Who deserves to love? Who deserves to live? And, most importantly, who gets to decide what it means to be human?



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CAN TURNING OFF YOUR PHONE BRING YOU CLOSER TO GOD?

Pastor John Mark Comer has won a massive following by preaching about the ills of technology.

BY NANCY WALECKI

John Mark Comer can be a hard man to find. He's one of the most famous pastors in America right now, an author whose books have together sold more than 1 million copies, but he's not the most reachable guy. He has a professional website but no contact page. He rarely travels. And as I reported this story, I began to learn his habits: Sending him a text early in the day was a wash, for instance, because he doesn't check his phone until after morning prayer time. Once, when I reached out by email, I got an out-of-office response that he had set before Christmas explaining that he was observing "rhythms of rest" and asking that I try him again after his return in mid-January. Incoming messages sent in the meantime would be deleted.

I had first seen Comer in October, at a service for Church of the City New York, held inside a historic chapel in Lower Manhattan. Lo-fi beats played over the speakers as hundreds of people, mostly in their 20s and 30s, milled around and looked for seats in the crammed pews. When Comer took the stage, dressed in a matching ochre shirt-jacket and pants, a silver stud in his left ear, the crowd cheered and whooped.

He pulled up a slide. It was not the usual Bible story or psalm, but an excerpt from Anne Helen Petersen's 2019 *BuzzFeed* essay "How Millennials Became the Burnout Generation." Burnout is "not a temporary affliction," it read. "It's the millennial condition." The Gen Z one, too, Comer added. "It's like we just churn out tired, exhausted souls like a widget factory," he said. "I don't know if you feel this at all yet in your body or in your bones. If you don't, it's because you're still young and you haven't been in the city very long. But you will. Trust me, you will."

Then he clicked over to a passage from the Gospel of Matthew:

Come to me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest. Take my yoke upon you and learn from me, for I am gentle and humble in heart, and you will find rest for your souls. For my yoke is easy and my burden is light.

"Most of us, as modern Americans," Comer said, with a hand over his heart, "we read that line and there's just this, like, deep, soul-level, *Yes, I ache for that.*" The guy in front of me took a picture of the slide with his phone. I noticed that his screen was set to gray scale.

So was the screen of the person sitting next to me.

Signs of Comer's influence had been popping up in my life all year. One friend had started observing a 24-hour, phone-free Sabbath. My roommates began fasting several times a

COMER
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GOD.

hurting oneself through each day; a schedule that makes little room for God. Technology has only exacerbated the problem. Comer calls the modern world "a virtual conspiracy against the interior life," and urges readers to reclaim their focus from the algorithm and shift it toward God.

The Ruthless Elimination of Hurry, he told me, is "a book about discipleship to Jesus masquerading as a self-help book." Many of its suggestions are similar to what you might find in articles about digital detoxes. To break a cellphone addiction, he offers detailed advice on how to "turn your smartphone into a dumbphone": delete social media and web browsers, turn off notifications, and set your screen to gray scale, to curb the appeal of the remaining candy-colored apps. His prose, too, is rendered in a pithy, how-to style that one of his critics has dubbed "The Ruthless Elimination of Paragraphs."

Because of this approach, Comer can seem more like a wellness personality, such as Andrew Huberman, than a pastor. Like Huberman, Comer offers a concrete regimen that's attractive to people who feel unmoored in contemporary society. Comer's skeptics, when remarking on his rapid ascent, point to these

month. Then, in quick succession, three different people recommended that I read *The Ruthless Elimination of Hurry*, Comer's 2019 best seller.

In that book, Comer advances the theory that the great enemy of spiritual life is hurry. By this he means not simply busyness: Hurry is a gnawing sense that there is always more to do; a life spent

similarities and wonder if what he's offering is simply baptized wellness, a pop spirituality tailored to the tastes and frustrations of affluent young people. But sitting among his followers, I wondered: *Could Comer's practices actually bring them closer to God?*

I MET COMER the next day at a coffee shop in the East Village. Our cashier, who looked about 24, recognized Comer and was visibly starstruck. "Your books are so amazing," he said. "I pass them around to all my friends." Our lattes, he insisted, were on the house. Comer told me that the same thing had happened yesterday in SoHo, then he shrugged. "Coffee shops are like bars for Christians."

Comer is Protestant, non-denominational, and roughly in the evangelical sphere, but his work is mostly about how technology—what he calls "the machine"—is spiritually deforming people. "Any version of discipleship to Jesus that doesn't seriously take into account that," he said, pointing at my phone, "is going to be wildly deficient." Christian spirituality has always adapted to its time, Comer said. In trying to adapt the faith for the 21st century, he looks to the life of Jesus, who took a Sabbath, fasted, and spent regular time in silence and solitude. To Comer, these weren't the rhythms of Jesus's life just because he happened to live in Galilee in 30 C.E. They are spiritual practices that Christians in any era ought to emulate.

Comer's most recent book, 2024's *Practicing the Way*, is a sort of how-to guide for Christlike living. Inspired in part by the monastic Order

of Saint Benedict, Comer encourages readers to incorporate nine of Jesus's habits into their lives: scripture reading, service, keeping the Sabbath, solitude, prayer, fasting, community, witness, and generosity. He calls his work "spiritual archaeology"—reintroducing modern believers to ancient Christian practices. "Everything we need, for the most

part, is there in church history," he said. "We've just lost a lot of it."

Comer is hardly the first such archaeologist. Each generation of evangelical Christianity has three main celebrities, Russell Moore, the editor at large of *Christianity Today*, told me: the politics guy, the church-growth guy, and the personal-spirituality guy. In the

1980s, these roles were played, respectively, by Pat Robertson, Rick Warren, and Dallas Willard. Right now, Comer is the personal-spirituality guy (yes, it's always a guy). Willard encouraged evangelicals to adopt virtually the same practices, such as fasting and taking a Sabbath, in 1988's *The Spirit of the Disciplines*, and a subset of evangelicals has practiced



John Mark Comer says his practices should be judged not by how happy his followers are, but by how close they are to God.

them ever since. But Comer is making his case at a very different moment.

“A lot of American evangelical leadership right now is algorithmic,” Moore said, meaning that many pastors ratchet up their sermon rhetoric to find an audience on social media—usually by decrying homosexuality and abortion. Comer has written that God’s vision of marriage is between a man and a woman, and he’s argued against the idea of abortion as “reproductive justice.” But he doesn’t really preach about those issues, so the traditional Christian political camps aren’t sure what to make of him. He’s too conservative for the progressive Christians, and the conservative ones assume that he’s a tote-bag-carrying NPR liberal.

Comer doesn’t avoid the algorithm entirely. He has more than a quarter million followers on Instagram, where he mostly posts clips about the nine practices and shares quotes from Christian writers in minimalist fonts on earth-toned slides. He likens such social-media outreach to a street preacher at an Old West saloon: You say your piece about Jesus, hope you change some minds, and get out as quickly as you can.

IN DECEMBER, I went to Comer’s house for tea. About two and a half years ago, his family moved from Portland, Oregon, to Topanga Canyon, a mountain community outside Los Angeles known as a hub of West Coast hippiedom—think Deadheads, crystals, and astral-projection workshops. The road to Comer’s home is shaded by scrub oak and barely wide enough to accommodate a single car. We

sat in the living room beside the Christmas tree, where presents lay wrapped in butcher paper. Comer was on cooking duty that night, and his wife unloaded the groceries. Their teenage son and daughter milled around the living room as Comer and I spoke. He apologized for the commotion.

Comer grew up in the ’80s in Silicon Valley; his parents were “first-generation Christians,” as he put it. His father, Phil, was a rock musician in the ’60s and ’70s who encountered God for the first time during one of Billy Graham’s crusades, eventually becoming the worship pastor at Los Gatos Christian Church, one of the Bay Area’s earliest evangelical megachurches. Comer took after his dad, joining the ministry and then co-founding a church in the suburbs of Portland with his parents in 2003, when he was 23 years old. Comer was the cool preacher, a West Coast urbanite just like his congregants; he understood why people might be cynical about religion. (When we met, I apologized for saying “damn” in front of a pastor. He reminded me that I was with a pastor from California.)

His church added about 1,000 congregants a year for seven years straight and soon outgrew its original building, coming to command multiple locations around the city. Comer became the head of what was essentially a ministry franchise, he reflected later—“the Starbucks model of ‘local’ church”—where he was trying to give thousands of people the same experience, whether they were in downtown Portland or the suburbs.

By about 2014, Comer was preaching six services on Sundays and heading home

at 10 p.m., long after his kids were asleep. He didn’t have time for himself or his family. The Bible calls Christians to be patient, to love. But Comer was becoming more hurried and less loving. He realized, as he would later write, that “you can be a success as a pastor and a failure as an apprentice of Jesus.” In

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Millennial terms, he was suffering from burnout, badly.

Comer took a break from preaching and started reorganizing his life. He tried to emulate Christ’s daily actions, gradually incorporating them into his lifestyle both then and after he returned to pastoring, now at just one of the church’s locations, known as Bridgetown Church, in downtown Portland. He began fasting, eventually working up to two days a week, and observing the Sabbath by turning off his devices on Saturdays and spending his time resting

and worshipping. He still needed to use email and social media for work, but he took these apps off his phone and checked them on his computer only once a week. And because Jesus lived simply, Comer pared down his closet to three outfits for the Oregon winter and two for the summer.

He worked less, spent more time with his wife, built more *Star Wars* Lego sets with his kids. “Even better,” he’d later write about that period, he could “feel God again.” Comer was convinced that his entire church would benefit from these practices. So, over the next five years, Bridgetown adopted the disciplines as a congregation, creating the blueprint for the nine practices that Comer later would lay out in *Practicing the Way*.

Running a huge church was hard on him; for years, he had wanted to write and to work one-on-one with people instead of preaching. Comer stepped down from Bridgetown in 2021 and now leads a non-profit, also called Practicing the Way, which offers a free course that more than 21,000 church groups have adopted. He’s on the teaching staff at a church in Los Angeles, but mostly, Comer serves as the pastor of his own small church, which follows the *Practicing the Way* disciplines: The 30-person congregation fasts together, takes the Sabbath together, and, on Sundays, meets for a service in his living room. He has “built a quiet life,” his friend and successor at Bridgetown, Pastor Tyler Staton, told me. “Some might accuse him of being a touch boring.”

COMER TOLD ME that his average reader is 27, with at

least some college education, living in a city. I'm 27, with a college degree, living in New York. I wondered whether I could adhere to his disciplines, and if so, how they might affect my faith. So, for the past six months, I've tried to structure my life around *Practicing the Way's* nine core habits.

I'd wake up early to spend an hour alone at the window next to my fire escape, reading scripture and praying; this was a major upgrade from checking my phone first thing in the morning. Once a week, I'd observe the Sabbath—put away my screens, do some form of worship, revel in the fact that I could do nothing for a day and God would keep the universe going. As part of the service practice, I volunteered at a soup kitchen once a month and started carrying food with me when I walked around the city, in case I passed people who looked hungry.

I did chafe against some of the disciplines. Navigating modern life with no phone for a day was a mess: Without Google Maps, I'd get lost; without texting, every meetup with friends felt like the high-stakes rendezvous at the end of *An Affair to Remember*. And although sometimes I'd have a moment or two of transcendence on my weekly fasting day, for the most part, I was just hungry.

I am surprised, though, by how much these practices have become central to my life—not because I think I will be smote if I don't do them, but because it turns out I like them. (Except for fasting. That one is still a bummer.) The new constraints on my time and attention forced me to truly consider what was important or not, and to prioritize those

things. I spent less time on the parts of my day that brought me little joy (my phone) and more time with friends. My life is less hurried. I'm happier.

But my happiness is not the point, according to Comer. The purpose of a spiritual discipline is “not personal fulfillment. It's not personal expression. It's not emotional wellness. It's not to de-stress,” he said. The point is to have your character transformed by your attunement to God. Then it will be easier to follow Jesus's two greatest commandments: love God and love others. Fasting and discipline, you can get from Andrew Huberman; self-care, from Goop. But, Comer told me, “wellness culture is not talking about the Sermon on the Mount.”

That sermon—in which Jesus says people must love their enemies, must turn the other cheek, and cannot serve God and money—asks a lot from believers. Dallas Willard, Comer's forebear, argued that a person who expects to live up to Jesus's commands on the spur of the moment, without structuring their life at least somewhat around Jesus's, is like “a baseball player who expects to excel in the game without adequate exercise of his body.” The theory is that, to become more Christlike, you have to find more ways to literally live like Christ.

Comer's critics worry that by focusing so much on Jesus's daily regimen, he risks recasting the son of God as the original lifestyle guru. “The (real) point of the Gospels—identifying who Jesus is, putting faith in him, and worshiping him—is put in the background, while living like Jesus is put in the foreground,” Kevin DeYoung, a theologian and Presbyterian

pastor, wrote in a review of *Practicing the Way*.

According to DeYoung, this isn't just a small matter of emphasis. “How effective can an approach to spiritual formation be when it almost completely misses the point of Jesus's life and ministry?” he wrote. DeYoung told me that when the apostle Paul writes to the early Ephesian church about how to combat evil in their lives, “he doesn't tell them, ‘Here are a set of rhythms and come up with 10 rules for your life.’” He tells them about the power of God.

DeYoung and others also criticize Comer for conforming his ministry too much to the lives of young, well-to-do urbanites—repackaging Christian monasticism for the TikTok generation. Given how inconvenient Comer's disciplines can be, his skeptics think they're achievable for yuppies in ways they may not be for others who have fewer resources or more demands on their time. DeYoung and his wife have a big family, and although Comer's routine may sound nice, he told me, “we're trying to just get through our week.”

Comer counters that many churches are facing what he calls a “crisis of discipleship” because they don't give congregants enough instruction on how to actually live as Christians. But he says that he's not doctrinaire about the practices; he doesn't expect everyone to do all of them, all of the time: Jesus himself rebelled against the rigidity of the Pharisees by healing people and harvesting grain on the Sabbath. The night I saw Comer preach in New York City, he stressed that the question shouldn't be *Did I fast this week?* or *Did I observe the Sabbath?* Comer wants

his followers to ask themselves instead, *Am I becoming more gentle?* and *Am I becoming more humble?*

I Googled myself yesterday, so I still have a ways to go. But I had never asked myself those sorts of questions before. As a Christian moving in mostly secular circles, I'd felt that simply believing in God was a big enough feat. My faith had never shaped the way I lived each day. I am proof that you can say you love God and offer very little of your life to him. The practices became a way to call my own bluff.

I'm a member of the precise audience Comer is writing for—those who believe in the Gospels but haven't made much time for a spiritual life; those who no longer feel at home in an evangelical community that has itself been warped by the imperatives of social media; those who (if we're honest) can sometimes feel embarrassed to be seen as religious in a secular world. He told me that he is speaking to people who “want to figure out how to stay true to the Christian story in a very hostile cultural environment” but feel they need a road map. Even if the temptations of contemporary America look nothing like the ones the early Christian ascetics lived in the desert to avoid, that doesn't necessarily mean the road map itself is out-of-date. And if, in promoting that road map, Comer can sometimes seem like many secular wellness influencers, maybe it's a sign that they, too, are responding to a collective crisis of faith, and don't yet know it. *A*

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New Chairs

*Photograph by Laurence
Getford, sculpture by
Robert Rauschenberg*



Collaboration, for Robert Rauschenberg and Merce Cunningham, began with the arrangement of chairs.

In the summer of 1952, when Rauschenberg was 26 and Cunningham was 33, both were living at Black Mountain College, a nontraditional art school in North Carolina that encouraged exchange and experimentation among its students and faculty. One August night, the composer John Cage—Cunningham’s partner—convened an impromptu performance in the dining hall featuring Rauschenberg, Cunningham, and others. No one took any pictures of the event, and firsthand accounts and recollections vary. Cunningham, who later became famous as a choreographer, was chased by a dog as he danced. Rauschenberg, a path-breaking visual artist, seems to have provided

paintings for the “set,” and played old songs on a gramophone. There was no script, and certainly no rehearsal—but not everything was left to chance. Chairs were carefully laid out in a square, in the middle of the action, so that audience members could look at one another while they watched the performers. The people were part of the art, and not knowing exactly what, or whom, to focus on at any given moment was the point.

Cunningham and Rauschenberg remained friends and collaborators. Of his work with Cunningham, Rauschenberg reportedly said that he felt more at home with dancers than he did in the world of painting: “The idea of having your own body and its activity be the material—that was really tempting.” Much of Rauschenberg’s art was three-dimensional; he was widely celebrated

for his “combines,” which incorporated found objects into canvases and freestanding sculptures. In a 1981 sculpture, *The Ancient Incident (Kabal American Zephyr)*, he used wood-and-metal stands and two wooden chairs to create a pyramid of sorts—an elegant, if impractical, seating arrangement.

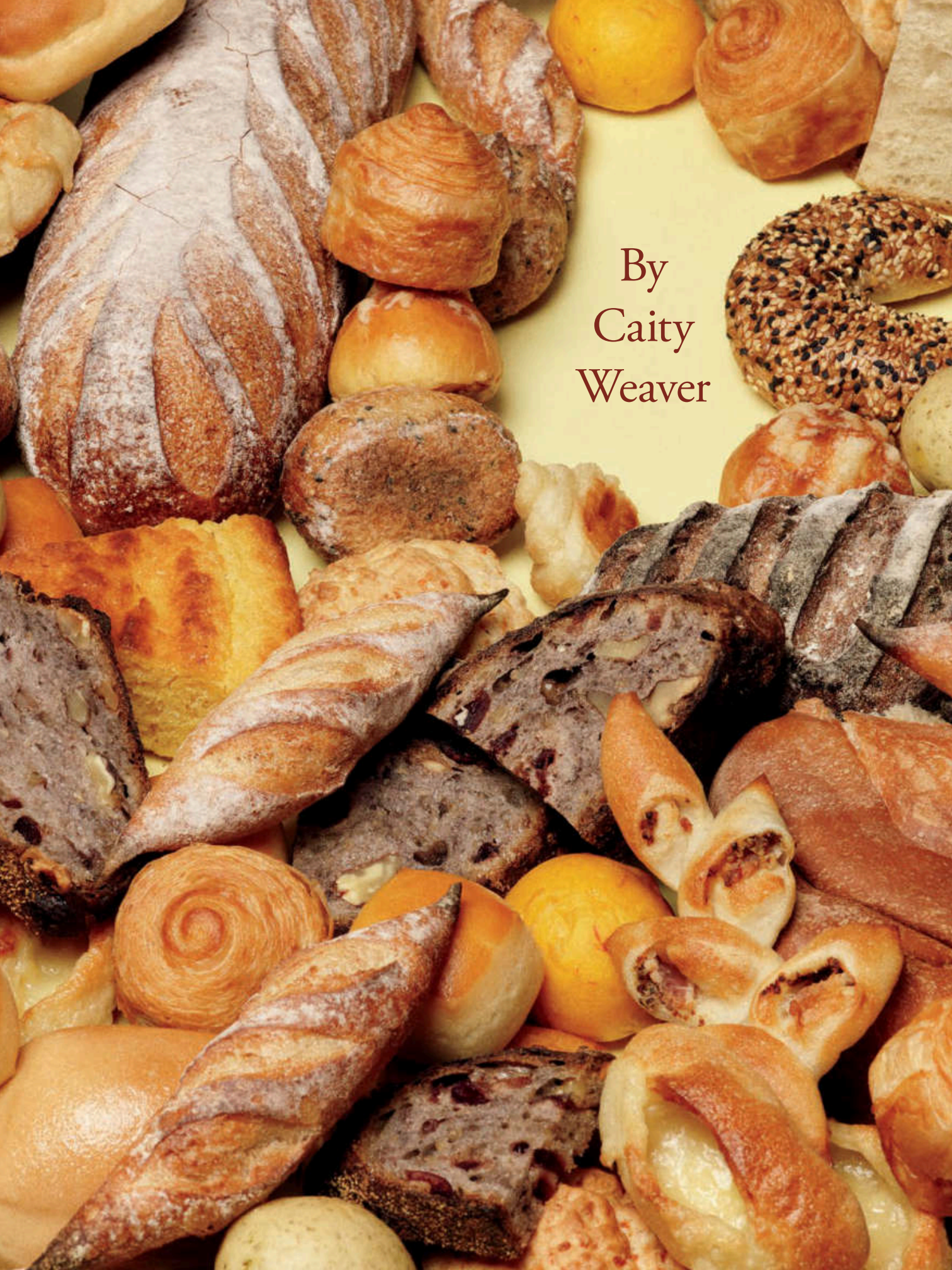
By 2007, Rauschenberg and Cunningham were 81 and 87, respectively. They still had a penchant for invention and spectacle—and play. At Rauschenberg’s home and studio on Captiva Island, in Florida, after Rauschenberg challenged Cunningham to a wheelchair race, they posed in front of *The Ancient Incident*, adding another layer of chairs, as well as their own bodies, to the 26-year-old sculpture. As Rauschenberg’s wry grin makes clear, the old friends thoroughly enjoyed their fresh act of mutual creation. —Amy Weiss-Meyer

Robert Rauschenberg and Merce Cunningham with Rauschenberg’s 1981 sculpture The Ancient Incident (Kabal American Zephyr) at his Captiva Island studio in Florida, 2007

I Found It: The Best Free Restaurant Bread in America

Thirteen thousand miles. Infinite contenders. One beautiful loaf.

Photographs by Hugo Yu

A dense, close-up collage of various breads and pastries. The assortment includes long, crusty loaves with flour-dusted tops, round rolls, some with a golden-brown sheen, and others with a more rustic, cracked texture. There are also spiral-shaped pastries, a bagel topped with black and white sesame seeds, and several slices of dark, dense bread, possibly rye or pumpernickel, showing a moist interior. The breads are piled together, creating a rich, textured composition with warm, golden-brown and brown tones.

By
Caity
Weaver

Here is the promise you and I must cling to across the thousands of words that follow:

At some point within this text, I will reveal to you what—after 555 responses, 13,000 miles of travel, and months of monomaniacal research—I have determined to be the best free restaurant bread in America. I will not attempt to slither to the moral high ground, arguing that *best* is a meaningless measure, or insisting that all bread is dear in its own way. Even if you attempt to betray me—for instance, by merely scanning the text that follows for the phrase *Here it is: the best free restaurant bread in America*—I will uphold my end of the bargain.

I encounter on this quest three types of Americans, because only three types exist. The type that you are—or the type that you are dealing with—is revealed in response to the question “What is the best free restaurant bread in America?”

The American people, alas, have grown skittish about answering plain questions. An unconscionable number ask what I mean by this, as if the words might have an obscure double meaning. To be clear: Any bread from any restaurant in America is eligible, so long as it is free to all customers. The contents of the basket set on the table before the meal arrives, the cost of which is invisibly diffused throughout other menu items. Rolls that arrive unbidden. Popovers, if everyone gets a popover no matter what. You know what I’m talking about. Free restaurant bread.

The first type of American: people who joyride the day’s updrafts like marvelous, glossy crows. They easily recall the locations of treats encountered over their lifetime. They answer this question Glock-shot fast, as if they have been waiting to be asked it. They are happy.

The second type: fairly certain that they have consumed bread at some point;

allows that a portion of that consumption could have occurred within the confines of a restaurant, or a restaurant-like environment; will grant that some pieces of said bread were perhaps free and/or enjoyable to ingest. But they profess to have retained no specifics. Their personal histories are inscribed in chalk, regularly power-washed with jets of deterging Time. They resent the implication that they could ever derive meaning from the pale, abstract remnants of narrative that constitute their internal autobiographies, and, with a few kindhearted exceptions, will not attempt to. Many, in fact, will appear oddly furious to have been asked this question, and will invent wafer-thin excuses as to why they are unable to spend two seconds considering it.

The third type: a tragic, paranoid (though occasionally brilliant) figure. Ask this person, “What is the best free restaurant bread in America?” and their eyes shimmer with panic. These individuals live with the terrific knowledge that there is a best free restaurant bread in America, and the awful conviction that they are incapable of identifying it. It is not a lack of contenders that prevents them from volunteering an answer—the prison of their mind teems with memories of free restaurant breads—rather, they are silenced by a hallucinatory fear of nebulous consequences that could befall them should they personally misidentify the best free restaurant bread in America, even in private conversation. Asked this question, such people refuse to answer. “It’s too much pressure!” they insist. Whence this pressure, of what force, applied to what possible end, is never explained. Men and women with advanced degrees are over-represented in this type.

HUGO YU FOR THE ATLANTIC





A selection of the 16 varieties of bread presented to the writer on a three-tiered rolling cart at Joël Robuchon in Las Vegas

Though it strikes the ear as an insoluble query, there is a correct answer—right now, known only to God (and to me, an agent of his will), but erelong to the steadfast reader.

Here is where the notion for the undertaking came from: Tucked within the viscera of the continental United States is a restaurant that gives away superb free bread. Every time I have eaten it (before this past year, three times total), I have said aloud (to my husband, who did not care), “This is the best free restaurant bread in America.” The thought made me feel the way you do when you realize you were just a half a moment away from being plowed by a car, and were spared only by a chance nanosecond of dawdling before stepping into the street: giddy and flabbergasted and grateful to be alive. It seemed incredible, but also possible, that this really could be the best free restaurant bread in America. What if it was? Even more dizzyingly, what if it wasn’t? What if—unfathomable—someone else was giving away an even better bread for free? The thought drove me crazy. I begged for the opportunity to investigate.

Naturally, I told my superiors, this investigation would bring me into contact with the entire arc of human history. People have been eating bread—in many places, eating mostly bread—for millennia. We can’t say for certain that the individuals who fled their burning homes on the shore of the Sea of Galilee 23,000 years ago (leaving behind baskets they’d woven, tools they’d carved from bones, and sleeping areas they’d turned snug and cozy) ate bread, but we know from microscopic barley and oat remnants embedded in a grindstone abandoned to the flames that they were, at least, processing flour. (To situate these folks in time: Cats would not be domesticated for another 14,000 years or so.)

Once people began munching bread, they never stopped. (Or, at least, they never stopped until very recently.) The word *bread* can also refer more generally to food, sustenance, or livelihood—not just in

English, but in languages from Russian to Hindi. Breadcrumbs are scattered throughout our language. The word *lord* is derived from a compound word in Old English—*hlāfweard*—translating, roughly, to “loaf guard” or “loaf keeper” (*breadwinner* could be seen as a modern fraternal twin); *lady* comes from *hlæfdige*: “loaf kneader.” The arm bones of Neolithic women, researchers have found, were 11 to 16 percent stronger than those of the women’s rowing team at the University of Cambridge, likely from grinding grain for hours every day.

(Of course, eventually, my investigation would lead me back to the site of the bread that inspired it, thereby accomplishing my secret personal mission: procuring a fourth basket of free bread from that restaurant. Unfortunately, what happened to me on my return visit was so shocking and abominable, I was tempted to re-pitch this article as “What Is the Restaurant in America That I Hate, That I Will Never Go Back to, That Has Made of Me an Enemy for Life Due to Its Psychotic Soda Policy”—on which, more upsetting details to follow.)

How would I determine the best free restaurant bread in America? Simple: I would ask every single person I encountered, “What is the best free restaurant bread in America?”; travel to the most likely candidates; and try the bread myself.

The \$725.32 Free Bread

Sixteen splendid bread varieties are yours for claiming off the three-tiered lacquered rolling cart at Joël Robuchon in Las Vegas. You can have as many as you want, all for free, with your meal. My meal was the Degustation Menu, which costs \$525 per guest. The breads range from the fanciful (surprisingly pointy bacon-and-mustard pods, heart-stoppingly yellow saffron focaccia) to the nearly indistinguishable (classic baguettes, traditional baguettes). There are flaky spirals and poofy cubes and bread with the gently rounded profile of a tasteful breast implant. There is olive bread; rosemary brioche; basil focaccia; walnut raisin; one miniature croissant; two cheese breads; a

third kind of baguette that is exactly the same as one of the other baguettes, only smaller. There is country loaf. Sixteen.

The three-Michelin-star Joël Robuchon is located within the abyss of the MGM Grand Las Vegas, directly adjacent to a Cirque du Soleil-themed gift shop, though it seems determined to ignore this fact. The MGM’s more than 5,000 rooms colluded to make it the Earth’s largest hotel when it opened in 1993; it has since lost that ominous distinction without shrinking in square footage. Roaming its purgatorial interior, you could be wandering a mega-cruise ship beached in the desert, or vacationing amid the elevator banks of a parking garage containing every car in the world. It is as all-encompassing as the world of a nightmare. In addition to Joël Robuchon, at the time of my visit, the MGM’s droves of restaurants included a Netflix-themed chow palace, Netflix Bites—where screens over the bar silently flashed random trailers for Netflix original programming, interspersed with *Stranger Things* and *Bridgerton* screen savers (Netflix Bites has since closed)—and a

person’s living room, down to the smattering of black-and-white framed snapshots of Nicolas Cage and Celine Dion. I am seated on a velvet couch of Tyrian purple, opposite a tabletop trio of pink roses and in front of a Nic Cage photo. My black napkin is of a material lovelier than my dress; to sleep beneath sheets stitched from such napkins would be the apex of indulgence.

The concept of an elegant chuck wagon buckling beneath the weight of its cargo of bread is not unique in Las Vegas to Joël Robuchon, but the Robuchon grain trolley is esteemed as one of the finest. To ensure that I will be hungry enough to sample the totality of its breads at my 9:15 p.m. reservation, I consume nothing after a modest breakfast. This will prove to be a mistake. By afternoon, counting down the hours in my MGM hotel room (\$39.20 a night before fees, a little more than 5 percent of my dinner bill), I pay more serious consideration to a can of Sour Cream & Onion Pringles—which I do not even like—than I did to the paperwork when I bought my car. I gaze, too,

“Fun article
for people
to read.”

restaurant inspired by the Jonas Brothers’ great-grandmother, Nellie’s Southern Kitchen: A Jonas Family Restaurant.

Unlike at Netflix Bites, there are no hot-pink signs reading I’D BON APPETIT HIM inside Joël Robuchon; it is a refined place, its cream facade evoking the stately grandeur of Haussmann’s Paris. Chandeliers, plural, are visible through the glass doors. The Robuchon dining room is peculiar within the MGM in that it was built to human scale; it feels like a rich

upon a lavender can next to the potato chips, envisioning the sugarplum delights it might enclose. Upon closer inspection, it turns out to contain a vibrator, two condoms, and personal lubricant (could this be edible as a kind of syrup?). By the time I am shown to my purple couch, I am hungry enough to eat the tablecloth.

The army of waitstaff who attend to each patron at Joël Robuchon is classy. When I confess to my headwaiter that I would, if possible, prefer not to have lamb

for one course, he thanks me as if I have paid him a compliment. These professionals, many of whom have worked here for decades, would never make a woman eating a \$525 meal alone at 9:15 on a Monday night feel bad for any request. But still. It is impossible to lock eyes with a Frenchman, after he has just spent minutes delicately extolling the virtues of 16 different breads, and ask, “Could I do one of each?” without feeling ridiculous, no matter how evenly he responds, “Absolutely!”

Unaware that every passing second escalates the odds that they will lose a silver button, a finger, or even a limb to my ravenous maw, the waiters continue the pageantry of the bread service. “Butter from France!” one trumpets as he wheels over a second cart, this bearing a hoodoo of butter beneath a spotless glass cloche large enough to contain a human head. A spoon in each hand, he shaves off a translucent spiral, which he confetties with salt. I am so dangerously close to eating the butter plain, like a scoop of ice cream, that I hear him announce, “Olive oil from Alicante!” only faintly, as a cry from a distant ship.

At last, 20 impeccably choreographed minutes after my arrival, my first round of breads is placed before me: 12 oven-warmed rolls crammed into a silver bowl. For one light-flooded second, I am a doe in high beams, paralyzed by everything that could happen next. Then I grab the bacon-and-mustard roll and throw it into my mouth so fast that I forget to taste it. I am about to snatch a second roll, any roll, when a waiter materializes at my elbow to tell me a story.

It is the history of what he calls “a beautiful dish”—a beautiful dish he has recklessly placed between myself and my breads. It is a shallow bowl of mesmerically arranged dots: three concentric rings of molar-size white dots, each topped with a little green dot, converging, as if in worship, upon a perfect circle that is itself an agglomeration of still smaller black dots—all suspended in straw-colored jelly. It looks like something from the biology lab at Liberace University. These, I am informed, are chlorophyll-kissed cauliflower pearls surrounding a caviar disc. The caviar is flecked with 24-karat gold leaf. I scarf it

down like my dog inhales breakfast, in order to get back to the bread.

The saffron roll tastes of nothing. The pale-green basil focaccia looks like bread from the morgue. Some of the pickings are quite tasty, but the sheer number of rolls dilutes the impact of each. When the headwaiter asks if I have a favorite “so far,” I humiliate myself by describing a square bread covered in cheese that does not exist. He instantly identifies the two rolls I have conflated—an ethereal marshmallow-size cube made with milk instead of water, and a sphere crowned with crunchy, oven-toasted Gruyère that tastes like cheese-flavored air—and brings out more of these for me to confirm. I accept; I could eat 60 to 600 more!

Another mistake. I had meant to merely sample the breads; instead I am consuming each in toto. The remaining 13 courses are whisked out to me at a relentless pace. There are triangles of many colors; foam; a leaf that is a cake; a ladybug that is candy; gold foil distributed with such apparent abandon—festooning a truffle; smeared on the rim of a glass—that it may simply be drifting through the kitchen’s HVAC system like ash from a phoenix’s nest. “I’m eating so much gold,” read my notes.

As I challenge the elastic limits of my gastric wall, distending it with hundreds of dollars’ worth of fabulous things in rare shapes, and also rolls, I rely more and more on the chemical burn of Diet Coke to excoriate my palate between bites. Joël Robuchon’s Diet Coke is crisp and cold, and swims right up to the brim of the voluptuously curved glasses they serve it in; it devours my tongue like a cleansing fire. Feeling sheepish, and also sluggish, and also like I will never be hungry again, I ask the maestro of the bread cart if I might have my second round. It is time for the loaves.

At 10:46 p.m.—90 minutes after my arrival; I’m exhausted, unable to eat another bite of anything—I calculate how many courses I have left. *Five?* I am given a plate of Ibérico ham. It tastes exquisite: nutty, salty, rich. I force it down like I am eating packing peanuts. I notice that I have begun shivering slightly, probably because of the frosty Diet Cokes. “I love Diet Coke!” I write in my notes. Tendrils

of conversation from other diners drift to my table. “This was such a good dinner!” one woman declares—a demented way to describe what has happened here tonight; this is dinner in the same way that Australia is an isle. I impel myself to eat all of the foie gras I am served, because I know it is made inhumanely. It is 20 minutes to midnight by the time my posh experience draws to a close. I prefer the traditional baguette to the classic baguette.

What’s the Point of the Article?

“What’s the *point* of the article?”

This is the question an exasperated William Rubel, the author of *Bread: A Global History*, demands of me. Rubel is an American who was made a Chevalier of the Ordre National du Mérite Agricole by France’s minister of agriculture for contributions to agricultural knowledge. He is a scholar affiliated with no university. His objective is the total comprehension of a small portion of culinary history—aptly, because, with his untamed thatch of shoulder-length white hair and woolly-caterpillar brows, he looks like someone who could have been alive at any point in the era of man. He also founded a children’s literary magazine.

“Fun article for people to read,” I tell him glumly.

Rubel’s knowledge of bread is so comprehensive—and mine so nonexistent—that he is quickly, if cantankerously, becoming my own *bläfsveard*: the curmudgeonly warden of all loaf understanding. I came to him originally with a question to which I could find no answer: Why did restaurants start giving away bread for free?

“It’s the opposite of what you asked,” Rubel says. “It’s not ‘When did they begin giving away bread for free?’ Because no one could have imagined sitting down at the meal and not eating bread. It was not possible.”

In the timeline of Western civilization, restaurants are a brand-new trend. The United States had batteries before it had a restaurant. Delmonico’s began operating in New York City in 1837 as a novel





kind of dining space: one where patrons could purchase individually priced items off a menu. Prior to the importation of this French-style concern, a person who wished to be served a meal away from home was pretty much restricted to an oyster saloon (where they could have oysters) or an inn or a tavern (where a flat fee purchased whatever meal everyone else was getting—not necessarily oysters). To say that a 19th-century American tavern meal included bread would be like remarking that a 21st-century restaurant meal includes cutlery. We know that America's first restaurants offered bread to patrons because it would have been unthinkable not to.

People have judged restaurants on the quality of their free bread from the institutions' earliest days. In what is possibly America's first restaurant review (a mad-cap meta-account published in *The New York Times* in 1859), the bread at New York's Astor House is deemed "the best bread in the universe." And although dozens of poll respondents insisted to me that complimentary bread, as a concept, has been lately abandoned in this country—that "every" restaurant charges for bread "now" (not true)—in fact, people have been complaining about vanishing complimentary rolls for at least a century. In 1912, the *Times* devoted days of coverage to outrage over a new 10-cent charge for bread and butter: "HOTEL DINER BRINGS IN HIS OWN BREAD," read the headline of an article that described one man's attempt to skirt the fee.

In the days of tavern dining, proprietors would have wanted customers to fill up on as much bread as possible, so that they would consume less of the more expensive ingredients to which they were entitled. À la carte restaurants perhaps felt themselves grandfathered into what had become a mark of hospitality. Chefs I consult attest to free bread's ability—a finite ability—to make kitchens run more smoothly (by slowing down orders). It also makes customers less whiny: Restaurants give you free bread "just so that you have something to do with your hands and your mouth," Richard Horner, a New Orleans chef and restaurateur, tells me.

Horner lays bare the strategic timing of this generosity. Ideally, free bread should not hit the table until after customers have ordered their meal, "because then they order from a position of maximum hungriness," he says. Plus, the delay builds anticipation: "*Will there be bread? I see other people with bread. We haven't got bread yet.*" And then, once the bread is bestowed: "*Oh! There is bread! What a fun surprise.*"

Horner's demonic calculation for how many slices or rolls each table's basket should contain is $[Number\ of\ diners] + 1$. Unevenly divisible bread creates "a tension that I really enjoy."

But Horner describes himself as "anti-free bread"—a common position among restaurant professionals. A premature breadbasket can gut the total bill. Also, the

by demanding bread that is free, deprive themselves of bread that is worth eating. "It's either good and you pay," Roman tells me, "or it's free and bad. Bread costs money to make. It takes skilled labor, and it shouldn't be free."

Horner echoes her point. When free bread is "an afterthought"—provided only because free bread is expected—"I would rather just not have it on the table," he says. If you're going to give customers bread, "it should be as good as the rest of your food. And if that's the case, you should charge for it."

(No one outside the food industry ever tells me they'd prefer paying for excellent bread to receiving mediocre bread for free. Most people just want to be given bread they have not paid for.)

Do you want to know how abjectly I debase myself, attempting to divine this forbidden knowledge?

bread intended to placate customers can just as often be something else for them to complain about. "They get really, really particular about this thing you're giving them for free," Horner says. "'This isn't hot' or 'Bring me more stuff'; 'I need more bread'; 'I need more oil and vinegar for some reason'; or 'This butter is wrong.'" He sees the decline of free bread as a consequence of restaurants being stretched so thin during the pandemic. They just got fed up: "*You know what? You don't get bread anymore!*"

Several chefs, including the author Alison Roman, make the case that customers,

That bread being good constitutes a rare and wonderful possibility—certainly not an expectation. Nothing tastes as good as free costs.)

My primary means of determining the best free restaurant bread in America is to demand answers from people—my father and friends, yes, but also anyone else I can think of. Strangers encountered on errands. Everyone who sends me an email during the month of October. "What is the best free restaurant bread in America?" I amass several hundred answers.

In harvesting this knowledge, I am exposed to countless novel methods

through which humans might delight, disappoint, irritate, and surprise one another. Some people invent their own question on the spot and answer that instead: Asked to identify the best free restaurant bread in America, they tell of a great bakery where bread can be purchased for money, or the worst free restaurant bread in America. Others imagine that the question contains some hidden constraint, which they undertake to expose—"It can't be a chain restaurant," they declare, or "It has to be a chain restaurant." The fixins'-dazzled deliver monologues about butter and olive oil, forgetting that bread exists. One smug stranger in a hot tub tells me that she cannot answer, because she makes her own bread. (Does she bring it to restaurants?) A number decline to consider the question, because they no longer eat gluten. (I don't require anyone to eat the bread they mention.) (Unrelated warning—not a threat: Gluten-free bread is unable to transubstantiate into the body of Christ, according to Catholic law.) Some folks itch to argue with me about what I mean by *bread*, daring me to reject their votes for pitas, sopaipillas, corn tortilla chips, or hush puppies. They are disgruntled to learn that I let each person define *bread* as he or she wishes, desiring only that it incorporate a non-raw staple starch.

I am astonished that only a minority of people can summon an answer quickly. My mental filing cabinet devoted to cataloging free restaurant breads is one of the largest and most scrupulously maintained in my neocortex; I've discarded the contents of other filing cabinets ("Visuospatial Reasoning," "First Aid") to make room for it. What occupies the free-bread space in others' minds? Americans of the second type—those who don't have an immediate answer to the best-free-bread question—are certainly not charmed by being asked. They seem to resent being pulled out of the swift current of their life and forced to ponder restaurant bread for a few seconds. But aggression is not limited to such people. A man from Boston overhears me asking another stranger the question in an elevator, and cuts in: "Any restaurant you walk in, in the North End, is the best bread." I ask him to name one. "Any of

them," he says. "Pick one," I encourage. The man grows furious: "Any of them!"

My father's answer surprises me. When I was growing up, he, my mother, and I were all serious eaters (not in the sense of being discerning, but of deriving satisfaction from doggedly plowing through any volume of food) with a special penchant for free items. At 81, he tells me, he possesses a single vivid memory of free restaurant bread: He ate it on one of the handful of days in his life that he saw his father. "He would show up occasionally and try to act like the big dad," my father recalls, bringing Christmas presents to his wife and sons in South Philly. Once, in 1962, my grandfather bought his sons—one in the Air Force, the other (my father) a teenage gang member—lunch at the Four Seasons in Manhattan.

I am stunned to learn that my father—an indefatigable storyteller who I thought had long since frog-marched me through everything that had ever happened to him—once went to a restaurant as nice as the Four Seasons. I'd thought he might say the biscuits at Red Lobster, a restaurant that was the setting for so many jubilant meals with my parents, grandparents, and cousins that I struggle to recall a distinct memory from it; every meal blurs together in a montage of steaming biscuits and laughing faces, not unlike a commercial for Red Lobster. I ask my dad if he has any happy memories of his father. "None that I can think of," he says. But he remembers that the bread was warm.

What Celebrities Don't Want You to Know

Hear me when I say this: Irrespective of the vibrant plausibility of your parasocial fantasies, America's celebrities are not your friends. There is only one good celebrity in this world: the author Stephen King. According to Mr. King, the best free bread in America is "crusty and warm" and served at Hyde Park Prime Steakhouse in Sarasota, Florida. Given the fact that no other star, out of the scores I contact via their representatives, successfully manages to answer this question, I can conclude

only that America's celebrities consider it their unholy mission to ensure that her masses—their fans—die ignorant of the identity of her best free restaurant bread.

Publicists demand to know which other celebrities are telling me their favorite free restaurant bread before they will even consider passing along this question. LeBron James cannot devote one minute to contemplating the best free restaurant bread in America, a representative confides in October, because the totality of his "focus" is "on preparing for the upcoming season"—a frightening and lonely thought. (A few weeks later, James will shatter the tempered-glass backboard of his concentration at 6:32 a.m. Los Angeles time, confessing on social media: "I love watching YouTube golf 🏌️🇺🇸 videos!! Random I know. lol. SO COOL!" I email his rep a plea to slip the question to James while a YouTube golf video is loading. Do not hear back.) Ben Affleck cannot answer due to being "in the midst of a project"—aren't we all? Jennifer Lopez is likewise "filming a movie right now" and therefore totally unreachable by terrestrial communication.

Do you want to know how abjectly I debase myself, attempting to divine this forbidden knowledge from the impenetrable minds of celebrities? I contact Chris Pratt's publicist to seek Pratt's answer, even though—since we're all being so honest—I don't especially care to know it. (I am merely asking to be polite.) "We need to politely hold off as there isn't interest," comes the reply. Excuse me! That is actually not polite! I don't need to know that Chris Pratt isn't interested; and also, how can he not be interested in such an interesting topic? And also, I am the one who is not interested! But this is not even my lowest moment. That nadir is struck when I am forced to reach out to my nemesis: a celebrity publicist I have previously sworn never to speak to again, because several years ago she lied to me—did not refuse to comment; flat-out lied—when I asked her a direct question. Typing my query about the best free restaurant bread in America to this individual feels like dragging my raw, bleeding fingertips across a gravestone that has been scorched by lightning. And would you believe that not only does this publicist fail to provide an answer



*Red Lobster's
butter-radiant
Cheddar Bay Biscuit.
(The culinary historian
William Rubel
denies the possibil-
ity that any chain
restaurant might have
the "best" bread.)*

to my fun and fascinating question; she does not even acknowledge receipt of my email *or my follow-up email*? And so now I am forced to put into writing my new vow, a vow I will keep, even if it one day destroys my life, even if it kills me: Ashley, the next time you and I cross paths, it will be in hell.

("What a nice article this will be to read," Oprah Winfrey's ultra-classy publicist writes, while unequivocally declining her client's participation.)

On a handful of occasions, my interactions with public-relations professionals are at least moderately helpful. When pressed, Buzz Aldrin's and Tyler Perry's publicists reveal what they (these men's publicists) consider to be the best free

restaurant bread in America, though they will not ask their principals; I duly log their data.

More often, the exchanges are vexing. The senior director of media relations for the country's largest food-service lobbying group, the National Restaurant Association—the other NRA—tells me that no one from the group will be able to speak with me about free restaurant bread in any capacity, because it "isn't a trend that we track." I ask if someone might be able to chat with me about free restaurant bread anecdotally. "It's not even something we could talk about anecdotally," she responds. I ask if she will tell me what, in her personal opinion, is the best free restaurant bread in America. She

"Americans have got a lot of things right regarding the texture of foodstuffs."

never replies to me again. (Neither here nor there, but in 2023, an investigation by *The New York Times* revealed that this NRA used the \$15 fee that restaurant workers pay to attend its mandatory food-safety course to fund a nationwide lobbying campaign against minimum-wage increases.)

Almost but Not Actually the Best Free Restaurant Bread in America

Here it is: the best free restaurant bread in America are words that, in deference to the integrity of this investigation, I am unable to print immediately followed by the cymbal-washed, experimental-jazz phrase *Red Lobster Cheddar Bay Biscuits*. But such an announcement would be very nearly true. Raw poll numbers situate Red Lobster's signature bread offering—knobbly, crimped clods, butter-radiant and freckled with parsley—comfortably in second place. I have personally enjoyed these rolls (introduced in 1992 under the straightforward name Hot Cheese Garlic Bread) so many times that I worry I will struggle to evaluate the biscuits impartially, the same way a friend's beauty seems to increase over time as your love for her deepens. And so I beg my friend Alice, an Englishwoman for whom Cheddar Bay is *mare incognitum*, to let me watch her sample her first at our local Red Lobster in Santa Fe.

Our Ultimate Feast is not without some painful moments, such as when, one second before tasting the milky-slurry piña-colada dipping sauce for our Parrot Isle Coconut Shrimp, Alice asks, "What is this?" and then, at the exact same moment I gaily sing, "You're gonna like it!," gasps, "Oh my God—that is disgusting." But her verdict on the Cheddar Bay Biscuits is effusive: "Americans have got a lot of things right regarding the texture of food-stuffs," she says. "Outstanding."

The problem is that I want to examine the nubiform texture of these foodstuffs at Red Lobster's culinary-development center, in Orlando.

My email inquiry is answered by a representative from the PR firm that fields

press requests for Red Lobster. I express my desire to visit the offices of the company that purchases a quarter of the lobster and crab caught on boats in North America; she tells me she will "check in with the brand to see what is possible." What is not possible, I am informed a few days later, is setting foot anywhere inside the corporate lobster den, let alone its gleaming test kitchen. I can enjoy no audience with Damola Adamolekun—who at 35 became the youngest Red Lobster CEO in company history and has spent recent months in a media blitz, promoting the brand's determination to claw its way back into the hearts of young Black Americans as part of a post-bankruptcy revitalization strategy. Instead, I am invited to submit some questions via email or Zoom to ancillary executives.

By coincidence, in the midst of these faltering negotiations, I meet someone who previously worked with Adamolekun. She says he's "really cool," "actually quite lovely"; I should just email him directly, rather than becoming ensnared in PR red tape, like the hundreds of thousands of dolphins, whales, seals, etc. that perish in the Earth's oceans each year, tangled in trash and fishing gear; here is his email address. I send Adamolekun a short email, in which I attempt to make it clear that I am likewise really cool and actually quite lovely. "I'd like to figure out a fun way to feature Red Lobster in the story," I say. "I have a couple ideas that would involve you directly." (Ideas like: eat the biscuits with him, and many other ideas that will hopefully occur to me if he writes back.)

And that is how I learn that Damola Adamolekun is a snitch.

The next day, I receive an email from the same PR rep. "The brand and I connected following your email to Damola," she writes. "To keep things streamlined and to spare Damola's inbox, feel free to continue corresponding through me. 😊"

This PR representative is made of steel. Googling her name unearths a YouTube assignment recorded for a college public-relations class a few years ago. In it she coolly addresses the camera while expressing regret for a factory collapse in which, "so far, 1,100 people have lost their lives." (The crisis-video exercise was apparently

inspired by the 2013 Rana Plaza disaster in Bangladesh, in which 1,134 people were killed while working in a building where clothing was manufactured for retailers including the Children's Place and Benetton. "I cannot express how sorry I am that this had to happen," she tells the camera calmly.) I give up trying to penetrate the Red Lobster carapace.

What Is the "Best"?

Let us acknowledge that the "best" bread is influenced by current fashions. Soft white bread was, for much of human history, a yearned-for extravagance. Today, Americans generally regard it as the nastiest, lowest form of bread and stock it in their cheapest grocery stores. Tastes change.

The late 19th century in New York City—soot-blackened, ammoniac with horse urine—spawned a frenzy for breads baked in sanitary conditions. Under the headline "Bread and Filth Cooked Together," an 1894 exposé by *The New York Press* devoted several lurid paragraphs to the cockroach kingdoms of cellar kitchens, where, according to state inspectors, vermin "abounded, and as chance willed became part of the salable products." One baker recounted how an employer had forced him to mix worm-infested, "green and rotten" old pumpernickel into new dough to add volume. The English language "is not sturdy enough," the article insisted, to convey "the animate and inanimate horrors" that its reporters had uncovered. ("Unclean Men Mix the Dough and Sleep in the Same Rooms"!)

Within eight months, public outcry fast-tracked a law implementing minimum hygiene standards, including housing toilets in rooms separate from the ones where dough was kneaded.

By the early 1900s, basement bakeries were being replaced by aboveground factories. The new operations began packaging bread in waxed paper as a visual marker of sanitation. The paraffin-coated paper, moreover, helped bread go stale more slowly by delaying moisture evaporation; new additives incorporated directly into the dough delayed staleness



*Soft white rolls
from Texas
Roadhouse, served
with the restaurant's
honey-cinnamon
butter*

further. Soft white bread that stayed fresh for days, once a product of wild fantasy, became commonplace.

The rolls served at Texas Roadhouse (third place in the best-free-restaurant-bread contest by raw votes) are indisputably soft and white, roundly square, and immaculate enough to have possibly made themselves with no outside aid. Seven hundred years ago, a king might have eaten such satin-smooth bread on Easter; the Roadhouse gives it out for free, in portions that are infinite. (The first basket accompanies you to your table, like a fellow guest.) The menu items my husband and I order during our visit are remarkable in their own way—no rabbits stealing the last of the November lettuces

by moonlight ever chewed a colder salad than our Caesar—but without question, the free rolls, accompanied by honey-cinnamon butter, are the only items really worth paying for (besides the lovely, big Diet Cokes).

If the paschal king were served the bread now in vogue in the United States, he would be apoplectic. People might die. Our most au courant breads would be, to him, peasant fodder—dun-colored, chewy, whole-grain bricks or, even more inexcusable, loaves rendered intentionally sour.

That the “best” bread is prescribed by trend is demonstrated by no bread better than sourdough. Before the 20th century, William Rubel points out, it was considered unwise to eat bread that tasted acidic, biting, or in some way off: “Eating sour foods was credited with the reason that your family had diarrhea.” But, he says, in the 21st century, “the high-end culinary elite in this country is very aggressively against any bread that’s not sourdough.”

After an explosion of interest in the United States during the first spring of COVID, the obsession has continued to flourish, borne, Rubel says, on a memory mirage. In contrast with, say, grits (a dish that has, more or less, been eaten continuously in North America for more than a thousand years), there is, he insists, “no sourdough tradition in the United States.”

In this country, *sourdough* gained widespread usage in the days of the Gold Rush—as a term to refer not to bread but to people. According to legend, fortune hunters in the western hinterlands, far from a steady supply of baker’s yeast, kept their starters (a bit of fermented dough that could be added to the next day’s mix) warm by sleeping with them, which caused the miners to reek of sour dough.

As a term referring to a type of bread, rather than a type of person, *sourdough* did not take off before the 1960s, when it was presented as a kitschy, tough-to-chew wilderness food. Alice Waters—the farm-to-table divinity whose altar is every traffic-thronged urban farmers’ market—brought a craving for French-style sourdough back to California after she had it in Paris, where *levain* has a much longer history. Americans have now “fetishized the sourdough,” Rubel says, so much so that, in their pursuit

of tradition, they have bolted out beyond it, into an ahistoric gastronomic delusion: American sourdough, Rubel says, is uniquely astringent. “In France, they don’t want it to taste sour.”

Rubel also tells me that the whole premise of my article is flawed. “I think you need to think about *favorite* versus *best*,” he says. He objects to the fact that I am using the terms, essentially, interchangeably: “Obviously, those can be really different.”

Rubel’s pronouncement severs the tether that has been weakly holding me to reality as I attempt to determine the best free restaurant bread in America. I spend an afternoon losing and evading my own mind across a kaleidoscopic astral plane of axiological and epistemological contemplation. What if the true criteria for what makes one bread the best are unknown, not just to me, but to everyone on Earth? What are the chances that my 555 poll takers represent, exclusively, morons and deviants, whose tastes in no way reflect those of normal people? Wouldn’t many people citing the same thing as their favorite necessarily make it, at least in some way, the best?

The Bread That Flies Through the Air

While I attempt to ask as many different sorts of people “What is the best free restaurant bread in America?” as possible, my sample—though it encompasses respondents of diverse ages, races, incomes, political persuasions, formal-education levels, points of geographic origin, etc.—is inevitably limited.

Lambert’s Cafe is a remarkable contender for several reasons. Although it has only three locations, in Missouri and Alabama, its bread is among the 10 most-named by respondents: four strangers from the internet, two members of my husband’s family, a museum curator my friend knows, and the chef of another restaurant I visited on my quest. But the most noteworthy thing about Lambert’s Cafe is that it distributes its free bread to diners by lobbing it at them from across the room, forcing them to catch it in their bare hands. It is, as its shockingly robust gift

shop makes clear 20 million times over, the “Home of Thrown Rolls.”

I make my pilgrimage to Lambert’s a few days after last Christmas; in Foley, Alabama, families are milling around outside at night in T-shirts and shorts. The restaurant sprawls like a commercial ag shed. Its furnishings are psychotropic, but devoid of the gentle embrace of tranquilizers. Above my booth hang several wooden birdhouses and one birdcage (all vacant), an Alabama license plate, a lithograph of a magician, signs advertising gasoline and Coca-Cola, an illustration of mules in a river, a T-shirt for a wheelchair basketball team framed behind cracked glass, and a metal pictogram that appears to warn of ducks.

Not since stoop-shouldered Irish monks illuminated miracles on vellum in aureate arsenic have more densely inscribed materials than the Lambert’s Cafe menu been produced in the Western Hemisphere. Each page bears more rules and explanations than I have ever seen on a menu or legal document—all the more impressive because each page also contains more pictures. There are portraits of Lambert forebears; cartoons of farm animals making dry allusion to the fact that they are subject to slaughter for their protein; a Zodiac Killer cipher key, elucidating the 12 abbreviations for common allergens that speckle the menu; edicts governing plate sharing and doggie bags; an exhortation to visit the gift shop; a list of salads, all of which contain meat; the yowl “SLICE O’HOG From the left side and cut fresh every day!”; and many other elements, besides.

The one that soothes me so totally that it sends all the adrenaline molecules in my body drifting away on a blood lazy river is a red-text promise: “ALL YOU CAN DRINK” soft drinks. My Diet Coke is served in the restaurant’s signature mug, which, I learn later, while typing these very words, holds 64 ounces of liquid, and which, I also learn—upon Googling *64 oz x 2 to gallons*—means I drank an entire gallon of Diet Coke in one sitting? No???

Lambert’s Cafe ovens turn out an average of 520 dozen rolls a day, for a total of more than 2 million five-inch rolls a year. On the night of my visit, the roll warden—the *hlāfweard*—is a young man

in heatproof gloves with the salient biceps and keen sight of a baseball player. Patrons signal that they would like a roll to be hurled at them by raising a hand in the air. The accuracy of the bread thrower’s aim is spectacular, especially considering that his mental calculations must incorporate a flash assessment of each customer’s degree of hand-eye coordination. In the nearly two hours I spend in the restaurant, I see only one roll miss its mark, obviously due to catcher error.

These rolls are, I discover when one collides with my chest cavity, as hot as meteorites slamming into the Earth. They are, by far, the hottest part of my meal, which includes numerous cooked items. The rolls—big and bulbous, with a dense and super-soft interior; faintly sweet and just east of gummy; the tranquil hue of hot-dog buns—are fine but not great. I would absolutely go back. Terrific big sodas!

The Bread of the Appalachian Dancing Bear

Do you know what I love most about my spreadsheet containing 555 replies to the question “What is the best free restaurant bread in America?” (Apart from the fact that it has revealed to me, and soon to you, the hitherto hidden knowledge of what is quite possibly—and in fact I really do believe—the best free restaurant bread in America.)

I love seeing what 555 people said. I love the American optimism, which even more American confidence transforms into certainty, that every respondent is, or at least could be, possessed of the knowledge of the best free restaurant bread in America. I love the fact that no matter where you travel within the 50 states and Washington, D.C., you are never far from what at least one person considers the best free restaurant bread in America.

I love the town names—Big Indian, New York (named for a Munsee Lenape man, allegedly more than 7 feet tall, who lived there); Bee Cave, Texas (named for the honeybees—Mexican honeybees, allegedly—who lived there). I love the chance that the best free restaurant bread

in America is to be found on an island off the coast of South Carolina with a population of 130. I love contemplating the food court inside the Pentagon—site of a Lebanese Taverna, whose warm pita is nominated as the best free restaurant bread in America by a man eating at Netflix Bites, and by the chef José Andrés. I love the outrageous-but-not-impossible prospect that the best free restaurant bread in America might be handed out by an oyster bar in Omaha, which is almost as far from an oyster bed as it is physically possible to be in America.

Cafe Capriccio. Sanitary Fish Market and Restaurant. Silver Saddle. Spindle-shanks. Because I lack the budget and employer patience to journey to each of the 226 restaurants that received only a single vote, I determine, instead, to visit just one. This will serve as a spot check, to assess the quality of random strangers' nominations. Having no better means of selecting the spot, I pick the one that has the most charming name. This is how I end up driving into the woods—fully into the woods—of Townsend, Tennessee, to dine at Dancing Bear Appalachian Bistro.

Dancing Bear's entrance is an illusion of carved pine and glass. On approach,

its doors appear to depict the arches and stained-glass windows of a Gothic cathedral; close up, the woodwork resolves into the sloping tree branches of a humble forest scene. The dining room, on a cold winter night, is a cozy hall abundant with wood, lit and warmed by an immense stacked-stone fireplace.

The free bread arrives on a slate slab: two wedges of corn bread drizzled with sorghum syrup, next to a ruffled dollop of whisper-light butter. The bad news: Corn bread is just not my favorite. Therefore, I do not believe Dancing Bear's corn bread is the best free restaurant bread in America. The good news: If you love corn bread, this might well be the best free restaurant bread in America, to your misguided taste. It is fathoms above other corn breads. It does not crumble into infinite particles when I bite it. The wedges leave wet sorghum smacks on the slate. In fact, I am dribbling sorghum all over the table. What decadent madness, to entrust every diner with such a sticky substance. I request more bread and, using my trowel-shaped knife, coat it in butter as thickly as a mason mortaring a chimney. I eat a knife-ful of the salty butter alone because I am a wild animal. The bread is so good, it makes me giddy. *Is corn bread my favorite?*

(Eventually, I learn that I just happened to be there on a corn-bread evening. The restaurant also serves two varieties of focaccia.)

The rest of my meal—roasted-garlic-and-herb-crusted beef-tenderloin tips with local mushrooms, apple-cider gelée, Granny Smith apples, and pickled cranberries; steamed Moosabec mussels—is so delicious as to border on the hallucinatory. The room thrums with conviviality, pierced, now and then, by shrieks of intoxicated laughter. I cannot shake the thought that, when people imagine a perfect little restaurant, this dining room is what they are searching for. When, as I mull dessert options, my waiter tells me that I may also just help myself to free s'mores outside, I wonder how this reasonably priced restaurant (my meal, with dessert—and free s'mores—comes to just over \$60 before tip) can possibly make money.

The corn bread from Dancing Bear Appalachian Bistro, in Townsend, Tennessee, might be the best free restaurant bread in America, but only if corn bread is your favorite.



Datassential, an analytics company that monitors the food-and-beverage industry, uses a representative sample of 4,800 establishments to keep tabs on restaurant-menu trends across the United States. In 2012, when the company began tracking the practice of charging for bread, 6 percent of restaurants did it. Last year, 36 percent of restaurant menus in the sample offered some form of bread as an appetizer, and 41 percent of menus listed it as a side. Seemingly every newspaper or magazine story about the increasing popularity of “bread courses” features at least one chef, owner, or manager explaining that a restaurant can no longer afford to give bread away. I want to know how Dancing Bear pulls it off.

The restaurant’s bread cost per table is “really not that much,” says Dancing Bear’s executive chef, Jeff Carter—about 40 cents, he estimates. The vice president of operations, Houston Oldham, tells me that has “very little effect on our bottom line.”

“If somebody’s telling you that they are scared of having bread on their menu because it costs too much,” Oldham says, “there is a cost of pain for your guests too: a cost of a bad experience when you don’t have a way to fill the gaps between courses.”

And, Carter says, the bread enhances the festive atmosphere. “We kind of consider this our gift to the guest.”

The other thing that Dancing Bear gets just right: nice big Diet Cokes in stout glass jars. And they keep them coming.

The Restaurant in America That I Hate, That I Will Never Go Back to, That Has Made of Me an Enemy for Life Due to Its Psychotic Soda Policy

A confession: Throughout this investigation, I nurture an unscientific—though, I am fairly certain, forgivable because ultimately correct—bias. Although it receives just one vote (mine), I remain confident that the bread that inspired this quest truly is the best free restaurant bread in America. A week after my trip to the earthly paradise known as Dancing Bear Appalachian Bistro, I fly to Atlanta—to the steak house Bones—in Atlanta—to eat it.



Here is what the restaurant does beautifully on my visit: the bread. It is a boule cut into four wedges. Every possible shade of golden retriever, from pale cream to the deepest cognac orange, is represented by some centimeter of this rotund loaf; its floured bottom is the dark brown of all of their paw pads. Its crust is a texture known to old-fashioned Yankees as cat ice—the brittle sheet, so thin that a cat’s paw could shatter it, of an iced-over puddle. On very close inspection, the irregular latticework of air pockets inside the chewy crumb resembles a network of semi-translucent cobwebs. It has no dominant taste other than the flavor of the verriest bread—simple, warm, perfect bread—which it possesses in extraordinary quantity.

Here is what the restaurant does poorly: serves Diet Cokes in glasses that

The boule from the steak house Bones, in Atlanta, is simple and perfect—unlike the restaurant’s contemptible Diet Coke—pricing strategy.

are, I'm going to say, no bigger than a thimble inside a sewing kit inside a dollhouse and, I am astounded and appalled to discover upon receiving my bill, charges you \$4 for each and every single one you drink. (Having previously dined here only as my husband's brilliant and visually stunning dream date, I had apparently never looked at a bill at this restaurant.) Over the course of one evening, I spend a total of \$16 on Diet Cokes. Worth every penny, of course—1,600 of them—but I'll never go back.

I award this restaurant negative 10 million stars.

The Chain-Restaurant Popularity Paradox

Can the best free restaurant bread in America come from a chain restaurant? According to raw poll votes, the answer is yes. Chain restaurants claim nearly every spot in the top 10 of my poll. On the one hand, this is to be expected; people are more likely to have been exposed to the bread at a restaurant with 940 locations than at a restaurant with just one. On the other hand, although chains are named most often in the responses, the number of a restaurant's locations do not predict its overall popularity; Olive Garden, with the most locations, receives the fifth-most votes.

I email Sir David Spiegelhalter, a professor emeritus of statistics at the University of Cambridge and a former president of the Royal Statistical Society, to see if he might suggest a math equation to derive meaning from my helter-skelter data. "If a restaurant had 10 customers, and 8 thought it had the best bread, this would seem more impressive than if another restaurant had 100 customers, and 10 thought it had the best bread," he writes back. I concur with my associate. The problem: To weigh the number of votes a restaurant received against the number of that restaurant's customers, I would need to find reliable estimates of each restaurant's customers per year. "But I don't know where you get the footfall data from!" replies Sir David, now as hopelessly lost as I.

I decide to calculate the rate of bestness by analyzing the two variables I know for certain: the number of each bread slinger's locations and the number of nominations it received.

Dividing votes (40) by location (215) gives the Cheesecake Factory—the restaurant that received the most total votes—a bestness rate of 0.19, or the equivalent of 19 votes per 100 restaurants. Lambert's Cafe earns a bestness rate of 2.66—the equivalent of 266 votes per 100 restaurants. While imperfect, this method at least does not penalize restaurants for failing to be national chains—though, for the purposes of the poll, I accept all nominations at face value. If a person tells me they believe the best free restaurant bread in America can be had at Olive Garden, I believe them. I am open to the possibility.

William Rubel is not open to the possibility. When I mention that table bread, these days, is most reliably found at restaurants like the Cheesecake Factory and Texas Roadhouse, he is staggered that I'm even considering them as possible purveyors of the best free restaurant bread in America. "It never occurred to me that that's what you'd be referring to," he says.

"There is no best bread, in an elite cultural sense, at these places you've mentioned—which are places that people like me have never been." He "cannot imagine why I would ever walk through the door" of such a place. He would "never go to" them "under any circumstances."

I imagine a circumstance: What if a Red Lobster is all that's around?

"I don't eat at chain restaurants," he says. "I eat at artisan restaurants."

What if he were driving, I insist, and there were no other options. Would he starve?

"That's why I don't travel the United States," he says.

Red Lobster, Rubel explains, is "what I would read as sort of down-market. I'm sorry—you go there." (Only when it's open!) "But it's not going to Chez Panisse." The amount of money possessed by the average Red Lobster patron is likely less than the average diner at a restaurant evaluated by the James Beard Foundation, he observes. Therefore, he points

out—not unreasonably—their concepts of "value" may differ.

It will be impossible, Rubel thinks, for me to identify the best free restaurant bread in America if I'm willing to entertain nominations for chain restaurants. "Because, I'm sorry, those factories are not producing anything that would be called 'best' by any objective standard—probably," he says.

However, "brown bread" from the Cheesecake Factory is not only the most popular answer in the poll; it also tends to come to people quickly. Helen Rosner, a food correspondent for *The New Yorker*, sums up the tastes of the nation even without being privy to the polling data. "Obviously the Cheesecake Factory's brown bread is the gold standard of free restaurant bread," she writes to me in an email—and, in the same heartbeat, presents a bang-on psychological profile of the country's citizens. "It's distinct," she writes. "Dark brown bread shows up pretty rarely in most people's daily lives, so it both feels special, and has the competitive advantage of not being subconsciously compared to near-infinite other breads of similar complexion."

One January afternoon, I travel to the smallest Cheesecake Factory in America—the flagship location, in Beverly Hills—to break brown bread with Jay Hinson, the company's senior vice president of restaurant-kitchen operations. The average Cheesecake Factory location serves about 7,500 "brown breads"—they are "whole-wheat baguettes," technically, drearily—a week, plus 6,800 of the less-remarked-upon sourdough baguettes that accompany them in the same basket. All of the bread is baked off-site—the sourdough at facilities in New Jersey and Los Angeles, the brown bread in Chicago—frozen, and shipped to the restaurants, where it is rebaked to order. The Cheesecake Factory declined to share any details about the amount of money it spends creating thousands of breads for hundreds of restaurants every week, but at one point in our conversation, Hinson observes, "It is very expensive to have a bread program that is free." At another, he tosses out a hypothetical scenario in which a restaurant company might spend "\$10 million" on



The miniature whole-wheat baguette from the Cheesecake Factory is firm, marginally sweet, speckled with oats for texture, and memorably brown.

bread, which seems like an absurd number to chance upon as a totally random example; make of that what you will.

Hinson, an amiable man with six daughters, began working at the Cheesecake Factory as a line cook in Westbury, New York, 28 years ago, and now flies to Chile to meet salmon vendors, and Turkey to meet branzino vendors, and Sweden to watch German-made ovens churn out pasta and steak simultaneously, with an eye ever fixed on the horizon of potential Cheesecake Factory refinements. He is loquacious only about the science of cooking, but also possessed of a striking corporate verbal tic, in which he substitutes the word *opportunities* for *problems*: “If your equipment, after five years, has opportunities, you have to place service calls.” “We’ll meet with my team and discuss any opportunities that happened the week prior. Did we solve

them all?” Many customers “had some opportunities with” a previous sourdough iteration that was unacceptably crusty.

The miniature whole-wheat baguette placed on our table is the rich brown of life-giving Diet Coke. It is warm, of course; soft, but with a firm crust; covered in a dense constellation of oats, for “a little bit of texture,” Hinson says. It is sweet in the way that adults like things to be—marginally—and mellowed further with the addition of salted Grassland butter. I sample it as I sample everything: like a black hole. I consume two baskets of baguettes solo; Hinson seldom eats free restaurant bread. I would like it to be sweeter, or saltier, or both. But it feels virtuous to be eating something at least moderately healthy, and so blatantly brown.

Except, Rubel informs me (of course), brown bread is not especially healthy. “It’s not?” I ask. “In real life?” Rubel replies. “No.”

I think of Rubel, and his self-sentenced ignorance of the delights of Red Lobster, a few weeks later, when I visit my father. Measured by the amount of joy it is capable of producing, I’d told Rubel, “a Cheddar Bay Biscuit at Red Lobster is pretty good.”

We moved my father cross-country to his apartment in Santa Fe a few years ago, after my mother died unexpectedly. I can tell before I’ve set one foot inside his door that the man has treated himself to a Red Lobster Ultimate Feast. “Ohhh, it smells like lobster in here!” I exclaim; he has been feeling poorly, and I have taken, recently, to entering his apartment with the verve of a cartoon character. My father is in his recliner, the Ultimate Feast sprawled out before him: A snow crab’s severed Jurassic limbs jut over the edge of his wooden tray alongside a half-eaten Cheddar Bay Biscuit.

I am happy to see that he’s summoned an Ultimate Feast for himself, because a couple of weeks earlier, he told me that food doesn’t “taste like food” to him lately. But I realize that he hasn’t made his characteristic dent in the spread.

“What does it taste like?” I ask.

“It kind of tastes like sawdust,” Dad says. “Even the biscuits didn’t taste good, and I love their biscuits.” He is so darkly fascinated by this—Cheddar Bay Biscuits’ novel flavorlessness—that he repeats the observation a minute later. “It’s amazing,”

he says, “because I usually love their biscuits.” He encourages me to take the extra biscuit home, which of course I do.

My dad will die a few days later, while I am working on this story. This conversation about Cheddar Bay Biscuits will turn out to be one of our last.

The Best Free Restaurant Bread in America

Based on survey responses, Americans seem capable of genuinely convincing themselves that they have just eaten the best free restaurant bread in America anytime they are given gratis bread that is warm or hot. This is not just psychology, Kantha Shelke, a food scientist, tells me; “it’s actually thermodynamics.” Because aroma is “80 percent of the flavor,” Shelke explains, and warm bread releases volatile aroma compounds into the air, “the warm bread literally tastes better to us.” (She also tells me that, short of seizing a Cheesecake Factory and transforming it into your private residence, you will never, ever be able to re-create the exact taste of its brown bread at home. Commercial enterprises have access to oxidizing agents, dough-conditioning enzymes, and surfactants that “simply are not available to home bakers.”)

Apart from temperature, *pillowy*, *soft*, and *sweet* are the most common adjectives applied to favorite breads in people’s responses, followed by *crispy* and *crusty*. Small efforts to enhance presentation, plus novel shapes and flavors—bread served on a black linen napkin, for example, or apple fritters—seem to pay off big in terms of memorability. There are some quirky regional trends: Many Californians are able to name the exact local bakery from which their favorite restaurant bread is sourced. Millennials from Massachusetts are inordinately likely to at least mention a pizza chain called Bertucci’s that, I am informed over and over again, gives young diners raw dough to play with at the table. Immediate family members frequently identify the same bread as their favorite, as if this has been determined by group vote. Many people can only recall breads eaten as children.

Two restaurants are named often enough in the poll to reach the top 10 without being chains: Parc, in Philadelphia, and Le Diplomate, in Washington, D.C. These restaurants, both operated by the Philadelphia restaurateur Stephen Starr, turn out to serve the exact same bread. If, for the purposes of calculation, we consider them a single restaurant with two outposts, they receive the equivalent of 1,150 votes per 100 restaurants. There are other, no doubt smarter ways to manipulate the data. And, of course, there remains the possibility that the poll has demonstrated only the peculiar tastes of morons and deviants—with the exception of the gracious Stephen King. But you can’t keep fiddling with the numbers of your bread poll forever. At a certain point, you have to rejoin the world.

The wicker baskets at Parc, a French bistro on Rittenhouse Square, contain three varieties of bread tucked into wax paper—but the only one people talk about is the cranberry-walnut loaf. It is fitting that the best free restaurant bread in America should contain cranberries; they are indigenous to North America. If you were going to design a restaurant bread specifically intended to appeal to 21st-century Americans, you might well create this exact foodstuff: It is a very chewy sourdough, with a thick, crispy crust that is chocolate brown in color—practically the same hue as the Cheesecake Factory bread. The dried cranberries add so much sweetness that some people mistake them for cherries, but oats and nuts check the suavity before it runs amok. In fact, the bread has an Everlasting Gobstopper-ish ability to harmoniously convey the sensation of eating an entire meal, with dessert, in every bite. It is assembled from familiar ingredients, but unusual enough to be memorable. The terrazzo arrangement of nut and berry is beautiful by candlelight; the crumb appears studded with gems.

Starr estimates that, at a cost of about 60 cents a basket, with 10,000 customers a week, Parc gives away slightly less than half a million dollars in free bread every year—a figure that does not include butter. The kitchen turns out about 1,500 loaves a day, of which 200 are the cranberry-walnut. The brief that Starr gave



Slices of the cranberry-walnut bread served at Parc, in Philadelphia, and Le Diplomate, in Washington, D.C. Each bite delivers the sensation of eating an entire meal.



his chef and baker when the restaurant opened was: “Just come up with the greatest breadbasket ever.” The goal, he tells me, was to create a breadbasket so satisfying that “you didn’t have to spend any money. You could just come in here, order the breadbasket, a glass of wine, and you’re good for the next five, six hours. We just wanted it to be joyful.”

“From a financial standpoint, it was the dumbest move we ever made,” he

says. “It costs so much and people eat so much of it.” He’s come close to charging for it, he says. But “the moment I think I’m going to do it, I go, ‘I can’t do it.’”

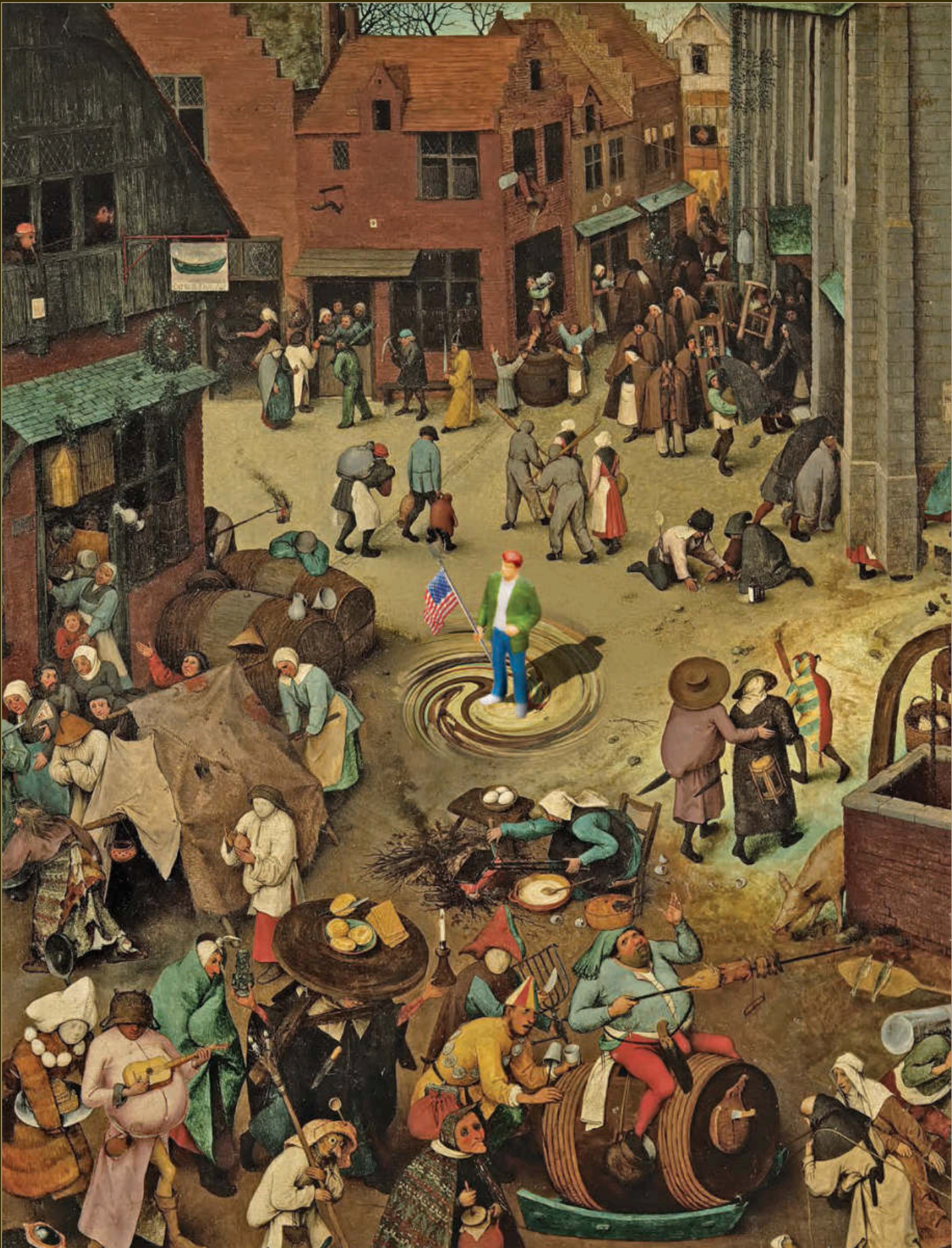
My visit to Parc, a few weeks after my father’s death, is the first time I go to Philly, his hometown, without his knowledge. I am seated near a family: a mother, father, and college-age daughter. I can hardly look at them, even as I can’t keep my eyes off them. Veiled by Parc’s low lighting, I allow myself to sink into a luxuriant, tear-flooded sadness. My parents will never again shout to be heard in a winter-crowded restaurant, or identify the cheapest (Mom) or most expensive (Dad) entrée. They will never again call, into a McDonald’s drive-through speaker, the beverage-order coda that I have never heard anyone outside my immediate family utter: “And a cup of free water.” Before my check arrives, I request a to-go box of just cranberry-walnut bread, and am floored by the quantity of pieces I receive in a swish brown bag. I wish I could tell my parents about it. Just knowing it was possible to receive so much bread for free would have delighted them.

William Rubel’s profoundest anxiety about my article, I learn, is that I will inadvertently denigrate another culture’s bread—by suggesting that a yeasted roll is inherently superior to, say, chapati. He fears this more than the possibility that I might assert in print that Red Lobster Cheddar Bay Biscuits taste better than the bread served at Chez Panisse. (“I guess I need to eat it,” he says, catching himself declaring, with no firsthand knowledge, that the table bread at Red Lobster could not possibly be superior. I will extend this same grace to the bread at Chez Panisse.) “You’ll need to find some way to clarify that you aren’t saying these are the best breads in the world,” he tells me. “These are what people you talked to in America at this time considered the best.”

“There’s no recipe for the best bread,” Rubel says. “The best bread is written in each person’s heart.”

I disagree. The best bread—at least the best free restaurant bread in America—is the aforementioned cranberry-walnut loaf. *A*

Caity Weaver is a staff writer at The Atlantic.



HISTORY IS RUNNING BACKWARDS

Why reactionaries
are taking
over the world

By David Brooks

Illustrations by Nicolás Ortega



Maybe you've seen photos of Tehran in the 1970s, just before the Islamic Revolution: images of young women going to work in miniskirts, of couples making out in parks while wearing bell-bottoms, of people at pools in bikinis. It looks like Paris or Milan or Los Angeles. But in 1979 the revolution happened, and now Tehran looks like something from an earlier century.

Sometimes I think that our whole world has become kind of like that—going backwards in time. The religious movements thriving in today's secularized age are the traditionalist ones that dissent from large parts of contemporary culture—not only the

Shiite Islam of post-revolution Iran, but Orthodox Judaism and conservative Catholicism. Young Americans are flooding into Eastern Orthodox churches.

Many of us thought that the world would get more democratic as it modernized, but for the past quarter century, we have seen a reversion to authoritarian strongmen. Donald Trump, acting like some 16th-century European prince, has made the presidency his own personal fiefdom. Vladimir Putin borrows ideas from reactionary thinkers such as Aleksandr Dugin—an Eastern Orthodox, anti-liberal philosopher who rejects the Enlightenment—to justify his imperial conquest of Ukraine.

If you go on social media, you can see photos of tradwives baking cookies for their husband and five kids. The secretary of health and human services and his followers don't trust those newfangled inventions, vaccines. In 1999, it seemed that world affairs would be dominated by multilateral groups such as the European Union and the World Trade Organization—but now we are back to 19th-century-style great-power rivalries between China and the United States, between Russia and Europe. Trump's new National Security Strategy has even revived the Monroe Doctrine.

We used to have a clear idea of where modernity was heading—toward greater autonomy and equality, secularism, stronger individual rights, cultural openness, and liberal democracy. Progress was supposed to lead to the expansion of individual choice in sphere after sphere. Science and reason would prosper while superstition and conspiracy-mongering would wither away.

Turns out that was yesterday's vision of the future. Billions of people around the world looked at where history was heading and yelled: *Stop!* They see that future as too spiritually empty, too lonely, too technological, too polluted, too confusing, too incoherent. Whatever their specific complaint, they are driven by a sense of loss, a desire to go back to a simpler, happier, and more sustainable time. Part of the brilliance of the phrase *Make America Great Again* is that it taps into that sense of nostalgia and loss.

Periods of great disruption inevitably produce yearning for an earlier golden age, and ours is no different. You can tell what kind of reactionary a person is by asking them what era they want to go back to. For some MAGA dudes, it's the Roman empire, when

men were men. For some theocrats, it's the Middle Ages, when men were monks. In the U.S., many on the right want to go back to the social mores of the 1950s: men in the workplace, women at home; white people on top; epic levels of church attendance; and wholesome fare such as *Oklahoma!* and *Leave It to Beaver* onstage and on television. Meanwhile, many on the left want to go back to that decade's union- and manufacturing-led economy, or to the utopian socialism of the 19th century. Our politics is drenched in nostalgia.

Those of us who believe in progress and the values of the Enlightenment tend to be condescending toward these reactionary impulses. We assume that the reactionaries are unsophisticated, intransigent, parochial—afraid of the freedom that modernity brings. It's futile to think you can turn back the clock, we say.

But civilizations turn back the clock all the time. The Italian Renaissance can be seen as a concerted artistic and intellectual effort to return to classical Greek and Roman times. In *Lost Enlightenment*, the historian S. Frederick Starr recounts how, during the Middle Ages, Central Asia went from being the most scientifically and economically advanced region of the globe to falling behind Europe. During the Ming dynasty, China stopped exploration and de-emphasized scientific progress.

The 18th-century French Enlightenment cult of reason produced the 19th-century Romantic cult of passion as a counter-reaction. The 19th-century explosion of industrialization produced the neo-Gothic reaction, led by people such as John Ruskin, who celebrated pre-machine living.

For much of the 20th century, faith in progress was the guiding ideology of modernity. Think of all those world's fairs and theme parks, the giddiness about the wonders of Tomorrowland. That faith in progress was not only a technological one—flying cars!—but a spiritual and moral one. Many, including me, derived meaning from the belief that we were contributing to social progress.

Today, however, billions of people have lost that faith in progress as a source of meaning and are flocking to its opposite. In the 21st century, traditionalism has emerged as a catalytic school of thought. Reactionaries are propelling events, shifting culture and history in their direction. If we want to understand where all of this is taking us, we need to understand what's driving them and where they get their beliefs. And to contend successfully with the traditionalists' effects on our politics and culture, we also need to recognize that elements of their worldview are correct. But which parts are correct, and which are completely off the rails?

IF YOU GO SPELUNKING into the mind of a traditionalist of a more intellectual sort, you will usually find Oswald Spengler somewhere deep inside. The first volume of Spengler's *The Decline of the West* was published in 1918, just as the First World War was winding down. He argued that each culture has its own unique soul, comprising its habits, customs, and myths. Like any living organism, each culture grows, matures, ages, and dies. In their youthful phases, they display great creativity, a flowering of the arts, an effusion of strong personalities. As they transition to maturity and eventually senescence, they urbanize and bureaucratize, elites lose moral authority, and creativity withers.

Spengler argued that Western culture emerged around the end of the tenth century. He called it “Faustian.” It was individualistic, expansionary, acquisitive, insatiable in its striving. Once a culture slips into its decline phase, it becomes imperialistic and materialistic, and technologists drive what happens. The political system slides into what Spengler called “Caesarism”—rule by despots. Urbanization and industrial growth create masses of atomized people susceptible to demagoguery. Financial power is concentrated in impersonal institutions, weakening the old elites. Large-scale bureaucracy leads to a centralization of power. When crises hit, people want decisive authority. If you believe that our society is in decline, Spengler’s sweeping theories describe and explain what is happening today.

If Spengler was part of the cultural-determinist wing of the interwar reactionary movement, René Guénon was part of the mystical wing. Both men believed the West was in decline, but for different reasons. While the historian Mark Sedgwick was researching his superb book *Traditionalism*, Dugin told him that what Karl Marx is to communism, Guénon is to traditionalism. Guénon was born in central France in 1886. Throughout his life, he studied various forms of spiritual knowledge—gnosticism, Islam, Taoism, Hinduism. He was not a political writer but a metaphysical one who believed that different religions are living links to the same underlying cosmic truth. He also believed that Western civilization had turned away from this spiritual truth and was living through what Hindu thinkers call the Kali Yuga, the age of corruption and moral decline.

Reading traditionalist writers, you find that each comes up with a different term for the spiritual deadness they associate with modern civilization. Spengler used the word *Kulturverfall*. For Guénon, that word was *quantity*. In his 1945 book, *The Reign of Quantity and the Signs of the Times*, he argued that in this phase of “progressive ‘materialization,’” only things that can be counted are considered real.

In the modern age, Guénon continued, science dominates. Modern scientists think they are taking a cold, objective look at reality, but they are pitifully naive, stuck at the level of what scientific materialism and measurement will allow. A modern scientist, in the Guénon view, is oblivious to spiritual reality—which, to the traditionalist, is the primary reality—and so adopts a worldview that denies the existence of the metaphysical realm. The modern scientist is like someone who investigates the workings of an orchestra without the ability to hear music or even the awareness that music exists. All he can describe is bows scraping against strings and air flowing through wind instruments. His theories make a hash of what he is observing, leaving his readers in a flat, soulless realm of disjointed facts.

The modern person senses a vacuum where his spiritual life should be. He covers the hole in his soul with ceaseless agitation, unending change, and ever-increasing speed. “The dominant impression today,” Guénon wrote more than 80 years ago, is “an impression of instability extending to all domains.” His commitment to traditionalist spirituality brought him eventually to Sufism, a mystical strain of Islam. He converted, moved to Cairo, married an Egyptian woman, and died there in 1951.

Guénon had a profound influence on Julius Evola, an Italian writer who had a brief moment of celebrity in the American press in 2017, after the media revealed that the Trump adviser Steve Bannon had referenced Evola during a conference at the Vatican. The white nationalist Richard Spencer called Evola “one of the most fascinating men of the 20th century.”

Evola was born in Rome, fought as an artillery officer in World War I, and then became an artist in the Dada movement. He agreed with Guénon that we are living in an age of corruption that has turned its back on spiritual truth. In 1934, he published a manifesto called *Revolt Against the Modern World*. Evola broke with Guénon, however, by embracing politics after World

War II and becoming the chief ideologue of the Italian far right. His views were anti-egalitarian, anti-liberal, antidemocratic. He was pro-monarchy and pro-hierarchy, and supported a racial caste system. He was post-liberal before being post-liberal was cool.

Benito Mussolini was a big fan, but Evola criticized fascism for accepting too much of the modern world. What is necessary, Evola argued, is a “race of masters,” who will lead a “revolt from the depths.” Any attempt to make a better world with spiritually stunted

people will fail—because spiritually stunted people chase shallow, hedonistic values, and a noble society can be built only by those whose lives are oriented toward spiritual excellence.

Evola was political where Guénon was not, bluntly racist where Guénon was not. Gábor Vona, a prominent hard-right politician in Hungary, called Evola “one of the greatest thinkers of the twentieth century” in the foreword to a 2012 selection of Evola’s writing titled *A Handbook for Right-Wing Youth*. Today many of us look at Europe’s far-right parties and see pseudo-storm troopers. But those parties see themselves as a spiritual vanguard trying to preserve the highest registers of the soul.

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UNDERSTANDING CONTEMPORARY TRADITIONALISM requires understanding its intellectual underpinnings in the thinking of these forefathers. All traditionalists tell a story about a time when people were rooted in stable homes and a way of life that got destroyed by a historic rupture that ushered in the soulless modern era—whether they call that era Faustian Civilization (Spengler), the Age of Quantity (Guénon), the Kali Yuga (Guénon and Evola), or something else.

Today's traditionalists do not agree on when history took a wrong turn. But they all tell some sort of decline story. "It's an empirical fact that basically everything in our day to day lives has gotten worse over the years," the right-wing podcaster Matt Walsh has written. "The quality of everything—food, clothing, entertainment, air travel, roads, traffic, infrastructure, housing, etc.—has declined in observable ways."

R. R. Reno is the editor of *First Things*, one of the most influential Catholic traditionalist magazines in America. Reno's story of decline doesn't really start until just after World War II. During the first half of the 20th century, he argues, Westerners lived amid rivers of blood—wars, revolutions, genocides. After the Nazis were defeated, many people across the West concluded that the savagery had been unleashed by strong attachments to nations, ideologies, homeland, race. To head off future world wars, people across a range of sectors felt it necessary to create a culture that would prevent the strong beliefs and loyalties that might lead to fanaticism and war. A representative example is the philosopher Karl Popper, a champion of the scientific method, who wrote *The Open Society and Its Enemies*, which celebrates minds and nations that are not closed around core truths but are instead perpetually open to new possibilities. Forms of critical thinking were elevated to undermine grand philosophies. Moral relativism—the idea that it's up to each person to find their own values and truth—prevailed. Children were raised in permissive environments to foster greater pluralism. As Reno puts it in *Return of the Strong Gods*, postwar thinkers came to a fundamental conclusion: "Whatever is strong—strong loves and strong truths—leads to oppression, while liberty and prosperity require the reign of weak loves and weak truths."

This cult of openness, Reno observes, was bipartisan. Liberals believed in lifestyle freedom and conservatives believed in economic freedom, but they both believed in the primacy of individual choice. You do you; I'll do me.

But all of this openness didn't lead to a nirvana of free individuals. It led, the traditionalists believe, to a society in which social bonds were attenuated. It led to a nihilistic society in which people could find no grand purpose. It led to a consumerist society in which people shopped to fill their spiritual void. It led, in Reno's words, to "dissolution, disintegration, and deconsolidation."

"Unable to identify our shared loves," Reno writes, "we cannot identify the common good, the *res* in the *res publica*." Civic life collapses.

Though today traditionalism mostly lives on the right, it sometimes emanates from the far left. The British writer Paul Kingsnorth, for instance, was a radical-left environmentalist before becoming an Orthodox Christian traditionalist. The two positions are not so different—both reject technocratic modernity. Kingsnorth has his own term for the spiritual deadness of modern life: "the Machine," which, in his telling, comprises all of capitalist, technocratic society. In his book *Against the Machine*, he describes a visit to a grocery store: "I saw the sheer *unnaturalness* of this way



of obtaining food, and the unnaturalness, too, of our wandering these straight lined, strip-lit plastic aisles inside this giant metal box instead of gathering mushrooms from a forest floor.” Kingsnorth’s writing has a strong *Small Is Beautiful* hippie vibe, but he goes beyond that. “The degree of control and monitoring which we endure in ‘developed’ societies, which has been accelerating for decades and which has reached warp speed in the 2020s, is creating a kind of digital holding camp in which we all find ourselves trapped.” He sees the ideology of the Machine as a “liberation of individual desire” that effaces our communal civilizational bonds and turns our world into “a blank slate to be written on afresh when the old limits of nature and culture are washed away. This is our faith: that breaking boundaries leads to happiness.”

The Machine is not only a system outside of us but a state of mind within us, one built around rationalism, economics, scientism, optimization, and efficiency. Its impulse is to use pure reason to achieve power, control, and domination. We like to think the Nazis were fanatics who operated outside of reason. Not so, Kingsnorth argues. They were consummate embodiments of the rationalist project, using social science to engineer what they took to be the optimal society.

The rationalist Machine seeks to merge your mind with the AI bots that are turning you into something less than fully human. Kingsnorth quotes a famous line from Wendell Berry: “The next great division of the world will be between people who wish to live as creatures and people who wish to live as machines.”

WHAT DO THE TRADITIONALISTS offer as a replacement for contemporary culture?

First, they offer roots. The master trend of modernity is freedom. You get to do what you want. You can go to college far away, move from city to city, surf through different cultures and lifestyle options.

This, traditionalists charge, leads to an aimless, ephemeral life. “The modern person belongs everywhere and nowhere at once,” Alan Noble, a literature professor at Oklahoma Baptist University, writes in *You Are Not Your Own: Belonging to God in an Inhuman World*. Such a person is perpetually sampling experiences but is not rooted. When the so-called abundance progressives argue that America has a housing crisis, the traditionalists counter that what America really has is a home crisis. Cultural change and mass immigration mean that people can’t even feel at home in their own country.

Traditionalists, by contrast, offer stable attachments. For the traditionalist, the primary unit of modern social life is not the sovereign, free-choosing individual; it is the social covenant that connects people. We are not born into a void. We are born into particular families, particular neighborhoods, particular tribes, particular faiths. Your life is connected via a great chain of bonds to your ancestors, whom you honor, and to future generations, whom you serve. In the traditionalist imagining, people are planted in the spot of earth where the bones of their ancestors lie, the place where they can be intimately known and deeply loved, where stories and skills get passed down by elders, and where they know the hills and trees so well that their contours are

carved into the heart. Living up to your covenantal obligations constitutes the essence of moral life. Traditionalists are willing to accept limits on their freedom if it enables them to live within a local network of strong attachments that give life meaning.

Second, traditionalists offer enchantment. Moderns, they believe, live within what Max Weber called the “iron cage” of rationalism and bureaucracy, which is denuded of any enchantment. The goals of science and capitalism are pragmatic, materialistic, and instrumental. In a disenchanted world, religion withers, and so do the humanities, the poetic, and the spiritual. To borrow from R. R. Reno, why read *Middlemarch* when you can learn about marriage from a behavioral economist armed with studies, correlations, and standard deviations?

Traditionalists generally believe in a transcendent realm of the spirit that exists above and prior to the world we experience through our senses. This transcendent level of reality is independent of you—it is ordained by God, contained within the mysteries of nature, expressed through myth and song more than through analytical thinking. “Every culture, whether it knows it or not, is built around a sacred order,” Kingsnorth writes. “This does not, of course, need to be a Christian order. It could be Islamic, Hindu or Daoist. It could be based on the veneration of ancestors or the worship of Odin. But there is a throne at the heart of every culture, and whoever sits on it will be the force you take your instruction from.”

Third, traditionalists offer moral order. Good and evil are not matters of personal choice. Natural law is woven by God into the fabric of the universe. Traditionalists get worked up when they find themselves in a culture that can no longer define what a woman is, because they believe that categories like gender are elemental to natural law.

The fourth thing that traditionalists offer their flock is protection against the cultural depredations of modernity. Modern progressives decry the evils of colonialism. But to the traditionalist, progressives are themselves colonialists: Their educators determine what ideologies will be pumped into your kid’s brain, their psychologists redefine how you should raise your family, their thought police determine what words can come out of your mouth. To the traditionalist, professional experts—social workers, university administrators, therapists, DEI officers, and the media—are the storm troopers of elite domination. In response to all of this, traditionalists seek to help people recapture control of their own culture.

The people I’m quoting in this essay are mostly intellectuals, but their loyalty is with the working class because they share (or at least think they share) the same beliefs. “Lower-middle-class culture, now as in the past, is organized around family, church, and neighborhood,” the historian Christopher Lasch wrote in *The True and Only Heaven*. “It values the community’s continuity more highly than individual advancement, solidarity more highly than social mobility.” The working class doesn’t require seminars to teach it traditionalism; it grasps the concept intuitively.

The culture war between the modernists and the traditionalists is not just between classes within nations, but between civilizations. Every few years, the World Values Survey studies various cultures around the globe. Protestant Europe and the English-speaking world, including the United States, stand out for their

tremendous emphasis on individual autonomy, self-expression, and secular social values. Most of the rest of the world places higher value on traditional family arrangements, the importance of religion, and respect for authority. We moderns may think we own the future, but the traditionalists like their chances. If this is a global culture war, it's the whole world against us.

THE REASON I've dwelled at such length on the tenets and features of traditionalism is that I want my description to be accurate enough that traditionalists will see themselves in it, and to be detailed enough that even progressive, Enlightenment-loving moderns might understand the appeal of traditionalist ideas.

I confess that I feel a modicum of sympathy for some of the traditionalist arguments. One of my favorite insights from psychology is that a successful, well-adjusted life consists of daring explorations from a secure base. The traditionalists are right to say that one of the central problems in America and the West today is that many people have lost that secure base—a stable home and community, solid emotional connections, financial security, a coherent culture, and an understanding that our lives are contained within a shared moral order.

My problem with the traditionalists is that I don't agree with them about what a flourishing life looks like. Traditionalists strike me as the kind of people who would score extremely low on the personality trait called "openness to experience." They focus overwhelmingly on the secure base and seem to have no interest in daring adventures. They seem to want to lead stationary lives.

That's fine. Different strokes for different folks. But the traditionalists distort history when they write it as if all people have always wanted stationary lives and our goal as a society should be to make stationary lives the norm.

All traditionalists, from Spengler to Kingsnorth, tell a story about a historic rupture that destroyed the ancestral culture and gave rise to the rootless, soulless modern era. But no such historic rupture ever happened. Nor has there been a moment when humans were forever content to stay within the safety of their village. History has always been lived within the tension between the desire for security and the desire for learning, exploration, movement, and growth. The early hominids of the species *Homo erectus* may have loved their small African communities 1.9 million years ago—but they still ventured forth to places as far as China and Indonesia. The early Polynesians may have loved their home islands—but they still felt the urge to explore and settle an array of tiny islands in an expanse of ocean spanning millions of square miles. (And they did this in a time without modern navigation devices, when one slight steering error could set you astray in the enormous, empty Pacific.)

Human beings have a need for both security and exploration, for both belonging and autonomy, for both stability and innovation. Our lives are propelled by these contradictions, which can never be resolved.

Traditionalists are trying to live the monist dream—the dream that we can build a society in which all the pieces fit neatly together. But the many and diverse values that humans cherish will never fit neatly together. In every culture, groups argue

over which values should have priority in present circumstances. There's never been a tranquil resting spot, and there never will be.

Some traditionalists talk as if early or medieval Christendom is the static utopia they yearn for. Once upon a time, people lived close to the soil and were enveloped by faith—until those dehumanizing forces of democracy, capitalism, science, and technology ruined everything. But Judaism and Christianity are not separate from democracy, capitalism, science, and the rest of modernity. In fact, they provided many of the rules and ideas that are the basis of post-Enlightenment modernity: all humans are morally equal; respect individual conscience; history moves in a linear direction; every person has their own calling, as well as inalienable rights. Jesus was hardly a supporter of stasis. He was a Jewish radical who turned all the power structures of his society upside down.

Let me offer my own historical narrative and talk about where it overlaps with the traditionalist one and where it diverges. The story I tell is a long procession of stumbles. Some eras are more communal and some eras are more individualistic; some are more religious and some are more secular. But in the West, these cultural shifts have mostly been led by people trying to move humanity forward, in response to the needs of the moment. The stumbling process can be ugly—wars, atrocities, communism. But generally we have stumbled forward. At Harvard, the cognitive scientist Steven Pinker spent a decade or so collecting an Everest of data showing that life since the Enlightenment has been getting more peaceful, more affluent, more comfortable, happier, and more learned—as well as simply longer. And our progress is not just material; it's moral. Things that our society used to tolerate—torture, slavery, cruelty—have been deemed unacceptable by both law and custom. The late political scientist James Q. Wilson wrote in *The Moral Sense* that “the most remarkable change in the moral history of mankind has been the rise—and occasionally the application—of the view that all people, and not just one's own kind, are entitled to fair treatment.”

I look across the past 70 years—years the traditionalists say are filled with moral rot—and I see an astounding widening of the circle of concern. Segregation and racism have been reduced. Billions of women have a greater chance to gain power and professional success equal to men's. Colonialism has been repudiated. We've seen the greatest reduction in global poverty in the history of the world. America has expanded opportunity beyond white, Protestant men. We've even passed laws to reduce cruelty to animals.

But even in the historical story I tell, every moment of great cultural or social advance has had a cost. Over these past 70 years of progress, our culture has moved in the direction of autonomy, individualism, and choice. This has generated creativity and freedom, but it has weakened the bonds between people and the elemental commitments that precede choice—to family, neighborhood, faith, and nation. As part of this general tendency toward individualism, we have privatized morality, telling people to come up with their own values.

Freedom is great, but not if you don't know what ultimate end you are seeking. Our modern, individualistic culture has fallen for the belief that individuals are capable of devising their own morality. No historical evidence supports this belief.



NICOLÁS ORTEGA. SOURCES: ARTGEN / ALAMY; RICHARD DRURY / GETTY.

As we've advanced scientifically and technologically, we've forgotten something that the traditionalists understand: People absorb their moral values, their sense of purpose, and their way of life from within a tradition. The most important text of the Western moral tradition is the Bible. Even figures who were not great or conventional religious believers—such as Shakespeare, Jefferson, and Lincoln—knew their Bible. The second-most-important tradition of moral wisdom is the body of work we call humanism—the great novels, paintings, poems, dramas, histories, and philosophical tracts by thinkers and artists from all over the globe.

In our rush toward autonomy, we have failed to pass down these sources of moral wisdom from one generation to the next. The ethos of individualism has led us to cut ourselves off from our own traditions: We're so focused on the individual self that we fail to appreciate the millennia-long conversations within which each self swims. This rejection of tradition has been driven partly by ideology. In 1987, a group of progressive students from Stanford chanted "Hey, hey, ho, ho, Western Culture has got to go!" They were part of a multigenerational effort led by people who thought that because Western civilization had produced colonialism, the whole collective wisdom of the Western tradition should be thrown in the trash. But I think the bigger cause

was simple shortsightedness. Several generations of parents, educators, and students decided that the most important subjects to study are those that can help you make money. They didn't recognize the value of the humanities.

The loss of civilizational and moral knowledge that this has entailed has had practical consequences: sloppy thinking by people who have never been taught how to weigh evidence, reach conclusions, or recognize the flaws in their own reasoning; the astonishing decline in literacy; loneliness; the sense of purposelessness that marks so many lives; people who don't understand themselves or one another. How sick does a civilization have to be to not pass down its own sources of wisdom and meaning to its children?

Because we have neglected our own humanistic traditions, a growing gap has opened between our scientific, technological, and economic progress on the one hand, and our social, emotional, and spiritual decay on the other. Fixing this problem doesn't require that we go back and live in monasteries and nunneries. Nor do we have to confine ourselves to, say, the 1930s canon of Western Civ, or the 1950s version of what constitutes high culture.

I agree with the traditionalists that tradition is important, but I don't think of it as something we need to go back to. Rather, I see it as something that each generation pushes forward. And for this, we need a humanistic renaissance. In schools, universities, and culture at large, we need to focus more explicitly on the big questions of life: What is my purpose? How should the next generation live? What role should beauty play in my life? How do I build a friendship?

What do I owe my spouse, my community, my nation? We need to use the best that has been thought and said by all of the great civilizations of the Earth, but especially by Western civilization, which is our own particular home, our core resource while we try to stumble toward a better future.

Though Christopher Lasch considered himself to be on the political left, he is sometimes embraced by the traditionalists for his celebration of rootedness, community, and the traditional family, and for his critique of the meritocratic elite. "The populist tradition offers no panacea for all the ills that afflict the modern world," he wrote. "It asks the right questions, but it does not provide a ready-made set of answers." The traditionalists have no panaceas either, but they also ask the right questions. They remind us how important it is to embed ourselves and our children within the great humanist conversation that extends back thousands of years. What we should take from the traditionalists is the idea that restoring our society's connection to its humanistic legacy and long-standing sources of meaning can actually help us better realize the promises of progress. *A*

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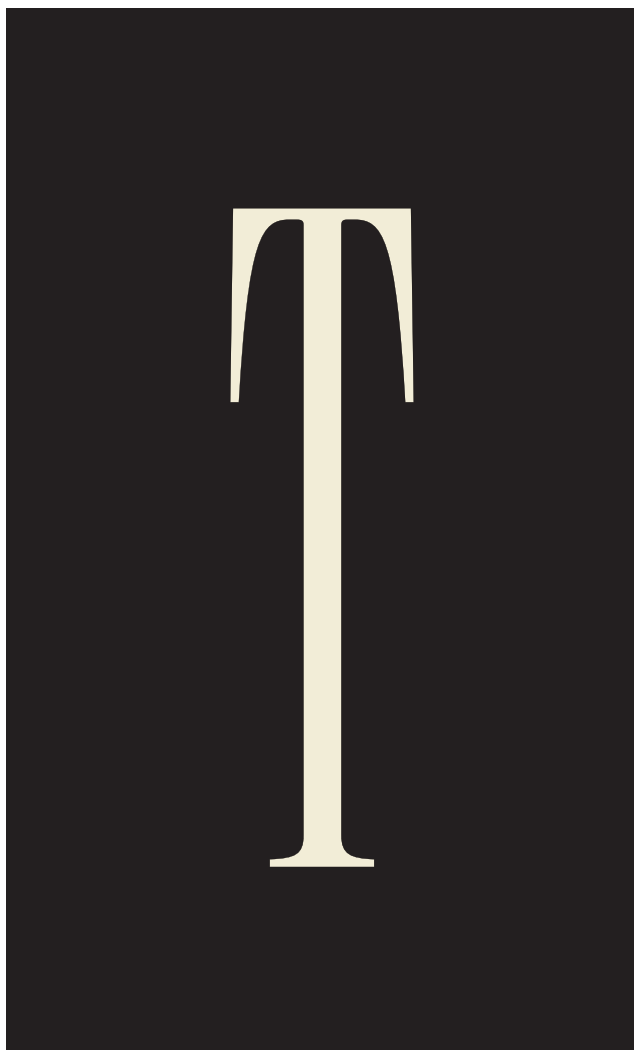
The Incredible Story of the Cartel Olympics

By McKay Coppins

Photographs by Adriana Loureiro Fernández

A Mexican athlete said he was kidnapped and forced to compete for his life in a tournament of gangs. But was he actually playing a different game?





They arrived suddenly—five white vans, identical and unmarked, blocking the street.

It was February 9, 2023, and Mauricio Morales was leading a group of migrants he had found at a bus station through Mexico City's San Rafael neighborhood. Mau, as his friends called him, had told the migrants he could help them at the nearby refugee camp where he worked. They had just crossed a busy boulevard and were making their way down a side street when the five large utility vans lurched to a stop in front of them.

Men with machine guns, wearing tactical gear, spilled out and started barking orders and threats: *¡Entren todos! ¡Ahora mismo, hijos de puta!* Were they police? Military? Mau couldn't tell, and there was no time to ask for identification. Within seconds, the migrants were being shoved into the vans. When Mau tried to resist, something hard hit him on the head, and he fell to the ground. As he was loaded into the back of one of the vans, he heard gunshots. He thought of his mother. *If this is the end*, he remembers thinking before he lost consciousness, *please let her be okay*.

Mau woke on the floor of a dank, windowless room with a single mattress and a bucket in one corner. His wallet was gone; so was his phone. He had no idea where he was or why he'd

been taken, but for the next few days, he and several other captives held with him were beaten and tortured. Men took turns pummeling him—breaking his ribs and pulling out his fingernails. When he tried to ask what they wanted, the beatings only got worse.

Then one day the men removed him from the room without explanation and deposited him back into a van. Assuming he was about to die, Mau began to weep. But when the van came to a stop and his captors hauled him out, he noticed that they were being careful with him now, almost gentle. "The boss wants to talk to him," he heard one of them say.

The facility they took him to was strange. It vaguely resembled a school: four wings divided into classroom-like compartments and an enclosed courtyard in the middle. But there were no children here. Instead, men with guns patrolled the premises while women who looked like they were dressed for a night of clubbing loafed around. *Narcocorridos*, accordion-heavy cartel ballads, played loudly over speakers in the courtyard.

Mau was taken to a makeshift office, where a man with a paunch and a thick mustache sat behind a desk. He was flanked by a large bodyguard in a butcher's apron and a voluptuous woman in a low-cut, form-fitting dress. He seemed irritated as he assessed Mau. "Look at him," the man grumbled. "He's so fucked up." He sent the bodyguard and the woman, who seemed to be his girlfriend, out of the room. Once they were alone, the man became warm and friendly. He introduced himself as Don Paco, and apologized to Mau for what he'd been put through.

"I know who you are," Don Paco said.

He told Mau that his men had noticed a tattoo of the Olympic rings on his wrist. After some research, they discovered that they had inadvertently kidnapped a world-class athlete—an Olympic runner who'd competed in Beijing, London, and Rio de Janeiro. This was serendipitous, Don Paco explained, because he happened to be in the market for athletes.

He said he was a leader of an organization called La Unión Tepito. Mau had heard about La Unión on the news. The cartel was relatively new, having risen to power in the past decade or so, but its tight grip on Mexico's capital city had made it one of the country's most notorious criminal syndicates. Don Paco told Mau that for all the attention paid to bloody turf wars and theatrical executions, organizations like his were an important part of the community—and Mexico was better off when its cartels got along.

Then Don Paco revealed something that would forever change how Mau saw his own country: For many years, Don Paco said, a secret tournament had been organized by Mexico's biggest cartels. They each fielded teams in sports such as soccer, flag football, and boxing, and rival cartel leaders gathered to watch the games. He described the event as a civilized affair, where the bosses could place friendly wagers and do business without shooting one another.

Winning the tournament was a point of immense pride, Don Paco explained. And so he had a proposition for his new prisoner: He wanted Mau to coach and play on a flag-football team. The team would train at the facility and then represent

La Unión at the tournament. If Mau won, he and his teammates would be released. If not, they would meet the same fate as anyone else who let down the organization.

Perhaps sensing Mau's incredulity, Don Paco put it bluntly. "If you win, you live," he said. "If you lose, you die."

Then the cartel boss flashed a broad smile. "But I'm sure you'll win, so it won't be a problem."

THE EMAIL ARRIVED in my inbox on a Thursday evening in December 2024: "Are you free for a call?" the subject line asked. "Massive story."

The message was from Robert Reynolds, a Las Vegas lawyer and talent manager whose clients included a collection of aughts rock acts, most notably the Killers. I barely knew Reynolds. We'd first spoken years earlier, when I tried unsuccessfully to get an interview with the band's front man, Brandon Flowers. Reynolds had never given me a tip before, and frankly, I couldn't imagine what "massive story" the manager of the Killers might be privy to. But my curiosity was piqued, so I gave him a call.

Reynolds picked up after one ring—"McKay!"—and launched into his story. He spoke in a throaty rumble, his bro-ish cadence punctuated, in moments of peak enthusiasm, with an emphatic *dude*. A few months earlier, he told me, he'd fielded an unusual ticket request from a high-ranking official at the United Nations. The official told him that a beloved volunteer at the UN's refugee camps in Syria, Ukraine, and Mexico had recently been held captive for months by a cartel. He was now recovering from the ordeal, and his colleagues wanted to lift his spirits with surprise tickets to his favorite band's sold-out show in Mexico City.

Reynolds obliged, and met the volunteer, whose name was Mauricio Morales, before the concert. After some coaxing, he got his new friend to recount his harrowing experience. The story floored Reynolds. "I was like, 'Dude, this is a movie!'" he told me.

Reynolds was a fledgling filmmaker himself. He'd helped produce a few documentaries—including an Emmy-nominated HBO film about his brother Dan Reynolds, the lead singer of Imagine Dragons—but what he really aspired to was screenwriting. This story, he believed, was his way in. Shortly after their meeting, he purchased Mau's life rights and began working on a film treatment for *The Cartel Olympics*.

The project was already generating buzz, Reynolds told me. The actor Michael Peña, of Marvel Cinematic Universe fame, had expressed strong interest in playing Mau. The darkness of the story was just the kind of thing that Oscar voters loved. So was the "body transformation" that would be required for Peña to convincingly play an Olympian. But the actor had a condition: He wanted a journalist to vet Mau's account and publish it in a reputable outlet so that he and the filmmakers could say, with full confidence, that the movie was "based on a true story."

That's where I came in. Speaking in excited, hurried tones, Reynolds laid out his proposal. I would interview Mau and write a story about his captivity, and then sell the film option to Reynolds, who—with his industry connections and Peña's attachment—could get the project fast-tracked at a major studio, and make us all a small Hollywood fortune.

I told Reynolds I'd think about it, but when I hung up the phone, I burst out laughing. The story seemed preposterous. An intercartel sports tournament? The hero's life hanging in the balance? Flag football? It sounded like an overwrought episode of *Narcos* or something. "It would be an incredible story if it were true," I told my wife that night. "But it almost certainly isn't true."

My opinion changed the first time I spoke with Mau, a few weeks later. I understood immediately why Reynolds found him so compelling. He was understated and self-effacing, politely answering my questions in good but imperfect English, and apologizing whenever he stumbled over a word. In a squawking, almost Muppetty voice, he told me about his work in the refugee camps, how he organized intramural sports teams to keep the kids entertained while they endured their nightmarish limbo. I liked him right away.

When I asked him about the kidnapping, he told me the story in halting, disjointed fragments, pausing periodically to steady his emotions. He didn't get flustered by skeptical questions—he simply explained what he'd seen as best as he could recall, sometimes admitting that certain bits were hazy. After a while, as I made him recount repeatedly the gruesome details of his torture, my skeptical-reporter persona began to soften. I found myself apologizing for my aggressiveness. "It's okay, Mr. McKay," he said.

To my surprise, Mau seemed credible. More important, he offered a list of sources who he said could vouch for him and verify parts of his story.

My first interview request went to James Winston, an aid worker and human-rights investigator based in London who worked for R4V, a UN-backed organization that supports migrants and refugees. Winston was the person who had initially contacted Reynolds and connected him with the UN official. He had also worked closely with Mau at the refugee camps, and spent years studying the atrocities committed by Mexico's cartels. He was doing fieldwork when I first reached him, but he answered a list of questions by email. When I asked him if there was any reason I should distrust Mau's story, his response was chiding. To uninformed outsiders, he told me, the depravity of Mexico's cartel culture was difficult to comprehend. "Many stories may seem unbelievable," he wrote. "But after years of immersion, I can assure you that they reflect a very real aspect of this society." In fact, Winston said, he was writing to me from a rural outskirts of Guadalajara, in west-central Mexico, where he was investigating what appeared to be a clandestine crematorium operated by the Jalisco New Generation cartel. Authorities had discovered a pile of bones, bullet casings, and more than 200 pairs of shoes in a burned-out building on a remote ranch.

"If I may," Winston wrote, "I'd suggest delving further into this culture to better grasp the reality and, potentially, write a more informed piece on Mau's story."

I felt like an idiot. I thought I'd been approaching this story with the clear-eyed wariness of a savvy reporter. But to Winston, I was exposing my sheltered-American naivete. He had a point. My sole experience in Mexico had been a week in 2011 at a resort, where I'd snorkeled with my wife, eaten coconut ice cream, and taken guided tours of some ruins.

But I knew Mexico was a real place, with real problems. The country's past two presidential administrations had catastrophically failed to rein in the cartels, and the new president didn't seem to be faring much better. If I was going to do Mau's story justice, I would need to go deeper.

Before signing off, Winston warned me that pursuing this story would come with risks. Publishing Mau's account "could very likely result in his death," he wrote. And if I tried to report in Mexico, I would be putting myself in peril: "Mexico is currently a very dangerous country for journalists."

IN THE CARTEL PRISON, training began daily at 7 a.m. sharp: laps in the courtyard, followed by push-ups and weight lifting with cinder blocks. Then the prisoner-athletes of La Unión Tepito were divided into groups and spent the rest of the day practicing for their assigned events. There were teams for soccer; a handball-style game called *frontón*; and *tochito*, or American flag football, which has become popular in Mexico.

Mau mostly kept to himself at first, interacting as little as possible with his teammates. Unlike him, most of the men in the prison were creatures of Mexico's criminal underworld, and he found them frightening.

One, nicknamed El Diablo, was a dead-eyed ex-cop who'd worked for a rival gang and spoke about his body count in an unnerving monotone. He specialized in disappearing victims. "It wasn't just drug dealers," he volunteered. "I had to do 14 kids one time." There had been nowhere to hide the bodies, he explained, so he'd meticulously dismembered each corpse and then dissolved the limbs in a vat of hydrochloric acid. Mau had trouble looking him in the eye.

Another teammate, Augusto, was a hulking lawyer who looked to be about 70. Augusto claimed that he was in the tournament as punishment for mishandling one of La Unión's cases. But the rumor around the prison was that he'd actually raped and murdered a young assistant who turned out to be the girlfriend of a cartel leader. Augusto was an asset to the team: He was deceptively strong for his age, and skilled, too, having played American football when he was young. But he had a menacing air and a virulent misogynistic streak. One evening, the team was watching a movie in which a woman was strangled to death on-screen. Augusto, visibly aroused, began to masturbate.

Weeks passed in the prison, then months. Deprived of contact with the outside world, Mau lost track of time. He ran drills for his team and drew up plays. At times, the experience felt almost like summer camp: sports and exercise during the day, dinner and taped soccer games on TV at night.

But terror was never far away. Many nights, Mau would lie in bed, listening to agonized screams echoing from other wings of the prison, and try not to think about who was getting tortured this time, and for what, and whether he would be next.

As Mau got to know his teammates better, he was surprised to discover that they weren't all irredeemable and depraved. Palomino was a taxi driver who had started running errands for the cartel to supplement his family's meager income. Loquillo desperately missed his wife. Little Hugo was a skinny *sicario* in training

who'd been lured into cartel life as a teenager with the promise of glamour and travel, and who peppered Mau with questions about what London and Beijing were like.

Mau became especially close with Mamers, a muscular hit man who was his first real friend in the cartel prison. They talked about their lives outside—Mau's work in the refugee camps earned him the mocking nickname Samaritan—and traded workout routines. When the subject of ex-girlfriends came up, Mamers admitted that he struggled with jealousy in relationships, and Mau counseled him on how to relax and be less controlling.

The more time he spent with Mamers, the more Mau realized that they weren't so different. They'd simply had different opportunities. Mamers—like Little Hugo, and Palomino, and so many more—had wound up on the Mexican conveyor belt that transports directionless young men into organized crime with ruthless efficiency. He had done terrible things, it was true, but how many choices did he really have? Mamers wasn't a rotten person, Mau concluded. He was the product of a rotten country.

And unfortunately, Mau could now relate all too well to being trapped in a corrupt system. No matter how many kids his cellblock mates had killed or women they'd raped, his survival depended on working with them.

One night, after training was over, Don Paco gathered the prisoners in the courtyard. There was a chill in the air that reminded Mau of late summer, though he couldn't say for sure what month it was. Don Paco announced that they would leave for the tournament the next day. Celebratory cervezas were passed around as the boss gave a pep talk on the importance of sportsmanship and clean play. He didn't want to see his teams cheating, he told them—it would spoil the pride of La Unión's victory.

Before he left, Don Paco reminded the prisoners of the life-and-death stakes of the event, and then added a further warning.

"Some of you will walk free tomorrow," he said. "But you must swear never to speak of what you saw here. We know who you are and where to find you."

I BEGAN TALKING regularly with Mau on the phone. It was clear to me that independently verifying his story would be difficult. If it had happened the way he said it had, there would be no public record and few living witnesses. But I wanted to get a sense of the story's plausibility. Were Mexico's cartel leaders really operating with such impunity that they could routinely force scores of kidnapped athletes into a *Squid Game*-style tournament for their own amusement?

Mau pushed me to expand my imagination. He was endlessly patient with my ignorance. Sometimes he would recommend movies for me to watch, as though I were an addled child who could understand how his country worked only by watching TV.

When I would express surprise at one of his assertions—about judges bought off by cartels; about celebrities and politicians with known narco connections—I could almost hear him stifle a sigh of exasperation. "The thing you need to understand about Mexico ..." he would say, before launching into a lecture about how things work there.

A brief review of Mexico's narco history confirmed that there was a lot I didn't understand. For all their potency in the popular imagination, the country's notorious drug cartels are only a few decades old—much younger than America's crime families. But they have woven themselves into Mexican society. They raise money for churches and build health clinics in rural areas. They throw block parties and hand out toys to kids at Christmastime. And, yes, they host sporting events—see the boxing matches organized by Los Zetas.

*The left hand of
Mauricio Morales,
which he says was
mangled during
torture sessions by the
cartel that kidnapped
him off the street*

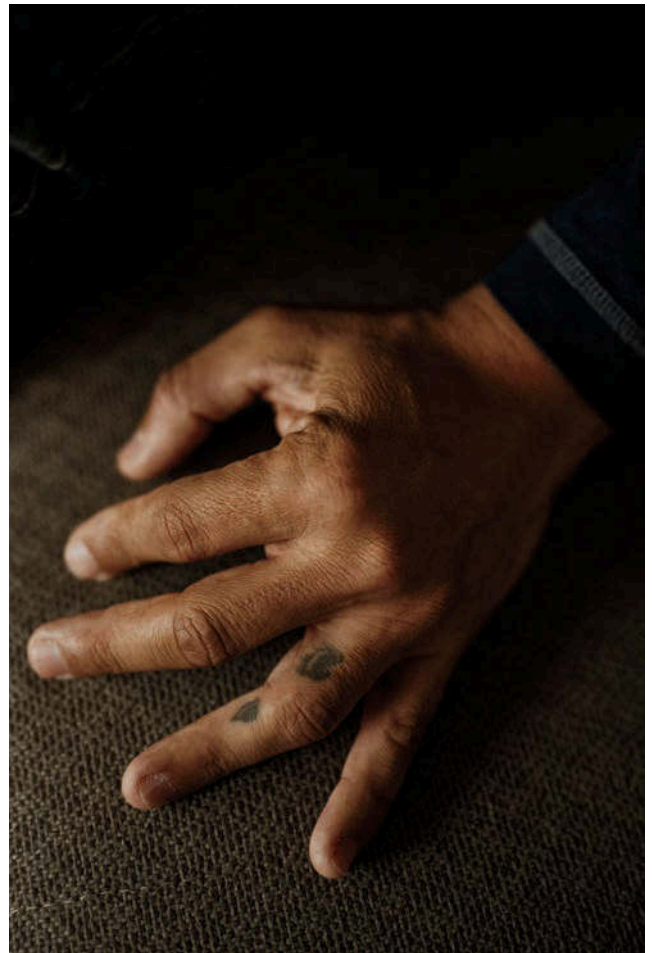
In some parts of Mexico, the state has been effectively replaced by cartel rule. Extortion payments to organized crime are part of daily life—required to run a business, secure protection for your family, and retrieve abducted loved ones. In 2010, after a photographer was gunned down in a parking lot near his newsroom in Juárez, the newspaper *El Diario* published a front-page editorial pleading with the cartels: “What is it you want from us? What is it you want us to publish or not publish? Explain so that we can respond. You are at present the de facto authorities in this city.”

Even after the Mexican government declared war on the cartels in 2006, some of the most-wanted bosses were still able to roam the country freely, untouched by the law. El Chapo, the elusive leader of the Sinaloa cartel, was known to drop by high-end restaurants for dinner—gunmen politely confiscating patrons' phones, El Chapo picking up everyone's tab when he was done.

The more time I spent reading these stories, the more I had to admit that Mau's, while still improbably wild, didn't seem impossible.

One day, at the end of an unusually long phone call, Mau seemed dejected. The news in Mexico City was dominated by the broad-daylight assassination of two aides to the mayor, possibly by cartel *sicarios*. The shooting had taken place not far from where Mau lived, and though it had nothing to do with him, he seemed to feel like he was running for his life with nowhere to hide. He told me that he'd come to believe that corruption and violence were so deeply rooted in Mexico that, even if all the cartels disappeared overnight, the culture they'd created would outlive him.

For several months, I interviewed people in Mau's life—friends, former co-workers, anyone who could vouch for his essential reliability. Some of them knew more about his captivity than others. Mau had evidently not been eager to talk when he was first released, and few had pressed him for details. It had seemed insensitive for them to ask too many questions—and besides, maybe not knowing was safer for everyone. But those I talked with could remember Mau disappearing one day in February and returning—shaken, scarred—many months later. “His gaze had changed,” Eduardo, a friend of Mau's, recalled. “He was always looking around, very watchful of everyone.”



My reporting that spring was frequently interrupted by a stream of messages from movie producers. Word had somehow gotten out in Hollywood, and multiple studios and production companies were suddenly vying to option my forthcoming story. Each of them had its own angle. The head of a large film studio in Spain, who had served as a U.S. ambassador under President Obama, appealed directly to *The Atlantic's* vice chair. A producer in Mexico claimed a loose personal connection to Mau—he had been friends with her college boyfriend, she said—but then referred to him by the wrong surname: Bermúdez.

How did all of these people know about my article? I had yet to write a word of the story—I still wasn't even sure there would be a story at all. And out of concern for Mau's safety, I'd told almost no one what I was working on. But when I asked the producers how they'd gotten my contact information, they all said the same thing: Mau had sent them.

Mau, for his part, seemed as mystified as I was. Reynolds was the only filmmaker he'd spoken with, he insisted, and the idea that he would be peddling this story around was lunacy. “I don't want to get killed!”

When I told Reynolds about the inquiries, he was not surprised. People in Hollywood talk, he reasoned; everyone pretends to be more connected than they are. Maybe Peña or his team had been hyping the project, or maybe the leak had come from

William Morris Endeavor, the agency that represented Reynolds. (Peña did not respond to requests for comment.)

But the prospect of competition clearly put Reynolds on edge. Soon after our conversation, he began pestering me to sign a contract giving him exclusive film rights to the story, and sending regular texts that sought to mask his anxiety with enthusiasm—*How's it going?? Just checking in :) So excited!*

THE MORNING AFTER Don Paco's speech, Mau and his team were awakened early. Hoods were placed over their heads, zip ties were attached to their wrists, and then everyone was loaded into vans like the ones that had first brought them there.

They drove for hours, Mau listening closely for clues about their location. City streets turned into freeways and then a winding, bumpy road. Eventually, the vans stopped, and Mau heard what sounded like a metal gate swing open. A few minutes later, he and his fellow prisoners were ushered out of the vans. When the hood was removed from his head, Mau was astonished by what he saw.

They were at some kind of vast, remote ranch in a mountainous region that Mau didn't recognize. Armed men in uniforms—could they really be police?—were directing traffic and confiscating weapons and phones, while men in cowboy hats and women in flamboyant dresses milled around drinking and chatting. The atmosphere was upbeat, almost festival-like. On a nearby stage, a group of musicians played brassy *banda* music; elsewhere, a gaggle of spectators admired a collection of parked monster trucks.

Mau's surprise turned to disbelief when he was escorted into an enormous gymnasium at the center of the property. In one section, magicians and clowns entertained young children. In another, a large board projected betting odds for the various tournament events, while men below clamored to place their wagers. Surveying the hundreds of attendees in the bleachers, Mau was shocked by how many people he recognized. The gym was filled with boldfaced names of Mexican society: celebrities, influencers, high-ranking politicians, TV-news anchors.

An emcee announced that it was time for the *sorteo*—a random drawing that would determine the first round of flag-football matchups. As Mau waited, Don Paco's girlfriend sidled up to him. "Luck is going to be very important here," she whispered. "You don't want to play against Sinaloa." Mau held his breath until the matchup was announced: La Unión Tepito would play Los Caballeros Templarios. "You got lucky," the woman said.

The flag-football games took place on a field outside the gymnasium. A referee briefly ran through the rules and blew a whistle, starting a 40-minute clock.

Mau realized quickly they were in trouble. Flag football is supposed to be a no-tackle, limited-contact sport. But their opponents were openly trying to maim them—punching, kicking, gouging—without any objection from the referees.

A sweetly acidic smell wafted toward the field, and
Mau asked his teammates what it was.
El Diablo was the first to answer. "That's blood."

After a few minutes, Mau called his teammates into a huddle. He told them to forget every rule he'd taught them. "There's no fair play in here," he said. If they were going to win, they'd have to play dirty.

The rest of the game was a violent scrum of chipped teeth and punctured skin. When the whistle blew, La Unión Tepito had defeated Los Caballeros Templarios, 14–7.

Spectators cheered while Mau and his teammates, bloody and panting, tended to their wounds. He barely noticed at first as the opposing team was led off the field, disappearing behind the gym. But then came a loud series of bangs that, amid all of the celebrating, sounded to Mau like firecrackers.

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WHEN SUMMER CAME, I set out with an *Atlantic* fact-checker to confirm the details of Mau's biography. With his account of the cartel tournament largely impossible to verify, Mau's story would have to hang on his trustworthiness as a source. If he was telling the truth about the small stuff, I figured, he was more likely to be a reliable narrator.

Mau seemed eager to help. He offered to dig up any documents we might need and promised to put me in touch with colleagues at the various NGOs on his résumé.

We started with his athletic credentials. Mau spoke often about his experience in the Olympics—how he'd been shaped by sports, and how competing had given him the necessary resilience to endure his captivity. An accomplished middle-distance runner, he sometimes lamented that he'd never made it to the Olympic podium—his final chance for a medal, in Tokyo, had been derailed by the pandemic and a devastating injury to his Achilles tendon.

On June 19, the fact-checker and I emailed officials at the Olympic committee in Colombia, the country for which Mau said he had competed. (His mother was a native Colombian, he

said, and he had dual citizenship.) We asked for confirmation that Mau had been on the team. The reply came back a few weeks later: They had no record of Mau competing on the track team. We scoured Colombia's published results from the past five Olympic Games, and came up similarly empty-handed.

When I called Mau, he sheepishly admitted that he had fudged some small details in our interviews to protect himself. He had actually competed for Mexico's Olympic team, he told me, not Colombia's, and he promised to share his accreditation documents to prove it. But he was worried that revealing this to a reporter would put him in danger. "The thing you need to understand about Mexico is that the press is very different here," he told me. Many reporters disregarded basic professional standards, Mau said, and some were actually on a cartel's payroll.

Besides, Mau was starting to wonder if the real threat might come from the government, not the gangs. Mexico's new president, Claudia Sheinbaum, was under enormous pressure from her voters and from the Trump administration to crack down on cartel violence. A former Olympic athlete from Mexico alleging an illuminati-style gathering where politicians mingled with murderous cartel leaders would not go unnoticed in the National Palace. Mau was consumed by images of the police dragging him from his apartment in the middle of the night and disappearing him again, this time for good.

He apologized repeatedly for lying. "I kept some information to myself," he explained. "I didn't want anything to happen to me. People around me are very much afraid. I'm afraid."

The fear in his voice sounded genuine. And I had to admit that his paranoia was understandable. What reason did he have to trust me, really?

We talked about various ways of ensuring his safety; he even said he might leave the country before the story came out. I told Mau that I would take every reasonable precaution, but that I needed him to be completely honest with me going forward. He agreed. Before we hung up, I asked him if there was anything else I should know.

"No, Mr. McKay," he said. "I promise."

THE NEXT SEVERAL ROUNDS of the tournament passed in a macabre blur—violent and frenzied, yet oddly methodical. Each game ended the same way, with Mau's motley team limping off the field in victory, and the losers disappearing behind the gymnasium. More firecrackers. More of that sweet, acidic smell.

As the tournament progressed, Mau became monomaniacally focused on doing what was necessary to win. With each round, the games got harder, and Mau got more ruthless—twisting limbs, stabbing at eyes, trying to inflict maximum pain with each illegal tackle. Some of the players he was assaulting were not even *sicarios* or drug traffickers—they were ordinary kidnapping victims like him. But his conscience had been numbed by a single-minded focus on staying alive.

By the time the championship game arrived, the sun was setting behind the distant mountains. The crowd on the sidelines had ballooned as word got around about La Unión Tepito's

unlikely run. Mau's team had beaten cartels with more money and more manpower, and he got the sense that La Unión was the Cinderella story of the tournament. Even the guards, previously gruff and dismissive, were now treating them with grudging respect.

Their final game would be against the Tláhuac cartel—a team of tall, quiet, wiry men. As Mau studied his opponents from a distance, Don Paco's girlfriend pulled him aside with some intel. She'd been watching Tláhuac all day, she said, and he should know that the players specialized in torture. "They are super dirty," she told him.

The game, as predicted, was brutal. Mau broke a rib and two fingers; other players lost teeth, causing blood to stream from their mouths. At one point, a Tláhuac player threw Palomino to the ground and tried to strangle him while the refs looked on indifferently and the crowd roared its approval.

When regulation ended, both teams were still scoreless, and the game entered overtime—the first team to score would win. Mau called a play that they'd practiced often during their training. Mammers faked a handoff to Palomino, who scampered furiously toward the end zone, drawing the defense away. Mau, left open, sprinted to the opposite side and caught a short touchdown pass from Mammers.

The whistle blew. The game was over.

For a moment, there was silence. Then the sidelines erupted—cheers, *banda* music, firecrackers. Mau collapsed to the ground, sobbing. It didn't feel like a celebration, but something closer to grief.

From the field, Mau was shepherded onto a stage in the gym, where he was greeted by a beaming Don Paco. Someone placed a gold-colored medal around Mau's neck. It felt heavy and ridiculous. For a moment, the two men stood side by side—the cartel boss and his champion—as the whooping, chanting crowd bathed them in applause.

Then, without warning, guards grabbed Mau and shoved him into a van. His bloody clothes were ripped off his body; a hood was placed back over his head. Dizzy and dehydrated, Mau slipped in and out of consciousness. Eventually, a door was opened, his hood was removed, and he was pushed out onto some pavement. The van peeled off.

It was dawn, and he was in a quiet slum that he'd never been to before. Stripped to his underwear, bruised, barefoot, and bleeding from his face, Mau stood and began to walk. The medal was still hanging around his neck.

IN THE DAYS AFTER my come-to-Jesus meeting with Mau, he labored to reassert his trustworthiness. He sent me documents, screenshots, and references to prove that he was who he claimed to be. He wanted me to know that he wasn't a dishonest person—that he'd lied only out of fear for his safety. But every piece of evidence he produced just raised more questions.

He sent me a medical report that he said was from his first doctor visit after his release from captivity; it showed high cholesterol and not much else. Where, I asked him, were the mentions of broken ribs, mangled fingers, and stripped fingernails? Mau seemed faintly amused by my question. "If you're looking for

something that says, ‘This guy was tortured by a cartel,’ it’s not going to say that,” he deadpanned. Fair enough.

The Olympic “accreditation” he’d promised to send, meanwhile, turned out to be a grainy photo of a laminated pass, attached to a lanyard, with his name printed on it and the familiar Olympic rings in the corner. At first glance it looked impressive enough. But when we shared the photo with a source at the International Olympic Committee, he said it was a guest credential—something issued to friends and family, not athletes. (By now I’d also heard back from the Mexican Olympic Committee, which said it had no record of Mau competing.)

Then there was Mau’s surreal Instagram profile. He had mentioned his account in passing more than once, but whenever I asked for a link, he would change the subject. Once I finally found it myself, I understood why. The account had nearly 400,000 followers but close to zero engagement, suggesting that his “fans” were mostly bots. The grid was filled with photos that seemed to slide in and out of reality: Mau posing with Mike Tyson, Mau posing with Lionel Messi, Mau shaking hands with Kofi Annan, and at least one apparently AI-generated image of a tuxedo-clad Mau at the Oscars.

There were plenty of Olympic photos, but those were confusing, too. Most of them were selfies, not action shots. In some pictures, he was in a Mexican uniform; in others, an American one. There was an image of a glossy 2008 spread from an English-language magazine in Beijing that featured a photo of a shirtless Mau alongside an article describing his preparations to compete for the Mexican national team—in volleyball.

There did appear to be one photo of Mau running in the Olympics. It was pinned to the top of his Instagram profile: a pack of middle-distance runners on a blue track, and a bright-red arrow hovering above one of them. But when I looked closer, I noticed that he was wearing blue instead of Mexico’s green and red. When I asked him about this over text, he insisted that the photo was from the 2016 Games in Rio, and that an Instagram filter had altered the color of his uniform. But a reverse image search quickly debunked this lie: The picture was from Paris 2024, and the runner was an Italian named Pietro Arese, who just happened to look a little like Mau from a distance.

Exasperated, I called Mau.

“I’ll be 100 percent honest with you,” he said, when I told him what I’d found. “I didn’t have a picture of myself running in the Olympics, so I posted that to keep people interested.”

“How can you possibly not have a photo of yourself running?” I demanded.

He hesitated. “The reason,” he finally said, “is because I didn’t run.”

The story tumbled out of him all at once, in a rush of righteous indignation—how he’d made it onto the national track team as an alternate in 2016; how he’d witnessed rampant corruption among Mexican Olympic officials, who sold off valuable credentials to politicians and businessmen instead of prioritizing athletes and training staff; how he’d been caught leaking evidence of bribery to the press and was blacklisted from competing.

Mau admitted, with some embarrassment, that his Instagram persona was embellished—but he insisted that it wasn’t as bad

as it looked. (Didn’t everyone exaggerate their accomplishments on social media?) If the Olympic committee claimed to have no record of him, he told me, that was only because it had punitively scrubbed his name from its records. “People saw me there,” he said. “They know me.” This was just what happened when you tried to blow the whistle on corruption in Mexico.

I found this explanation dubious, but it didn’t matter all that much. Mau’s Olympic record per se was not essential to the story. His repeated lying, though, posed a clear challenge to his credibility.

James Winston, meanwhile, was proving strangely difficult to get on the phone. The London-based aid worker had been one of Mau’s most persuasive validators. We had corresponded at length over email and WhatsApp, but every time I asked him for a phone interview, he was unreachable—traveling in Honduras, or en route to Gaza. He always promised he’d call as soon as he could. He never did.

Hoping to at least confirm Winston’s expertise, I asked him to connect me with some of his colleagues at the NGOs where he’d worked. He gave me email addresses for two people, both of whom responded with warm notes about Winston’s knowledge and dedication; when I asked if we could talk on the phone, they grew skittish. One said she was too afraid of the cartels to be quoted. Both stopped responding. A subsequent Google search revealed that the websites for the organizations in their email domains didn’t exist. Both URLs led to identical “under construction” Squarespace pages. When I asked Winston for his LinkedIn profile, he said he would send it to me, but never did.

A few days later, however, I found a page for a “James M. Winston” that matched his purported résumé—and had been created that same month. The profile was sparsely populated, and parts of it appeared to have been written by a non-native English speaker. When we checked with the institutions he claimed to have an affiliation with—the London School of Economics, the UN Refugee Agency, R4V—none of them had any record of him. The James Winston with whom I’d been corresponding for months seemed not to exist.

BY AUGUST, I was ready to give up. Investigating Mau’s story felt like trying to clutch an ice cube—every time I attempted to grab hold of it too tightly, it slipped out of my grasp.

Only one thing was keeping me from walking away from the story: I’d found Mamers.

At the outset of my reporting, Mau had told me that he was in touch with his *sicario* teammate—the two men had a soldiers-after-the-war bond that transcended their many differences. At first Mamers didn’t want to talk with me, but Mau finally persuaded him to give me a brief FaceTime interview. His account of the cartel games overlapped with Mau’s in ways that were hard to dismiss. He was nervous, but said he could go into more detail if we met in person. I had to decide if this story, whose chief narrator had a gaping credibility problem, was worth a trip to Mexico.

On August 14, Robert Reynolds texted me in a characteristic flurry of exclamation points. “How’s it going?” he wrote. “So

excited for progress!! Michael Peña just called me. He's really excited about this."

Maybe it was the seduction of a Hollywood deal. Maybe I just felt like I'd gone too far to turn back now. But seeing this story through felt like the only option. I booked a flight to Mexico City.

I LANDED LATE on the night of August 24, and found the driver *The Atlantic* had hired waiting for me outside baggage claim. He was short and quiet, wearing a baseball cap and a serious expression. As we pulled away from the airport, he locked the doors and merged onto a wide, well-lit highway.

In preparing for the trip, I'd encountered a strange kind of narrative confusion when it came to American perceptions of Mexico City. As a tourist destination, the city had never been hotter; travel websites and influencers hyped its food scene and museums. At the same time, the Trump administration and its allies, seeking to justify a maximalist immigration crackdown, had cast the city as the apocalyptic capital of a failed state. The day after I arrived, Stephen Miller would make headlines by declaring, with his usual brittle certainty, that the Mexican government was "run by criminal cartels."

There were legitimate reasons to believe that the Mexican capital was growing more dangerous. The broad-daylight assassination of the mayor's aides in May had rattled the city's political class and awakened fears that Mexico City was no longer considered a neutral zone in the cartel wars. Sales of armored vehicles in the city were up, and private-security details were becoming more common.

The Atlantic wasn't taking any chances. Because the story involved cartels, my editors insisted on certain precautions. I would be traveling around the city with the private driver and accompanied, most of the time, by a fixer. A photographer would join us for some of the reporting, and when we ventured into neighborhoods considered especially risky, a security guard would come along. I'd shared my location with my editors on

my phone and agreed to check in every three hours. I couldn't decide if this was prudent or ridiculous.

As we drove toward my hotel in the verdant neighborhood of La Condesa, I watched the city roll past the van window: taquerias still open at midnight, couples walking dogs, clusters of young people outside bars lit with fairy lights. I thought about the Mexican TikTokers who made videos mocking American tourists for posting breathless dispatches about how "nice" and "safe" Mexico City felt—wide-eyed foreigners marveling that the streets were paved and the toilets flushed.

The next morning, I met my fixer, Ulises, in my hotel's restaurant. He was impossible to miss: 6 foot 4, burly, and jovial, with a stubbly beard and a roguish demeanor. I'd been warned by a Mexican reporter before my trip that some local journalists resented being called "fixers," but Ulises told me he didn't mind. Fixing had been good business for him. And besides, why take yourself so seriously? "My secret is that I'm a shitty journalist," he said, "but I know all the best restaurants in Mexico City."

Over breakfast, I asked what he made of Mau's story. He shrugged. He'd seen terrible things in his years as a cartel tour guide for foreign journalists, so he was open to the possibility that Mau's story was true. But he also seemed uncomfortable with the image of his country that Mau was conveying.

"Mexico isn't the Third World," he said. "I mean, look." He gestured toward the window, where a clean, tree-lined street stretched past the hotel. Cyclists weaved among cars; a woman in workout gear jogged by with headphones. "Isn't it scary?" he said sarcastically.

There were parts of the country where the cartels had enormous power, he said. But it wasn't accurate to suggest that Mexico as a whole was a dystopian gangland, or that the government was simply a puppet of organized crime.

I appreciated Ulises's skepticism, but I wasn't ready to write off Mau just yet. I would sit with him, in his own city, and let him tell his story one last time.

WE DROVE TO a quiet street in Ciudad de los Deportes and met Mau on the ground floor of his building. He looked as he did in his Instagram photos—handsome and fit, with a well-maintained coil of curly hair and a raglan T-shirt clinging to his shoulders and chest. But his smile was uneasy. As we climbed the stairs to his apartment, I noticed dark half-moons of sweat blooming under his arms.

"I'm nervous," he admitted. He'd spoken with Reynolds, who had urged him to be totally honest. Mau assured me that he would be: "I don't have anything to hide."

We entered a sunlit one-bedroom, and Mau and I took seats on perpendicular couches. Ulises and the photographer, Adriana, remained on the room's perimeter, quiet observers. Mau looked almost small sitting there, his muscular shoulders slouched, his hands fidgeting in his lap, a restive expression on his face.

I asked him to tell me the story of his kidnapping and captivity again, from beginning to end. The beats were familiar by now, and as I listened to him talk, I found myself thinking about all the people who benefited from narratives of cartel violence: American politicians; Mexican politicians; the journalists who hired Ulises to

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help them produce their sensational dispatches from narco land; the Hollywood executives monetizing movie treatments; the cartels themselves, who thrived on the fear. I almost pitied Mau. Even if his account wasn't entirely true, so many others were profiting from stories like this—why shouldn't he get a piece?

After finishing his account, Mau turned to what had become a persistent theme in our conversations: the metastasizing corruption in Mexico. He talked about the large number of people who were currently missing. When he rode the bus, the ads on the digital screens used to be for cellphone plans and soft drinks. Now they were almost exclusively for missing persons—grainy photos and cash rewards and phone numbers to call.

At my request, Mau FaceTimed his mother. I had hoped to interview her in person, but she lived too far away. She appeared on-screen in a modest living room, an older woman with careful makeup and a tight, anxious smile, sitting on a couch pressed up against a bare wall. I sat next to Mau as he held the phone, and he translated her narration of his disappearance from her perspective.

Recounting the story was clearly painful for her. At several points, she broke down in tears and had to stop, dabbing at her eyes with a tissue while Mau murmured reassurances in Spanish. She described the first call from the kidnappers, the male voice demanding money, the impossible deadline, the panic of scrambling to find the cash.

She also said something I'd never heard in Mau's many accounts of the story. The kidnappers, she told me, had demanded nearly 1 million pesos, or about \$60,000. To cover the payment, she said, Mau's older brother had been forced to sell his house.

Mau had mentioned before that his family had made extortion payments, but he'd always presented this as a minor detail. The money was not, in his telling, what saved him; it was his own triumph on the football field. Taken aback, I asked her to repeat herself. I glanced at Ulises, who had an inscrutable look on his face.

After we hung up, Ulises spoke. "That's a good brother," he told Mau. "He saved you, man." Mau seemed to stiffen at the comment.

Mau had promised to take us to the street where he'd been kidnapped. Before we left, he went to use the bathroom, and for the first time I looked around the apartment.

The walls were crowded with Olympic paraphernalia—selfies of Mau in branded warm-ups, medals hanging from nails, what appeared to be a framed letter from the International Olympic Committee certifying his participation in the Games. It was all perplexing. Hadn't he already admitted to me that he had never actually competed, that his Olympian persona was a social-media performance? He lived here alone—whom was he trying to convince with all this stuff on the walls? In the kitchen, a framed race bib hung near the refrigerator, the kind marathon runners pin to their shirts. To my surprise, it said "Bermúdez"—the last name that the Mexican movie producer had used for Mau. I made a note to ask him about it later.

When we got into the van, Mau blanched. This, he said, was exactly like the vehicle he'd been stuffed into when he was taken. As we drove, he warned us that the neighborhood we

were headed to was known "cartel territory"—we would have to be careful. But the street he directed the driver to was in a gentrifying enclave of expats and hipsters with man buns.

We got out, and Mau began narrating his kidnapping, pointing at various landmarks like a tour guide. But nothing about the scene he described made sense here. The street was too narrow and crowded with parked cars to accommodate the five vans he claimed had pulled up to snatch him and dozens of migrants. The block was lined with security cameras and bustling with pedestrians. In the 30 minutes we spent there, I saw multiple police cars roll by.

I kept thinking back to the conversation with Mau's mother. She certainly didn't seem like an accomplice in any hoax. Everything about her distress—the wobble in her voice, the tears—had felt sincere. While Adriana led a reluctant-looking Mau to a sunny corner of the street to take his portrait, I pulled Ulises aside and asked what he made of the mother's testimony. Maybe Mau was embellishing his story, I said, but it certainly seemed to me that his family really had made those extortion payments.

Ulises responded by asking what I knew about "self-kidnapping." The practice—people staging their own abduction to extract money from relatives—had become such an epidemic in Mexico, he told me, that the government had begun cracking down with tougher sentences and public-service announcements warning that it was a serious crime.

"I think he stole that money," Ulises said quietly.

I looked over at Mau, who had dropped his coquettish act and was now preening for the camera. I wondered, for the first time, if I was dealing with a very different kind of man than I had allowed myself to believe.

I MET MAU'S GIRLFRIEND, Nancy, at a café near the clinic where she worked as a doctor. She was slim and pretty, with wavy dyed-red hair and an assortment of tasteful bracelets adorning her wrists. She'd grown up in the city in an upper-middle-class family, gone to private school, and spent a year living in the U.S. as a teenager, where she honed her English, before returning home for medical school at one of the country's most respected public universities.

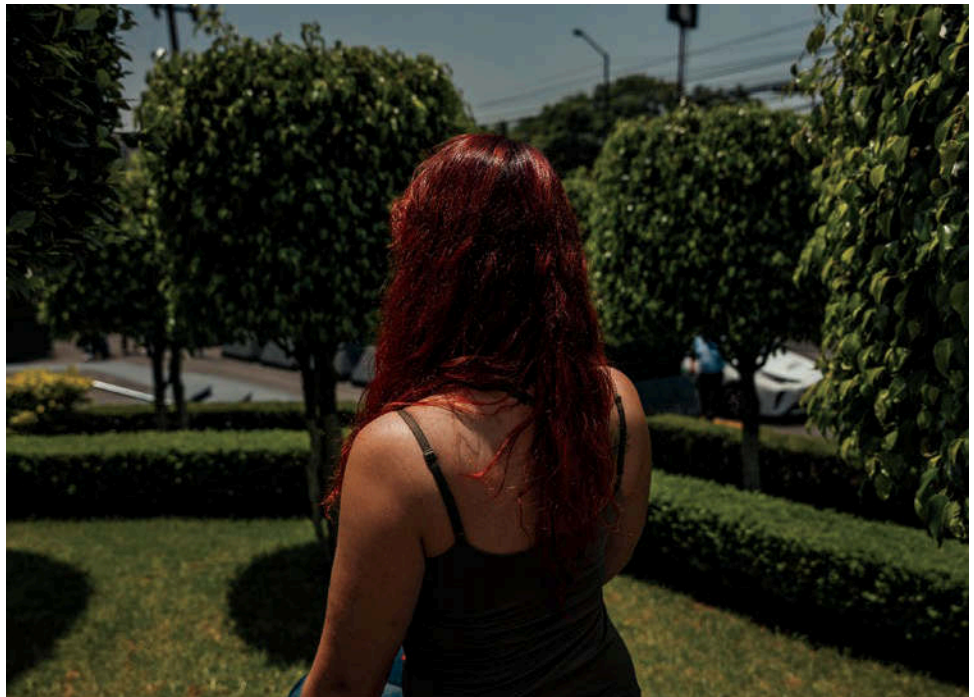
She told me she'd met Mau on Bumble a year earlier. She was drawn by the impressive claims in his bio—that he'd visited at



ADRIANA LOUREIRO FERNÁNDEZ FOR THE ATLANTIC

RIGHT: *Mau's girlfriend, Nancy, a doctor who met him on Bumble, said her view of Mexico was transformed by hearing about the cartel tournament.*

OPPOSITE PAGE: *Images of missing persons, many of whom have been kidnapped by the cartels, are omnipresent in Mexico City.*



least 100 countries and spoke seven languages. “I was captured by that,” said Nancy, an aspiring globe-trotter herself.

Early in their relationship, Mau told her that he’d been kidnapped by a cartel, but he didn’t talk much about his captivity at first. Details trickled out over time—the torture, the tournament, the VIP audience. Once, while she was watching her favorite news anchor, Mau pointed at the TV and said, “He was there.” She was shocked—she had always trusted the anchor’s reporting, “How could he be there? How could he know that, and not tell about it?” she remembered thinking. On another night, a well-known politician appeared on TV, and Mau told her that he, too, had attended the tournament.

Nancy came to feel as though she didn’t know her own city, her own country. The Mexico of her childhood had been replaced by shadowy figures and conspiracies of silence—a malevolence that lurked in places she’d passed a thousand times. She recalled driving one afternoon with Mau in the passenger seat when he’d suddenly tensed up. He told her this was the street where he’d been abducted.

“Here?” she’d exclaimed, in disbelief.

I asked her where it was. The neighborhood she named was miles away from the spot that Mau had taken us to.

It was clear to me that Nancy was genuinely in love with Mau. (When I conferred later with Ulises and Adriana, they agreed.) She said she was glad to be there for him as he processed the trauma of his captivity. They had built a tender and adventurous life together. She traveled with him around the world, and nursed his injuries. (One day, as she was running her fingers along his cheek, she felt the ridge of an old fracture that had never properly healed.) She also helped him work through old grievances with his family. Mau had never gotten along with them, she said. His mother had favored his brother, doting on him while treating Mau as an afterthought. “His mother is not very nice to him,”

Nancy told me. She had not met his family and didn’t want to: “I can’t stand that someone is that mean to him.”

I asked Nancy what Mau did for a living—a question I’d somehow never gotten a clear answer to.

She responded as if the answer were obvious: He was a runner for the U.S. Olympic team. She went on to gush about his athletic accomplishments—how most runners retired well before their late 30s, and how, defying the odds, he was determined to make it to the Summer Games in Los Angeles. “If he can get to 2028, that would be almost a record at his age!” As her eyes gleamed with pride, my stomach sank.

Before we left, I asked Nancy what she thought about Mau’s prospective Hollywood deal. She said that Mau had told her all about Reynolds, and Peña, and the development of the script. Ulises asked: Would she be a character in the movie?

Nancy laughed self-consciously and cast her eyes downward. “Well, I don’t know,” she said, clearly embarrassed by how much the idea pleased her. “He told me yeah, I might.”

ONE THING THAT Mau had told me was undeniable: The missing-persons posters were omnipresent in Mexico City. Once you saw them, they were impossible to miss—on buses, on street corners, at subway entrances. At the center of the city, there was a traffic rotary known locally as “the roundabout of the disappeared,” plastered with hundreds of faces. The government, eager to project an image of calm and security, had begun scraping the posters off the wall, but mothers returned every day to put them back up. More than 130,000 people are currently listed as missing in Mexico, a number that has roughly tripled in the past decade.

One evening, Ulises, Adriana, and I drove to an upscale shopping mall, where Mamers had suggested we meet. I had



messaged him on WhatsApp earlier that day to ask if I could bring a photographer. He agreed on the condition that she not take pictures of his face—for a former cartel hit man risking his life to tell his story, anonymity was essential for survival. To keep a low profile, he told me, he'd be wearing a hat and sunglasses.

But when I spotted him as we descended the escalator into the mall's atrium, I almost laughed out loud: He was dressed like a caricature of a tough-guy *sicario*—oversize sunglasses, a tight blue tank top stretched across his bulging chest, a gold chain around his neck.

We sat down at a table outside a coffee shop, and I asked Mamers to tell his version of the story from the beginning. He related the events in a steady voice, without embroidery or visible self-regard. He recalled meeting Mau in the prison for the first time and taking pity on him—a soft, bewildered naïf who clearly had no idea what kind of world he'd been dropped into. He described the members of their team: El Diablo, the taxi driver, the perverted old lawyer. He recounted the day of the tournament, the gymnasium in the mountains, the bands and the monster trucks and the VIPs in the stands.

"People from different political parties, different criminal organizations in the same place hanging out," he said at one point, switching briefly to English. "I was like, *What the fuck?*"

I asked him why he was telling his story now—wasn't he afraid?

Mamers said he'd taken precautions. He had moved to a different part of the city and grown a beard to avoid recognition. He was out of the cartel game, he told me, and now worked in construction. He wanted a different life.

He'd agreed to the interview largely out of loyalty to Mau. Befriending an innocent person who had been victimized by a cartel had forced him to reckon with his own complicity. For years, he said, he had done his employers' violent bidding without giving it much thought. Watching Mau endure it had unsettled him—and he wanted people to know what was going on in his country.

"I'm proud to be Mexican," he said, "but Mexico is sick."

When the meeting ended, we said goodbye to Mamers and walked out of the mall in a quiet daze.

Adriana broke the silence. "That was a mindfuck," she said. Ulises nodded. "I think," he said carefully, as though he couldn't quite believe what he was about to say, "that maybe something did happen to them."

I agreed. Whatever else was going on with Mau, Mamers's story seemed too detailed, too internally consistent, too mundanely specific to dismiss as a fabrication for my benefit. When I checked in with my editor that night, I told him that I wasn't quite so sure anymore that this was all a hoax.

Before going to bed, I started watching *The Maltese Falcon* in my hotel room. I felt a certain self-aggrandizing kinship with Humphrey Bogart's Sam Spade as he groped his way from one deception to another—each revelation rearranging the pieces without clarifying the picture, the truth always just out of reach.

But I couldn't shake the sneaking suspicion—though I tried to repress it—that in Mau's story, I was not the shrewd, enterprising detective, but a mark.

LA UNIÓN TEPITO sprouted in 2009 from a massive open-air market in one of Mexico City's most dangerous neighborhoods. It presented itself at first as a kind of neighborhood watch, in which young men from Tepito provided security, for a fee, to local vendors worried about larger cartels. The arrangement grew into a profitable protection racket, and La Unión Tepito soon expanded into narcotics and kidnapping. Ulises had told me that we'd need to be careful when we visited the market—no loitering, no pictures. But as we wound our way through the crowded maze of vendor stalls hawking counterfeit Gucci bags and black-market smartphones, I saw few obvious signs of organized crime. It wasn't until we slipped some cash to a shopkeeper who let us climb a hidden ladder in the back to a secluded rooftop overlooking the market's expanse that Ulises spoke freely: Those men zipping through the market on motorized scooters, he told me, were likely employees of the cartel.

Through one of Ulises's contacts, we'd arranged to meet a low-level employee of La Unión Tepito, a young man who asked me to call him Pedro. We sat with him at a plastic table in an alleyway a few blocks from the market. He wore a flamboyant tracksuit embroidered with a gold dragon that belied his flat, affectless demeanor. He told me he'd started working for

“the organization”—the preferred term for the cartel among its members—when he was about 16, following his father, a leader in La Unión, into the family business. He was now in his early 20s and served in a supervisory role.

I asked Pedro how a typical cartel kidnapping worked. He walked me through the logistics in a matter-of-fact monotone, as if he were explaining how to assemble a piece of IKEA furniture.

“First you study the person who is going to be kidnapped, then you go do the job,” he said. “They’re taken to a safe house. The family is contacted and a ransom is demanded. If the family doesn’t agree, then they start with the mutilation until the family complies.”

Mutilation? I glanced at Ulises to make sure I’d heard his translation correctly. He gave me a look that suggested I not seek elaboration.

I decided to tell Pedro why I was there. I’d heard a story, I told him—without using names or excessive identifying information—about a man who’d been kidnapped by La Unión and forced to compete in an intercartel sports tournament. I painted the picture for him as Mau had painted it for me—cartel bosses from Sinaloa and Jalisco in the stands, politicians and celebrities placing bets.

Pedro, who had been stone-faced throughout our interview, smirked. “Like a movie,” he said.

He told me that he had never heard of such a tournament, and that it went against everything he knew about how the cartel operated. Kidnapping, he explained, was a risky business. Hold on to a victim for too long, and the chances that he escapes or someone comes looking for him grow. La Unión rarely kept a victim for any length of time—if the extortion payments didn’t come, they’d simply get rid of him. Scooping up scores of people and holding them for months in some kind of remote training facility would be too dangerous.

As we made our way back to the hotel, my phone buzzed with an email notification from someone in New York. After I’d seen the Bermúdez race bib hanging on Mau’s wall, I’d done another round of Google searches on his name. Buried in an American court database was an opaque legal filing suggesting that a man named Mauricio Morales Bermúdez was involved in some kind of criminal case in Mexico. On a whim, I’d sent cold emails to several of the people named in the document. Now one of them wanted to talk.

When I reached him by phone later that day, he asked for anonymity to discuss ongoing proceedings. Then he told me the story.

IN 2010, according to several sources and allegations made in court documents, Mauricio Morales Bermúdez opened the Mexican office of the Non-Violence Project Foundation, a Switzerland-based nonprofit best known for its “knotted gun” logo. The foundation, with offices in multiple countries and a dazzling slate of celebrity “ambassadors” (Yoko Ono, Paul McCartney, Lionel Messi), made for an impressive résumé line. It also gave Mau entry into an elite segment of Mexican society.

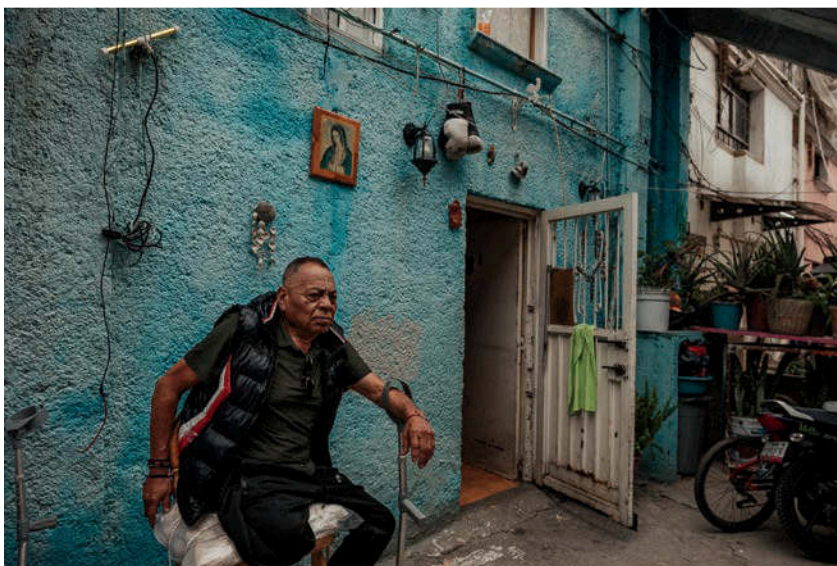
Through a fundraising auction for Non-Violence Project Mexico in 2013, Mau met Alejandro Martínez, a wealthy, well-connected labor-union leader in Mexico City. Martínez, a trained musician and lifelong Beatles obsessive, was intrigued by some of the rare items up for bid: guitars signed by Eric Clapton and George Harrison, a ukulele bearing McCartney’s name, and—most tantalizing—a T-shirt that had belonged to John Lennon, signed by all four Beatles. Martínez submitted bids on multiple items, and won more of them than he’d expected. Soon after that, he received an email from Mau, who introduced himself as the organization’s director.

In 2015, Mau invited Martínez to an event in Arizona on Super Bowl weekend. There would be a flag-football exhibition featuring celebrities and former NFL players, and then, as a valued donor, Martínez would attend the big game on Sunday. Martínez, thrilled, accepted the invitation.

OPPOSITE PAGE: *Mamers, who describes himself as a former hit man, corroborated Mau’s account of competing for their lives together while imprisoned by the cartel.*

RIGHT: *“Pedro,” a member of La Unión Tepito cartel, told grisly stories of kidnapping and mutilation—but said he’d never heard of any cartel tournament.*





The area around the Tepito market, in Mexico City, is largely controlled by La Unión Tepito cartel.



The exhibition was as advertised. Miguel Herrera, then the coach of Mexico's national soccer team, ran plays in the huddle; TV personalities from Univision and Fox Sports posed for photos with fans. Mau moved easily among them all—hugging athletes, greeting journalists, navigating the game as if the stars were old friends. Martínez would later remember thinking that Mau was a natural salesman. He even joked that Mau should come work for him.

But when Martínez tried to claim his Super Bowl ticket, he was told there wasn't one waiting for him; he ended up having to watch the game from a bar. He flew back to Mexico livid, and wrote to the organization to complain.

A few days later, Martínez began receiving contrite emails from an executive at Non-Violence Project Mexico. She apologized profusely for the Super Bowl mishap and said the organization wanted to make it up to him. Soon Yoko Ono herself was emailing him, on behalf of the foundation, offering him a special investment opportunity, available to VIP donors, that would guarantee a return of 50 percent.

The pitch was seductive. The union would receive not only a sizable return, but also anti-violence workshops for its members, and an array of perks for Martínez: a trip to the World Cup, concert tickets, and meet and greets with the foundation's celebrity "ambassadors." It sounded like an incredible deal. Martínez and Ono both signed the contract, and Martínez wired \$200,000 to the organization.

At first, the arrangement worked as promised. Trainers led workshops for Martínez's union in Mexico. Packages of memorabilia arrived—soccer jerseys signed by Pelé, Maradona, and Messi; NFL helmets covered in the signatures of Super Bowl MVPs; game balls from European championship matches. Martínez traveled with his family to a concert in California where McCartney and the Rolling Stones played on the same bill, and also got tickets to multiple Super Bowls.

Martínez ended up wiring about \$700,000 to the organization. But the promised financial returns never materialized.

When Martínez began asking pointed questions about how the nonprofit planned to produce such returns, he got evasive answers about corporate sponsors and VIP boxes donated by FIFA.

Eventually, the perks dried up. The workshops ceased. In Russia for the World Cup, Martínez discovered that his hotel reservation was missing and his game tickets weren't available under his name. By the time he flew home, he no longer trusted anyone associated with the organization.

He hired a team of lawyers and private investigators. Together, they pieced together an elaborate—and almost comically audacious—scheme. Those emails signed by Yoko Ono? They weren't written by her; her signature on the contract was a forgery. That shirt signed by all of the Beatles? Almost certainly fake. And the union money Martínez had wired for its "investment"? It had landed in a bank account controlled by Mauricio Morales Bermúdez.

Martínez's lawyers contacted the Non-Violence Project Foundation in Switzerland to alert the group that it had a con

man in its midst. But instead of offering to help sort things out, foundation executives sent back a series of strange, contradictory responses. (The foundation later disavowed some of the people who had written to Martínez, and said that key signatures and emails appeared to be fake. The foundation did not respond to detailed questions from *The Atlantic*, but in a statement it said that Bermúdez was never an official employee and that Non-Violence Project Mexico was a “separate and independent” nonprofit entity.)

The more Martínez’s lawyers dug into the foundation, the more suspicious he became that it might be involved in Mau’s scam. The fake employees who had pitched the investment had all somehow managed to use official @nonviolence.com email addresses. Some celebrities featured on the foundation’s website, meanwhile, said they had not authorized the use of their names or images. And an outfit calling itself the Non-Violence Project USA had been linked in press reports to a Medicaid-fraud scheme.

Martínez filed a legal complaint on behalf of the union naming both Mau and Non-Violence Project Mexico. Mau, seeming to catch wind of the investigation, left the country. For several months, according to private investigators hired by Martínez, he traveled around Europe, apparently using some of the union money to cover the cost of his jet-setting.

Finally, Mau came back to Mexico, where authorities turned up outside his apartment with a warrant. They arrested him for fraud on February 9, 2023—the same day he would later tell his friends, his girlfriend, and me that he had been kidnapped by a cartel. According to legal records, he spent 18 months in prison awaiting trial; he was released after promising to repay hundreds of thousands of dollars, and to cooperate in a fraud investigation against the Non-Violence Project Foundation. (In its statement, the foundation denied responsibility for the alleged fraud and said that it is “not a party to any legal proceedings” connected to Martínez’s claims against Bermúdez. Martínez declined to comment.)

Mau did his time at Reclusorio Sur, a men’s penitentiary near the mountains on the southern edge of Mexico City. Also awaiting trial in the prison was a small-time businessman who’d been accused of fraud and the theft of a bicycle. His full name was Edgar Omar González Giffard, but most people inside the prison called him Mamers.

ON MY LAST DAY in Mexico City, I asked Mau to meet me at a park near his apartment. Given the conversation I knew we needed to have, it felt unwise to go back to his home. We chose a concrete table with a built-in chessboard, surrounded by trees and low shrubs. Mau wore a yellow track jacket with ROCKY stitched across the chest.

Shortly after we sat down, I pulled up his mug shot on my phone. Turning the screen toward him, I asked, “Is this you?”

Mau didn’t flinch or scoff or reflexively start making denials. He just paused as his eyes scanned the image. I could almost see him processing this new development—testing the angles, deciding how to respond.

Determined to maintain control of the conversation, I plowed ahead, reading off the details that accompanied the photo: the fraud complaint, the sums of money, the name on the arrest warrant.

“You were arrested the same day you told everyone you were taken by the cartel, right?” I asked.

Unflustered, he began to tell me a new story. Yes, he said, he’d been arrested—but my timeline was wrong. He’d been arrested in 2022, a year before he was taken by the cartel.

And the arrest warrant that stated clearly he’d been taken into custody in February 2023? I asked.

It must have been doctored, he told me. Very powerful people were involved. He was the victim of a conspiracy—caught between a politically connected union and a corrupt international NGO whose bidding he had been forced to do. He said he could explain everything, but it would have to be off the record—he couldn’t be sure of his safety otherwise. I heard the familiar refrain of his pitch returning: *What you don’t understand about Mexico ...*

But I was tired of Mau’s stories.

I asked him if he had stolen the money his family had paid for his ransom.

“No, obviously not,” he said.

And James Winston—he wasn’t a real person, was he?

Mau insisted that he was.

Realizing that we weren’t going to get anywhere, I stood up to leave. Before we parted, I asked if he could send me the case file from his arrest—the documents that would establish the timeline and basic facts of what he’d been charged with.

“I don’t know, man,” he said. “I need to talk to my lawyer.”

Something in his demeanor had changed. It was as if he’d flicked off a switch. The likable, self-effacing man I’d been talking with for months had withdrawn, and in his place was someone colder, more distant. His mark had gotten wise—it was time to move on.

I said goodbye and made my way up the hill toward the park’s exit, looking back for one last glimpse at Mau. He was heading in the opposite direction, shoulders slightly hunched, staring down at his phone, his thumbs moving quickly across the screen.

WHEN I GOT BACK to my hotel that night, I called Robert Reynolds to break the news that the story he’d wanted so badly to adapt for the screen wasn’t true after all. He sounded genuinely shocked.

“Wow,” Reynolds said, almost as if to himself. “He seemed like such a good guy.”

Did he? I found myself wondering about that now. Had Mau’s performance really been so compelling? Or was his story just exciting enough, just potentially profitable enough, just flattering enough to American sensibilities and preconceptions, that Reynolds and I and everyone else had simply wanted too badly to believe it?

In retrospect, it seemed absurd that I’d ever taken Mau so seriously. As more of the pieces fell into place following my discovery of his arrest and imprisonment, he looked less like a heroic survivor or even a mastermind hoax artist, and more like



Mau, photographed in August at the spot where he said he'd been kidnapped by La Unión Tepito

a low-level scammer with a talent for improvisation. That email from the high-ranking UN official asking Reynolds for Killers tickets for a beloved volunteer? It was signed by Filippo Grandi, then the UN high commissioner for refugees, whose office confirmed that it was a forgery. (Mau denied writing it himself.) Those messages from movie

producers who had somehow caught wind of the story I was writing? It turns out Mau was stringing along multiple filmmakers—the producer in Mexico told me they were on the verge of signing an “exclusive” contract with him.

And yet, I still couldn't say definitively that he'd invented his account out of whole cloth. In the course of my reporting, I learned about interprison sports tournaments, including a football competition, organized by the Mexico City penitentiary system. It is well established that the cartels have a presence in the country's prisons—was it possible that Mau's fantastical story of heroism and life-and-death stakes was rooted in his own less cinematic, less blood-drenched experience as a regular prison inmate? Then there was the mystery of Mamers's “disappearance.” Late last year, Mamers went dark on social media and, Mau said, stopped responding to his messages. My own attempts to contact him were also unsuccessful. Mau

told Reynolds that his old friend was dead, most likely taken out by a cartel. Maybe he'd just gone to ground. In a country with 130,000 missing people, I suspected I would never know for sure.

In the months after I left Mexico, the news in my own country would be dominated by ICE raids and mass deportations—a hard-line immigration agenda built on the stories we are told about crime and migrants and cartel bosses. When the death of a drug lord in February set off a brutal wave of cartel attacks, the United States canceled flights to resort cities and issued shelter-in-place alerts for Americans in Mexico. Mau's account of the cartel Olympics fit neatly into the governing narrative of the age, one that imagines a permanent, untamable dystopia just beyond America's southern border.

Some stories take on a life of their own because they show how things really are. Others spread because they tell us what we already believe. And sometimes a story that's too good to be true is just that.

But a good story is a hard thing to kill.

Two weeks after my return from Mexico City, Reynolds called me.

“Dude,” he said breathlessly. “I just talked to Michael Peña.” He had filled the actor in on the latest developments—Mau's deception, my investigation, the whole ridiculous misadventure—and Peña saw potential. “He said he loves this even more than the original story!” The movie was back on. *A*

McKay Coppins is a staff writer at The Atlantic.

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What I saw at Jeff Bezos's Campfire retreat

AND NOTHING MATTERS



By Noah Hawley | Illustration by Tim Enthoven



At the end of Paul Thomas Anderson's 2007 movie, *There Will Be Blood*, Daniel Day-Lewis's oil-baron character, old now and richer than Croesus, beats Paul Dano's preacher to death with a bowling pin. Dano's Eli Sunday, a nemesis of Day-Lewis's Daniel Plainview during his seminal, wealth-building years, has come to sell Plainview the oil-rich land that he once coveted. But Plainview doesn't need the land anymore, because—as he explains in one of the most famous monologues in modern cinema—he has sucked out all the oil hidden beneath it from an adjoining property, like a milkshake.

Desperate for money, Eli begs for a loan. Instead, Plainview chases him around a bowling alley and murders him with great enthusiasm. Once it's over, a butler comes to see what all the noise was about. "I'm finished," Plainview yells.

No matter how many times I watch that movie, and I watch it a lot, I have never once taken those words to mean *I'm done for*. *There will now be consequences for my actions*. Quite the opposite: They mean that Plainview has completed his journey, through the acquisition of wealth and power, to a realm outside the moral universe. He's finished, in other words, pretending that the rules of human society apply to him.

In 2018, I was a guest at Jeff Bezos's Campfire retreat in Santa Barbara, California. It's an annual event in which the Amazon founder invites 80-plus guests—celebrities, artists, intellectuals, and anyone else he thinks is interesting—to spend three nights at a private resort. I had recently been approached by Amazon about moving my film-and-television business over from Disney, and although I had declined (or maybe *because* I had declined), Bezos's team invited me to Campfire, perhaps keen to impress me with the power of his reach.

On a warm October Thursday, a fleet of private jets was dispatched to airports in Van Nuys and New York to shepherd guests to Santa Barbara in style. At that point I had only a vague sense of who else was coming—famous people, rich people, influential

people, and me. A guest list, I was told, would be given to us once we arrived. Families were invited; an on-site nanny would be provided *for each child*.

So my wife and I got our two children from Austin to Los Angeles and took a 45-minute jet ride north, with a television mogul and a comedian on board. Bezos had bought out the entire Biltmore resort for the weekend, as well as the beach club across the street. He had brought in a security firm from Las Vegas to ensure our safety and privacy. Even the weather felt expensive, and when we were shown to our rooms, the designer gift bags we found were filled with luxury goods.

Each morning, we gathered in a lecture hall to hear presentations. If you've ever seen a TED Talk, you understand the format. The year I went, a sitting Supreme Court justice was interviewed, and a neurologist talked about technological advances in prosthetics. In the afternoons and evenings, we were encouraged to exchange ideas over drinks and four-course meals, with no set purpose—to network, in other words, with some of the most rarefied talent on Earth. The most common question I heard was "Why am I here?"

"Why am I here?" asked the 1980s hair-metal singer. "Why am I here?" asked the Pulitzer Prize-winning novelist, the famous anthropologist, the presidential historian. Only the movie stars and the billionaires didn't ask: They had done this kind of thing before. It turns out there is a circuit of idea festivals. Many tech billionaires host one, and if you find yourself on the right list, you can spend much of the year traveling the world, eating Wagyu, and discussing how to make the world a better place with the most famous talk-show host in history.

That's how the weekend started. Here's how it ended: My wife broke her wrist slipping on wet grass, and both children and I came down with hand, foot, and mouth disease. This is not a joke. One of us went home with her arm in a sling; the other

three developed itchy, painful red blisters all over our faces and extremities. If you're looking for a sign from God as to whether hanging out with the richest man on Earth is right for you, pay attention when he sends you not one plague, but two. Suffice it to say we have never been back to Campfire, nor have we ever been invited.

At drinks on the second night, the head of a major talent agency asked me what I thought of the weekend. I said, "I've spent my whole career trying to figure out how the world works. I didn't realize I could just come here and ask the people who ran it." On some level I was kidding. The lead singer of an alt-country band didn't run the world, nor did a noted author who would later be accused of impropriety. But finding myself at that resort by exclusive invitation, I now knew exactly what people meant when they talked about the elite.

Sitting in the lecture hall, pencils out, listening to a famous chef explain his humanitarian work, it was easy to feel like the solution to the world's problems lay within our grasp. And yet, looking around at faces I had only ever seen in a magazine or on-screen, I had an unsettling revelation: This is the hubris of accomplishment. To be declared a genius at one thing is to begin to believe you are a genius at everything.

Here we were, 80 individuals with a combined net worth that was greater than a small city's yet infinitesimal compared with the wealth and dominion of our host. How did he view this exercise—as a first step toward changing the world, or as a performative display of his reach and influence?

Bezos was everywhere that weekend—in a tight T-shirt, laughing too loudly, arms thrown around his teenage sons. He had recently become the world's second centibillionaire, his net worth hovering somewhere around \$112 billion, about half of what it is today. That number, previously unimaginable, had made him unique on a planet of 8 billion people, and you could feel it in the room. Even the richest and most famous among us were drawn to the energy of this impossible wealth.

Though we didn't know it at the time, Bezos's first marriage would be over a few weeks later. My defining impression of his wife that weekend was sadness, even though Bezos made a big show of performing the role of family man. In hindsight, it is that performance that sticks with me. The Jeff Bezos of 2018 acted

as if he still believed that people's impression of him mattered, that his financial and social value could be affected by negative publicity. He still believed that his actions had consequences. He had not yet freed himself—the way Daniel Plainview freed himself—from the rules of men.

Eight years later, Bezos and two of the world's other richest men—Mark Zuckerberg and Elon Musk—have clearly left the world of consequences behind. They float in a sensory-deprivation tank the size of the planet, in which their actions are only ever judged by themselves.

The closer I've gotten to the world of wealth, the more I understand that being truly rich doesn't mean amassing enough money to afford superyachts, private jets, or a million acres of land. It means that everything becomes effectively free. Any asset can be acquired but nothing can ever be lost, because for soon-to-be trillionaires, no level of loss could significantly change their global standing or personal power. For them, the word *failure* has ceased to mean anything.

This sense of invulnerability has deep psychological ramifications. If everything is free and nothing matters, then the world and other people exist only to be acted upon, if they are acknowl-

edged at all. This is different from classic narcissism, in which a grandiose but fragile self-image can mask deep insecurity. What I'm talking about is a self-definition in which the individual grows to the size of the universe, and the universe vanishes. Asked recently if there is any check on his power, President Trump—himself a billionaire, and by far the richest president in American history—said, "Yeah, there is one thing. My own morality. My own mind. It's the only thing that can stop me." Not domestic or international law, not the will of the voters, not God or the centuries-old morality of civic and religious life.

Decades of research in developmental psychology have shown that moral reasoning develops through consequences—not pun-

ishment, necessarily, but experiencing the effects of your actions on others, receiving honest feedback, having to accommodate reality as it actually is rather than as you wish it to be. It's not that the wealthy become evil; it's that their environment stops teaching them the things that nonwealthy people are forced to

Bezos and the world's richest men have left the world of consequences behind. Their actions are only ever judged by themselves.

learn simply by living in a world that pushes back. When you can buy your way out of any mistake, when you can fire anyone who disagrees with you, when your social circle consists entirely of people who need something from you, the basic mechanism by which humans learn that other people are real goes dark.

When Peter Thiel said, “I no longer believe that freedom and democracy are compatible,” he wasn’t talking about your freedom. He was talking about his own. You don’t exist. When Musk took a chainsaw to the federal government as part of the inside joke he called DOGE, he did so with the air of a man who believed that nothing matters—poverty, chaos, human suffering. He was having fun. It didn’t even matter that the entire destructive exercise ultimately yielded no practical financial gains. For him, the outcome was a foregone conclusion: He could only win, because losing had lost its meaning.

Since the 2024 election, there has been a philosophical shift on the right, and especially among tech billionaires, to vilify the idea of empathy. Musk has called empathy “the fundamental weakness of Western civilization.” He sees it as a weapon wielded by liberal society to bludgeon otherwise rational people into operating against their own interests. Empathy is something done to you by others—a vulnerability they exploit, a back door through which they gain access to your resources and will. This rejection of empathy as a human value gives cover to people who don’t want to feel anything at all. If empathy is the problem, then lack of it isn’t a deficiency—it’s an advantage.

I finally met Bezos on the last day of Campfire, at lunch, after my wife had broken her wrist. I went over to thank him for having us, and he asked how our Campfire experience had been. I told him that it was great, but that unfortunately my wife had broken her wrist that morning when she slipped on the wet grass while kicking a ball with our 6-year-old son.

The night before, we’d all stood by the pool at the beach club watching a cadre of synchronized swimmers execute a flawless water routine. I had spoken with a famous novelist, who said, “I just don’t understand why I’m here.” A famous rock star was about to start an acoustic set. The famous chef had made paella. Somewhere deep under my skin, a brutal pox was beginning to form.

The next morning, my wife fell, and I found myself in a black SUV with a team of private-security contractors, who whisked us

to the back entrance of a Santa Barbara emergency room, where she was seen and treated right away. We made it back in time to watch the Supreme Court justice Zoom in from Washington, D.C.

How was your Campfire? Bezos asked me an hour later, and because I am an honest person, and because I have been a host myself, I decided he would want to know that there had been a problem, but that his team had reacted quickly and been extremely helpful. To be clear, I was in no way blaming him, nor was I shaking down the richest man on Earth. Instead, I was simply offering Bezos, also a husband and father, a brief human connection.

But when I told him what had happened, Bezos looked horrified. He did not say “I’m so sorry.” He did not say “Do you need anything?” Instead, he made a face, and in an instant, an aide came

and whisked him away. When presented with the opportunity for empathy, even performative empathy, he chose escape.

A few hours later, on the private plane home, a famous movie producer offered my wife a blanket. My children’s faces were covered in spots. Under my fingernails, red welts were beginning to rise.

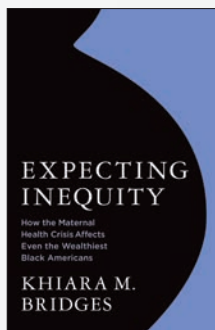
The world has always been run by rich men. The robber barons of the Gilded Age were known for their ruthlessness in the accumulation of wealth—hiring Pinkertons to shoot striking unionists. But they directly engaged with the world around them, using their wealth and power to muscle it into its most profitable form. And although today’s billionaires are clearly

manipulating society to maximize their own profit, something else is also happening—a disassociation from the reality of cause and effect, from meaning and history. These men no longer feel the need to change the world in order to succeed, because their success is guaranteed, no matter what happens to the rest of us.

“I’m finished,” yells Daniel Plainview, perched happily on the polished floor of his own celestial kingdom. Though he has just committed a crime, he has never felt so free. *A*

Noah Hawley is the creator of the FX series Fargo and Alien: Earth, and is the author of the novel Anthem.

**If empathy
is the problem,
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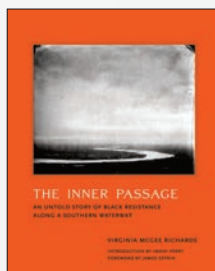
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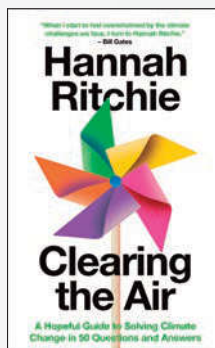
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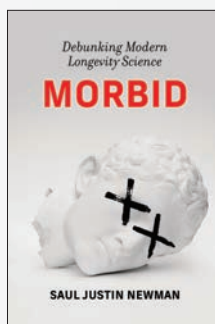
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SOMEDAY IN TEHRAN

BY *Laura Secor*



Tehran, 2006

The heartbreak of hoping for a democratic Iran

Like Donald Trump, I, too, once underestimated the Islamic Republic of Iran. In the fall of 2004, as an underemployed freelance journalist drawn to heady stories about international politics, I had the bright idea of traveling to the notoriously closed country on a tourist visa. Press visas for Iran were hard to come by, and my travel was exploratory—I had no particular assignment. My profile was low, I figured. Who would care if, between the obligatory sightseeing expeditions, I rattled around Iranian cities meeting political analysts, philosophers, students, filmmakers, and the relatives of Iranian expats I knew?

The Islamic Republic was not to be messed with in this way. Its visa regime was deadly serious; so was the official paranoia about foreigners. American tourists were required to travel with a specially vetted guide. For four weeks, I strained to see past the diminutive figure of a young woman I'll call Pardis, who pretended to be a tour guide while I pretended to be a tourist. Pardis excelled at her job, which was not only to make sure that I adhered to the terms of my visa, but also to report on all of my movements and conversations, and to obfuscate everything I saw.

One day I watched a bus disgorge a troop of uniformed Basij militiamen at an intersection in central Tehran.

"Who are they?" I asked Pardis.

"Oh," she said. "They're a youth group. Sometimes they help the police."

Because Pardis stood between me and all that I was truly curious about, I studied her. She was not a dour Islamist but a fun-loving 31-year-old who had hair flowing out of her headscarf and risqué online flirtations with men overseas. She was an orphan, unlucky in love, and ambitious in her minder-ing, circumstances that rendered her marginal—an unmarried career woman living with a roommate. She was also relentlessly trivial, with a knack for diverting any potentially substantive encounter I might have with her country or anyone in it into an endless stream of repetitive inside jokes and girlish banter.

We wandered through bazaars, threatening to buy each other the ugliest items we saw—a giant pair of red satin underwear, a wig, a dowdy zebra-print skirt. We flew to Shiraz on IranAir, a black-turbaned cleric across the aisle from us. Pardis took out a bottle of polish, began painting her nails, and smiled at me impishly. "In front of the mullah!" she said in her little voice. (He was absorbed in opening his airline-issue carton of apple juice.)

Pardis was not invested in anything that the Islamic Republic seemed to care about. But she was, for professional reasons, invested in exercising control over me. For my safety, she

insisted, I could never be without her protective presence. But when she entered a room—even, memorably, one where I sat talking with members of her own family about their feelings about the hijab—everyone stopped talking.

Privately, she'd tell me about her love interests. Relationships between unmarried men and women were commonplace but forbidden under the Islamic Republic. Suddenly she'd freeze in fear and implore me not to tell anyone, or backtrack and claim that she was talking about a friend. Toward the end of our month together, in the shadow of a breakup, she sat smoking and brooding in my hotel room. I told her that Iranian women seemed forced to live complicated lives.

She replied with uncharacteristic bluntness: "Better to say that women here find ways to kill lots of things inside themselves."

Pardis was not interested in politics, but I was. What had drawn me to Iran was a political and philosophical movement that seemed unique in the Muslim world. A circle of the most radical revolutionary elites—hostage takers, religious philosophers, former officials, even founders of the security forces—had fallen out of political favor in the early 1990s and spent the better part of a decade remaking themselves as proponents of incremental democratic reform. They produced an entire theoretical literature that drew on Western and Islamic sources; they mobilized young people to support their campaigns for elected office; and they tried to clean up abuses in some parts of the government they ran. The reformists were insiders who intended not to destroy the regime, but to liberalize it. They sought to make the supreme leader a benign figurehead—like the Queen of England, they sometimes said. The supreme leader had other plans.

My first visit to the country was comically unsuited to exploring any of this. By day, Pardis was obligated to fully occupy my time. Some of what we saw was splendid: palaces and gardens; museums of carpets, miniatures, and Islamic calligraphy; even madrassas and shrines. Then Ramadan set in, and all museums closed. Pardis had us driven around in circles or held me all but captive in her apartment, watching music videos on satellite television. After she dropped me at my hotel in the evenings, I went out to meetings I'd arranged on my own. She was livid when she learned of this. I needed to bring her with me, she insisted, or she'd lose her job. She threatened to sit in my hotel lobby until midnight to make sure I didn't leave—unless, she said, I agreed to give her the names of everyone I saw.

Sure, I said. I'd give her all of the names before I left. I never intended to do this, and she never again asked me to. Maybe

whoever needed to know about my movements already did. Or maybe Pardis covered for me—because she was lonely and considered me a friend, or because she feared she had told me too many of her secrets. Possibly she was simply satisfied that she had already done her job. I returned to New York in relative darkness about the reform movement and loath to write about the one thing I really knew, which was Pardis, and the story of how an otherwise indifferent person comes to hold a stake in a brutal regime—how she forces that stake on others just as it was forced on her.

DURING THE REFORMIST PRESIDENCY of Mohammad Khatami, from 1997 to 2005, a window opened wide enough for a democratic-minded civil society to draw breath in Iran. A crop of semi-independent newspapers sprouted, along with investigative journalists who dared to write for them. Cultural and philosophical magazines published searching essays on religion and the state. Young people formed NGOs to address an array of civic needs; some ran for newly formed city and provincial councils. Student activism spilled onto the streets.

Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei did his best to slam this window shut. His henchmen tortured journalists and student activists in prison until they made humiliating confessions on national television. State-linked thugs beat up a philosopher at his lectures and shot a political theorist point-blank on the steps of Tehran's city hall. Even so, a real infrastructure for democratic change persisted for a time—in the form of people who had the training and experience to run newspapers and civic organizations, citizens who expected these things to be allowed, and the semblance of a political network that connected society to the ministries of the state.

Two presidential elections tested the resilience of this infrastructure. I covered the first of these, in 2005, with a proper journalist's visa and a minder in her mid-40s who had a deep smoker's rasp and a loud, insistent warmth. Bahar (also not her real name—for their safety, I'm using pseudonyms for the private citizens I met) belonged to a lost generation of bohemian Boomers whose class and secular social milieu had been violently displaced by the 1979 revolution. Women who had once lived and studied abroad now gathered in homes that smelled of opium smoke, where husbands were absent or idle and grown children seemed adrift. I learned only later of money troubles, past prison sentences, and ethnic- or religious-minority status that must have contributed to the sense of profound isolation in those homes, where it mingled with something louche and lively and almost careless.

Of all the handlers I was assigned to in Iran—I returned in 2006, 2008, and 2012—Bahar was the least beholden to the agency she worked for. I gave her a list of the people I intended to speak with, many of them reformist politicians, student activists, journalists, and former political prisoners. Her boss told her we'd wind up dead, like a photojournalist who had reported near Evin prison a few years before. Bahar was undeterred. The people on my list were heroes to her for standing up to the Islamic Republic, and she would not forfeit the opportunity to meet them. She told her own handlers that my modesty required us to hire a female driver, which is how we managed to get her best friend, Niki, to ferry us around in her red Peugeot.

How to fully convey the eccentricity of my little entourage? Niki had the stark, exaggerated beauty of a fashion model, though she was gaunt and faded, with a thousand-yard stare. She was also mostly bald. She'd first shaved her head in 1979 to taunt the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps. By her telling, she went out bareheaded to test the hijab law, which required women to cover their hair.

Where is your scarf? a Guardsman asked her.

I don't need one. I have no hair, she said.

Ah, he replied. *But you are still a woman.*

Now Niki swathed herself in layers of flowing garments that resembled ordinary hijab less than they suggested dervish, flower child, and grim reaper all at once. She, too, wanted to meet the people on my list, and at times she entered the room with us. Bringing Pardis to any meeting had cast a pall of annoyance mixed with fear. Bringing Bahar and Niki added an antic element. They were extravagantly maternal, often starstruck, and prone to tears. One incident remains particularly salient in my memory.

The reformists had flubbed the election I'd come to witness. They ran three candidates, and many liberal-minded Iranians rejected all of them, on the grounds that the reformist project was a failure and Iranian elections were far from free. And so the populist hard-liner Mahmoud Ahmadinejad—Khamenei's favorite—surged to the presidency.

The morning the results came in, the red Peugeot was abnormally somber, Bahar and Niki absorbed in a nearly wordless grief. We were on our way to Tarbiat Modares University to see Hashem Aghajari, a reformist intellectual with a revolutionary background and a wooden leg that had replaced the one he'd lost in the Iran-Iraq War. Aghajari had been sentenced to death for a speech he gave in which he said that Muslims need not blindly follow a supreme leader, as though with "shackles around the neck." Under popular pressure, including an international campaign to nominate him for the Nobel Peace Prize, the regime had commuted his sentence, but he still lived under the sword of Damocles, and I asked him whether the election results made him fearful.

"We have a saying in Farsi," Aghajari replied. "'There's no shade darker than black.' The worst they can do is execute me. I have prepared myself for that. If I am worried, it is not for myself. It's for the Iranian people, for young people, today's generation and future generations. My freedom and my life, and those of one or two people like me, don't matter. They may take me to prison. I'm ready for that. In this society, we have no freedom to speak or to write. This is a prison, too."

Outside Aghajari's office, Bahar, or maybe Niki, motioned for us to sit a moment on a low brick wall in the university courtyard, where the sun beat down, and the two women wept.

"When we have people like this in our country," Bahar said at last, "why must we have Ahmadinejad as our president?"

REFORM WAS A CONUNDRUM like so many others under the Islamic Republic. It demanded cooperation and resistance at the same time—"pressure from below, negotiation at the top," as one of its theorists articulated the strategy. The trouble was that Khamenei never once indicated that he would negotiate.

A compromise, practically by definition, satisfies no one. Reform was a compromise between hope and resignation. Iranian oppositionists grumbled about the movement's timidity and its roots in the regime. The alternative, however, was confrontation, and throughout the period of my visits, Iranians were leery of it. The regime's appetite and capacity for violence were never in doubt, and the country's last revolution had gone very wrong. The movement behind it was broad-based, including liberals and leftists, but it was the Islamists who had emerged victorious in street battles and in politics, and who sealed their triumph through summary executions and imposed a theocratic state. This was not a distant memory. Mohsen Kadivar, a dissident cleric, once complained to me that his students railed against reform but shied away from rebellion. "If you won't be the men of revolution," Kadivar told me he said to them, "then be the boys of reform."

The last great showing of this meliorist current was the Green Movement of 2009. In that year's presidential election, liberal-minded Iranians, including many who'd boycotted the 2005 vote, turned out in electrifying force for the moderate reformist candidates Mirhossein Mousavi and Mehdi Karroubi. On election day, some polls had barely closed when the regime called an implausible win for Ahmadinejad. Iranians I spoke with were incandescent with fury. Millions poured into the streets, and Mousavi and Karroubi eventually joined them there. The protesters didn't demand an end to the Islamic Republic, even though many of them undoubtedly wished for it. They followed the cautious, legalistic reformist playbook and simply demanded that the system adhere to its own rules and allow them to elect the relatively moderate insider they'd voted for. They stood silently and held placards that read *WHERE IS MY VOTE?*

Bahar called me in New York on the day that the crowd was at its maximum in Tehran's Azadi Square. She was enraptured; the atmosphere was like nothing she had ever known. The barriers of suspicion, private humiliation, and pain that had divided people for decades seemed to drop away in that expanse of shared silence, and the sense of common purpose was like a current passing through the crowd. To her special delight, she saw Aghajari not far from her—maneuvering, unafraid, on his wooden leg.

The Green Movement was the largest, most sustained, and most organized campaign of street protests that the Islamic Republic ever confronted. Foreign commenters sometimes mistook this for the spontaneous *cri de coeur* of a thwarted presidential campaign, mobilized by Twitter posts, but in fact it was



The author in Tehran in 2005

a movement with a history, layers of experienced leaders, painstakingly articulated ideas, a pragmatic strategy, and a networked constituency. Precisely for this reason, the Islamic Republic set about destroying it with bullets, tear gas, batons, and torture.

Ahmadinejad's first term had already seen the closure of virtually all of the reformist publications and NGOs and the exclusion of reformist candidates from campaigns for most public offices. Now the regime arrested enough of the movement's leaders and activists to fill an auditorium, where they were paraded, hollow-eyed, in prison pajamas and forced to confess to outlandish conspiracies. Lesser-known young activists were remanded to a fetid metal shipping container

in the desert. Many were raped and killed. By 2010, even to speak of or publish a photo of former President Khatami was forbidden; the cautious reform movement was dubbed "the sedition," and Mousavi and Karroubi were placed under a draconian house arrest that would endure for a decade and a half.

When the Arab Spring came to Tunisia, Egypt, and other countries not long after the Green Movement was crushed, I ached for Iran. Of all the countries in the Middle East, up until 2009, Iran had perhaps the most credible infrastructure for democratic change—and one of the most obdurate autocracies.

MY FIFTH AND LAST VISIT to Iran, in 2012, felt in many ways like a bookend to the first, but with the coercion unmasked. Foreign journalists had been mostly excluded from the country since 2009, but three years later, I was part of a small group permitted to observe a parliamentary election. We were marched onto buses and driven to photo ops not of our choosing; even the top bureaucrats assigned to corral us made rueful jokes rather than pretend, per usual, that any of this was for our safety. Talking with a Green Movement activist required an assignation in a moving car after dark. Once again, I found myself studying the apparatus that stood in the way of studying anything else.

Just hours before I left the country, agents from the IRGC apprehended me for questioning because I had left my hotel at night without a minder. They interrogated me about my movements, my contacts, the time I asked my minder to take me to a butcher to confirm popular complaints about the price of chicken. "You have not behaved," an interrogator told me—and, more ominously: "We think you're not a journalist. We think you're a spy."

If they had actually believed this, they might have detained me indefinitely. But in the end I think they meant only to intimidate me. In the third hour of our interview, the interrogator seized my

belongings and left the room with them. He returned in a fury and threw a folder of mine on his desk.

“Do you think we are not intelligent?” he demanded. “We’re keeping your receipts.” He waved in front of me the ones I’d collected for reimbursement for my travel expenses on my return. (I later realized that he may have thought I’d kept them to document the inflation that the government was at that moment trying to conceal from its citizens.) “And we are keeping this.” He held up one of the two extra passport-size photos I’d had taken for my visa. But I was a journalist, he conceded, and he let me go.

By that time, Iran’s democratic infrastructure had mostly been torched. But the yearning and anger it had once harnessed only grew and became more confrontational. At times, opposition still attached itself to elections—to whoever among the allowable candidates represented the most liberal edge of the possible. But it also exploded in street protests of a qualitatively new kind, such as those that erupted in 2017 and early 2018, when members of the lower classes in provincial cities openly reviled the Islamic Republic and chanted “Death to Khamenei.” For another hot minute, the world held its breath for the Islamic Republic to collapse. Instead, it killed.

To imagine that this cycle would repeat itself in 2022 was almost unbearable. Outraged by the death of a young woman in the custody of the morality police, women and teenage girls made hijab the symbolic center of their revolt. The headscarf was both a tool and a symbol of suffocation: Removing it publicly, en masse, was an act of civil disobedience without precedent under the Islamic Republic. Although the “Women, Life, Freedom” uprising was violently quelled like all the rest—some 500 dead, maybe 20,000 in prison, families forbidden even to publicly mourn—it left a uniquely durable legacy, in that women began appearing uncovered in public with relative impunity. This was something new and promising. But it did not bring democracy or suggest what could.

Iran was and remains a heartbreaker. Where else is the civic spirit so enduring, and so unyieldingly denied? Time and again, the Islamic Republic proved itself implacable before even the most rudimentary of its subjects’ desires. It valued neither their lives nor any legitimacy that their consent could confer on the state. It refused them the dignity of small freedoms that might have cost the system nothing. And it would not even afford them a stake in prosperity: Over the course of the first two decades of the 21st century, a largely middle-class country was driven to penury, not only because of international sanctions, but because of the voracious corruption of the IRGC, which Khamenei allowed and encouraged as a means of hoarding power.

I’ll admit that I distanced myself from Iran. My run-in with the IRGC had made traveling there again impossible, and I questioned the value of what I could observe from afar. My network of sources outside the country had always been eclectic. Now it spanned a venomously polarized diaspora that traded accusations—of complicity with Iran’s foreign enemies, and with the ever more hated regime.

To hope for change in Iran was quixotic; to bet against it seemed cruel. Each upswell of protest presented a breathtaking display of youthful courage shadowed by near-certain tragedy. Eternally optimistic, a friend inside Iran offered me a metaphor: *If it takes 100*

blows of the axe to cut down a tree, he wrote to me on WhatsApp in 2022, *you don’t say the first 99 were useless*.

But the Islamic Republic seemed to be made of ironwood. It was not one man’s dictatorship. The revolutionaries had built institutions, both civilian and military, that perpetuated themselves. Networks of violence ran deep, through virtually every power center and organ of the system, and the regime retained a considerable base of ideological support in both the populace and the security apparatus. Time and again, asked to choose between their neighbors and their leaders, Iran’s men under arms chose the regime.

Would they really do it? Would they open fire on unarmed crowds of mostly young people, mowing them down by the thousands? This past January, the Islamic Republic made its security forces the instrument of an atrocity of world-historic proportions, killing at least 6,000 and possibly more than 30,000 protesters. Something broke inside of nearly every Iranian I knew. Or ignited: a fireball of rage and trauma. How could one live under such a regime? But what form of resistance was possible? One exiled activist told me privately that she fantasized about returning as an armed resistance fighter: “The reality is that we have reached a point, a dead end, where you almost have to be a partisan to win. Otherwise you have to accept that they will kill you and move on.”

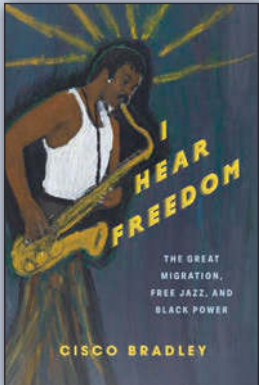
When American and Israeli bombs began blasting their homeland, many of my old friends and contacts hitched their country’s epic hopes to Trump’s epic fury. No nonviolent effort had dislodged or even shaken the regime; here at last was hard power. The alternative was the Islamic Republic, forever. But others among my old network were aghast. The hard power in question was wielded by outsiders for who knew what purpose, against a continuously widening ambit of targets. One friend texted me to ask: If the Iranians celebrating such violent destruction of their country come to power by means of it, can they really be said to be pro-democratic? How will they treat their opponents?

Lately I’ve been wondering whether a fault line has always run through the opposition, or if what I’m seeing now is new. On one side are those who still believe that despite the outcome of the 1979 revolution, its broadest animating impulses—the rejection of monarchy and American dominion, and the assertion of Iran’s sovereignty over its resources and political fate—are sacrosanct. On the other are those who have concluded that not only the Islamic Republic, but the revolution itself, was a wrong turn. There is a potent symbolism in their embrace of the son of the deposed shah as a leader for the future, and their acceptance of American force as the means for empowering him.

The views of these camps are anathema to each other. I am trying to listen respectfully to both—though truth be told, I cannot at the time of this writing imagine a way that this war ends in Iranian liberation, or a way that the Islamic Republic, with or without the war, decides to yield. But how can I say these things, or even think them? Not when every phone call ends with a promise—that we’ll continue the conversation, someday, in Tehran. *A*

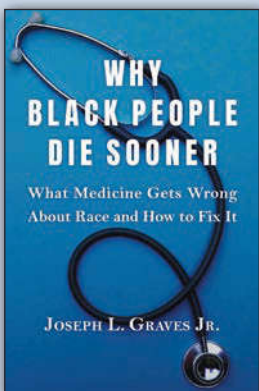
Laura Secor is a senior editor at The Atlantic and the author of Children of Paradise: The Struggle for the Soul of Iran.

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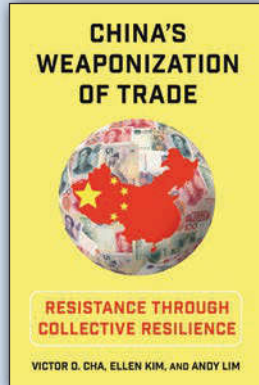
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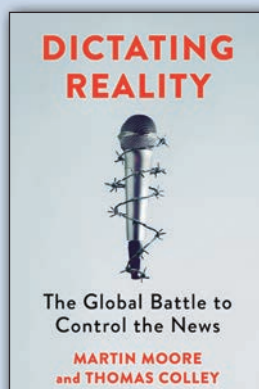
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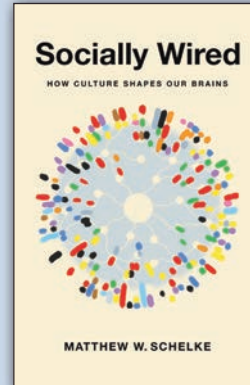
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—Kurt M. Campbell, former US deputy secretary of state and Indo-Pacific coordinator at the National Security Council (2021–25)



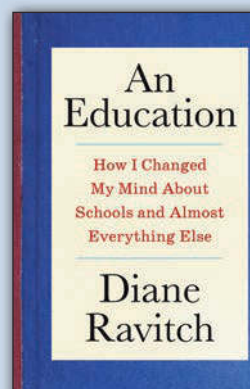
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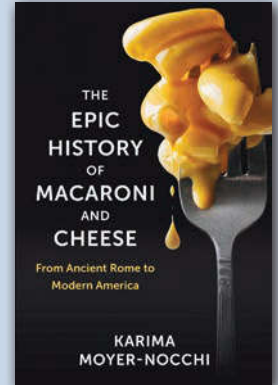
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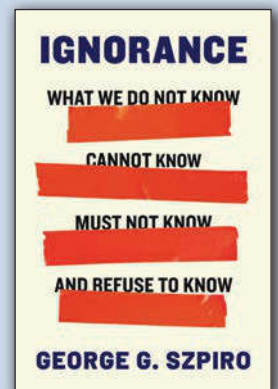
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"Finally, the true story about mac and cheese! Karima Moyer-Nocchi's writing is both entertaining and erudite; this book is a must read for pasta lovers everywhere."

—Vicky Bennison, creator of the *Pasta Grannies* YouTube channel



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Fun to read yet deeply educational, this lively journey through ideas reminds us why books still matter."

—William Eimicke, Columbia University School of International and Public Affairs



Culture & Critics



The Eighth Deadly Sin

*Humankind has devised
a new form of debasement.*

By James Parker

Sometimes, staring brainlessly into my laptop in the trough of a weekday afternoon, experiencing myself as a kind of online shadow, a thing of fidgets, a half-being hollowed out by roaming spectral appetites—for destruction, for gratification, for the email that never comes—it occurs to me to ask: Now, which of the seven deadly sins is *this*?

Anger's in there somewhere, sure, a kind of generalized psychic road rage, but not enough of it to qualify. Same with envy, pride, gluttony, lust—just floating shards. Avarice? Nah. Of the seven, sloth probably comes closest, that enigmatic void state known to the early Christians as “acedia.” But not even acedia, bottomless as it is, can quite comprehend this plugged-in groundlessness, this ether-sweeping emptiness, this interstellar elongation of the spirit. Sin, the theologians tell us, is whatever separates us from God. Whatever blocks the beams of divine love. And at 3:23 p.m. in Caffè Nero, I am all but unreachable by heavenly radiation; I can feel it wavering, honey-colored, at the fringes of my soul. So have we done it at last—you, me, the kids? Have we invented an eighth deadly sin?

I thought initially that the title of Peter Jones's *Self-Help From the Middle Ages: What the Seven Deadly Sins Can Teach Us About Living* was an oxymoron. Self-help is our thing, after all, our exemplary piece of circular modernity, our little closed circuit—the distressed subject coming to its own aid. The medievals, more vertical in their thinking, would have counted on the down-rushing swoop of God's grace.

But Jones, a medieval historian, shows us that the High and Later Middle Ages (1100 to 1500, roughly) were every bit as goofy as we are about human nature and behavior, and equally hooked on buzzwords, listicles (Catherine of Siena's five different types of tears, Thomas Aquinas's five varieties of gluttony), and junk science. To explain the inexplicable (that is, themselves), the medievals used the 12 signs of the zodiac, the four humors—yellow bile, black bile, blood, and phlegm—and the seven deadly sins. Jones takes the seven one by one, a chapter for each, arguing that this gnarly old taxonomy represents not only a timeless

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SELF-HELP
FROM THE
MIDDLE AGES:
WHAT THE
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TEACH US ABOUT
LIVING

Peter Jones

DOUBLEDAY

decoction of human wisdom but something of a moral map for our present wanderings. I think I agree with him, but let's see.

It turns out that there were eight, at least in the beginning. Evagrius Ponticus was one of the world-abandoning superstar Desert Fathers of fourth-century Egypt. Influencer-like, he stood in freezing wells and subsisted on bread and oil, and after much torment and cogitation, he drew up a list of what he called “generic thoughts,” or routine invaders of the spirit: gluttony, lust, avarice, sadness, anger, sloth, vainglory, and pride. Subsequent spiritual engineers made their tweaks to Evagrius's system, but the decisive overhaul was performed 200 years later, by Pope Gregory the Great. He rolled sadness into sloth, vainglory into pride, added envy, and voilà: the seven deadly sins.

Now the sins were characters. They could be personified, and artists went to town. An illustration for Guillaume de Deguileville's 14th-century poem “The Pilgrimage of Human Life” depicts avarice as a woman whose arms have been cut off (she retains the stumps) and replaced with allegorical limbs—feathered claws for rapaciousness, hands holding begging bowls and scales for moneylending, and so on. And is her tongue hanging out? Is she drooling with money-lust? It looks like it. Giotto painted envy as a woman—yes, the medievals, like us, were misogynists—a slanderous monster with a snake squirming out of her mouth, turning back, and reentering her head at the eyes. Also, she has huge, swiveling, batlike ears. And her feet are on fire.

Ghastly as they are, these allegorical images don't really touch us moderns, or not deeply. Much more disturbing and relatable, in Giotto's case, are the sour-faced onlookers and eavesdroppers who lurk at the edges of his frescoes in the Arena Chapel, in Padua: the servant watching in disaffection as an angel tells Anne that she is going to give birth to the Virgin Mary; the scowling, black-veiled woman overhearing Anne tell her husband, Joachim, that she has conceived. To be one of these characters, Jones writes, is to be a “bitter witness.” We know these people. We *are* these people. Social media: a cloud of bitter witnesses! This is envy—*invidia*—as it lives inside us, shriveling our spirits and kindling our meannesses.

Because this is 2026 and everything's got to be personal, *Self-Help From the Middle Ages* prefaces each chapter, each sin, with a reminiscence from the author's time teaching medieval history at a university in Siberia. Hemmed in by the cold, under laboratory conditions as it were, Jones self-examines in the lurid light of the seven deadlies. His transgressions are meek—a bit of ogling at the hot springs (lust), a snippy comment in a faculty meeting (anger). He doesn't trash the common room in an alcoholic blaze or crucify a colleague's cat. But this is precisely the point: The sins are quotidian,

undramatic, regular human business. You can do all seven without leaving your house. The trick is to recognize the sins, to “name” them (in a modern but very appropriate locution). They offer a kind of diagnostic prism, refracting the black, primordial beam of sin into lesser rays of the identifiably and manageably human. And once you know what you’re dealing with, you can summon its opposite. If pride is getting the better of you, engage humility; if gluttony, moderation; if envy, compassion; and so on.

Otherwise they’ll hold us, they’ll dominate us, these sins. While I was reading the chapter on anger, I experienced a surge in understanding as to the nature of sin itself. Sin is subtle, seductive, addictive, of course: The medical encyclopedia *The Property of Things* (circa 1240) describes anger very perceptively as a “wave of bliss.” (Oh, the white-hot elation of righteousness, carrying me away!) But it’s also rigid and carceral, a system of control. Jones gives us the 13th-century Catalan doctor Arnaud de Vilanova, who, after limited success treating anger with the miracle drug theriac (made from viper’s flesh sweetened with honey, a distillation of lilies, and about 40 other ingredients), fell to pondering the character of the malady itself. As Jones writes, “Fury pulls the mind away from reason (ratio), Arnaud reflected, and losing yourself in anger is like letting a puppeteer take control of your brain as well as your limbs.”

A puppeteer controlling your brain? Heavy-metal fans know where this is going—straight to the primary text of compulsion and merciless soul-negation, Metallica’s “Master of Puppets”: “Master of puppets, I’m pulling your strings / Twisting your mind and smashing your dreams / Blinded by me, you can’t see a thing / Just call my name ’cause I’ll hear you scream.” This is where the personification of the seven deadlies comes in handy: You, you naughty person, you libertine, rage beast, sybarite, whatever, might think that you’re committing a sin. But it’s the sin, the master of puppets, that is committing you. Unless you can turn, look it in the face, and summon the right ally.

As for the eighth sin, the new one—having Wi-Fi—is there anything to be done about that? Naturally, excessive online-ness has its counter-impulses: the digital detoxes and the dopamine fasts, all in the fine old spirit of medieval asceticism. You can go online right now and learn about how to be offline. But to free ourselves from this one, to even have the beginnings of a program to free ourselves, I think we’re going to have to do the truly and terrifyingly medieval thing. We’re going to have to get on our knees and pray. *A*

James Parker is a staff writer at The Atlantic.

Byzantine Room By Patricia Lockwood

In the Byzantine room the most
Beautiful cabochon is the missing one.
Clear, like the head of Brian Boru’s harp.
I imagined myself drinking and drinking
From ewers—they had real respect
For rock crystal back then.
Smears of the human on all glass,
Child height, clouds of breath.
Reliquary Arm of Saint Valentine,
Silver, with a sapphire on one finger,
Rough, uneven,
And then you come around to the other
Side and see a dungeon in his forearm,
Sprung open—we are free.
Next to it, the reliquary of Mary
Magdalene’s tooth, removed to fill
Some cavity. Everywhere the praying
Hands are missing from their statues,
Stolen.

Now turn to the *Pietà With Donors*.
“Limestone with traces of polychromy.”
Grapes fall from Christ’s open wound.
A man holds his single stiffened sheet
Of seaweed hair. His mother’s mouth
Blackened with centuries of disbelief,
Nonbelief, she didn’t believe it so hard
He came back to her. The cried-out
Eyes are alive, like his forehead
At the Cloisters. The tuck in his loincloth
Can be perfectly viewed,
His foot only imagined. The whole
Tradition, in this place, is on display.
The lectern eagle with split beak,
To speak. Saint John on Patmos
Receives the revelation, red meat
In the mouth of the dead dragon.
On either side of Christ, the donors
Smile: Pons and Armand, brothers.
This had to happen, they agreed,
It’s ours, and placed him in a private
Chapel. There is a deep cavern
Inside Pons’s bent knee where
Something, clear as cabochons,
Was, used to be. The water in living
Limbs that stands us up, that kneels
Us down, that drapes us over Mary’s
Lap like a necklace. All around,
There were unidentified stones
In those chalices that I, unbeliever,
Could easily name. And I too
Was wearing something that I—
Ancient, uncorrupted,
Uncovered—had made!

Patricia Lockwood is the author of six books, including the poetry collection Agate Head/Stone Soup, coming in October.

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The Feeling of Becoming Less and Less of a Person

*In Ben Lerner's new novel,
technology divides us further from
one another, and ourselves.*

By Nicholas Dames

Let's hazard an assertion: On or about June 2007, human character changed. To be more exact—because the phrase *human character* now feels antique—we might say instead that the human sensorium changed. By this we don't necessarily mean a sudden and definite alteration in how we perceive the world—in the forms, sources, and amount of information we absorb, and in how we conduct our relations with parents, children, spouses, partners, mentors, friends. Yet a transition was set in motion, differentiating life before the omnipresent smartphone and life after, and dating its onset to the birth of the iPhone seems apt.

The above is a loose homage to words that Virginia Woolf wrote slightly more than a century ago about the collapse of Victorian gender and class norms, a shift that she placed more arbitrarily, with half-ironic playfulness, in December 1910, a decade and a half before her essay appeared. In both cases, the mutation seems at once massive and slippery, glaring and subtle; the effects are phenomena without edges, pervasive yet noticeable only when caught by middle-distance memory. Few things are as hard to discern as what was different about the recent past.

Capturing changes like these calls less for history than for the oldest of forms, fable. Not far into Ben Lerner's *Transcription*, you realize that a fable is, in fact, what you have entered. His new novel may be set roughly two years ago, and in a highly specific and contemporary milieu, but it is also about a man in the middle of his life, away from home, signposts vanished and maps lost. Having slipped into a different world, he must now wonder where, if anywhere, he might feel at home. Only the reality-bending qualities of fable, perhaps, can evoke the threshold in human cognition that was crossed just a short while ago and convey the mystery of how or if we have remained ourselves on the other side of that change.

Transcription is the fourth novel by a writer who is not solely, or even primarily, a novelist. Lerner is also a poet and critic, and his novels are written as intermittent and experimental eruptions of engagement with some matter of urgent public concern. They fit within the quasi-biographical, reference-rich, largely plotless genre that the 2010s came to know as "autofiction." Yet Lerner's version, which has the feel of theory in a different mode, has tilted slightly toward a much older tradition, the novel of ideas. Each successive novel has become less indirect about its subject. His debut, *Leaving the Atocha Station*, published in 2011, is a comic, cerebral coming-of-age novel about a young poet in the era of the War on Terror. Pressing issues claim the foreground more overtly three years later in *10:04*, in which Lerner evokes life in the shadow of climate change, and in *The Topeka School*, published in 2019. In that book, his characters confront the decline of American public speech—its degeneration into varieties of unreason and the proto-fascist violence that follows.

The novels' topicality is leavened by a critic's erudition and a poet's facility for turning abstractions into images. The protagonists of these books partially resemble Lerner himself: a male writer from Kansas, the product of an intellectual family and an elite education, eventually a resident of New York City. These figures seem to offer an internal portrait of the author as well. He's hyper-articulate and earnest, though prone to disconcerting fits of duplicity and rage. He's also almost paralyzingly aware of being the beneficiary of a wealthy nation's tangible and intangible resources, and aware that those resources aren't sufficient for a life lived well. Taken together, Lerner's first three novels have the contours of a trilogy, installments in a collective biography whose theme is the evolving disquiet, even anguish, of late-imperial America.

Transcription is and isn't like these predecessors. Lerner's alter ego has returned, unnamed here and now firmly middle-aged, and the terrain is still that of cosmopolitan, credentialed, coastal-urban white America, steadily more embattled and self-doubting. But the book, divided into three encounters—conversations, really—has an unusually stark quality that gives it the feel of a parable. The subject matter is also different. Lerner here turns to media theory, despite the risk that this might seem both in the clouds and mundane: He's training his attention on the phones in our pockets, on something very small and yet boundless in its effects.

Here Lerner's dual talents give him a unique purchase. The "internet novel" of recent years has tried very hard to sound just like the internet—to compete with, parody, or mimic the deadpan, knowing wit and quick cuts of online discourse. Lerner's media theory is both more deliberately, novelistically banal and more freely lyrical. *Transcription* is indeed about those phones and their most literal, pedestrian appearances in our lives. At the same time, it is about how they have transformed the very guise of the world, which means that the novel is about change itself, about what living through epochal transition is like. Trying to explore this process is a project that lacks the dignity or sense of emergency associated with confronting climate disaster or authoritarianism. The experience is happening everywhere; it's the fish's theory of water. Helping us recognize the atmosphere we're immersed in has always been Lerner's talent.

TRANSCRIPTION OPENS with its protagonist on a train to Providence, Rhode Island. He's en route to interview his former college mentor, Thomas, a renowned German media theorist and artist, for a magazine on the occasion of his 90th birthday. It is early 2024. Masking and rapid testing are still on his mind. While on the train, he texts with his wife about their daughter's school anxiety; listens to a talk that his mentor gave half a century earlier; falls asleep and has a disturbing dream about trying to pick up his daughter at school and being turned away. Tugged at by both the young and the old, he starts to feel unmoored. At his hotel, preparing for the interview, he accidentally drops his phone—which he was counting on to record the interview—into a clogged sink. It goes "black mirror."

He has been sundered from the world, unable to locate an Apple Store where he could replace the phone, unable to call his mentor to apologize in advance for being late, unable to make a promised FaceTime call to his daughter. He's as inaccessible as the dead. On his way to the interview, he experiences the shift as a transfiguring estrangement, "a withdrawal indistinguishable from mild intoxication,

the landscape made strange, the stones stonier." Unmediated by a screen, he is seized by an almost unbearably sharp feeling of presence, while he is also moving back into his own deviceless past, as if the Providence of his youth has summoned itself from the underworld. We have entered the miraculous, uncannily familiar, possibly treacherous land of fable. Nothing captures the force of technology better than an enchantment that removes it, however temporarily. But the scene is also comically ordinary; he is just a man who cannot open his Contacts.

Defamiliarization, in *Transcription*, always swerves back into the familiar, into realist farce. When he arrives at Thomas's house, an incoherent shame seizes him, and he cannot admit to his mentor that his phone is unusable. His frail interlocutor begins to speak—elegantly, passionately—about his own youth in Hitlerite Germany and the fascist radio speeches that form his earliest memories, but his words are not being captured. And as this unrecorded rhapsody progresses, dementia weaves its spell. Thomas begins to confuse his young mentee and interviewer with his own son, mixing fragments of family wounds and recriminations into his reverie, as if he's forgotten that he's being interviewed. Lerner's protagonist plays along politely, anxiously. What else can he do? The interview will have to begin again tomorrow, with a new phone, in any case. He fails to confess that nothing has been recorded. Thomas's sibylline, disorienting words slip into the void.

We later learn, indirectly, that the promised tomorrow never comes—that Thomas's death has intervened, and the recorded interview never occurs. The nonevent is the void with which the novel's following two sections contend. The protagonist, we find out, has tried to fill it by publishing his conversation with Thomas as if it were a verbatim last interview, and the revelation of this imposture shocks not only Thomas's other acolytes—a "deepfake," one calls it, made under "false pretenses"—but also Thomas's son, Max, the protagonist's close friend from college. Their anger makes clear the scale of the protagonist's oedipal betrayal.

In the novel's final section, other crossed signals and cross-generational misperceptions emerge. Max now speaks, almost entirely uninterrupted, about his own failed communication with his father in recent years. He describes Thomas's near death from COVID in early 2020, during which a nurse held a smartphone to his ear so that Max could say a final goodbye of forgiveness and apology, a call that Thomas may or may not have heard. Max also recounts a later visit with his recovering father, in the course of which he surreptitiously recorded their conversation on a phone—another deception. All of this is framed by Max's narration of his young daughter's

TRANSCRIPTION

Ben Lerner

FARRAR, STRAUS
AND GIROUX

life-threatening eating disorder and the treatment that saved her: She was allowed to eat while glued to her iPad, watching the bizarre micro-genre of unboxing videos. Max relates all of this with a lucid matter-of-factness, because he is baffled by it.

One might take *Transcription*'s final section as Max's absolution—tacit, maybe even a bit grudging—of his friend, and his father's mentee, for his transgression. Here the novel comes close to a kind of mythic resolution, one that lets us glimpse a deep, unappeasable desire: to have the dead, or the dead's appointed representatives, forgive us, so that we may forgive them for having left us. Lerner, however, never lets us forget how entangled this need is with power cords and phones and screens, all the ganglia of modern, networked life—and how these devices are both bridge and barrier between parents, children, and grandchildren.

As Lerner's alter ego has aged through his four novels, he has acquired not just offspring but a profound unease about the different world that the next generation already inhabits, one that the parent not only can't control but can't even apprehend, as if the child's receptive organs are attuned to as yet unnamed hues and higher frequencies. Meanwhile, the world of aging parents threatens to vanish unrecorded. In the remembered/fabricated interview, Thomas provides a media metaphor for this—a "split screen" in which the young and old exist in parallel spaces. "The question," Thomas adds, "is how to depict the historical changes in atmosphere." *Transcription* is an attempt at an answer.

Historical transitions have magically disorienting qualities. They also are a matter of prosaic, minute negotiations. Lerner's characters always have thickly rendered intellectual lives, but in *Transcription* their intellection is directed, more than ever before, toward what you might call "getting used to it," finding ways to acclimatize to that new atmosphere. To the communication-and-storage devices in their pockets that, far more than any postmodern philosophy, have erased the feeling of embodied, subjective presence in the world. To the anxiety disorders of their children, which have the portentous mystery of an oracle's riddle. To the garbling, which the novel relays in its opening section, of collective social-historical memory.

In this way at least, *Transcription* is traditional. When fiction contends with technological change, it often situates that change in the context of generational loss. Marcel Proust's reflection on the telephone, in the third volume of *In Search of Lost Time*, happens during a glitchy long-distance call with the narrator's grandmother, in which her disembodied voice, reduced by telephony to tympanic vibration, becomes a premonition of the grave. So too in Lerner. Parents and mentors die, traces of them captured (or

not) only in the fragile black box of the device. Children seem accessible only through it. The middle-generation experience, the bidirectional mourning that comes of being split between the vanishing and the emergent, preoccupies *Transcription*.

If Lerner has an answer about how to acclimate, it's in *Transcription*'s turn away from the narration of consciousness, all of those second thoughts and dreamy associations that have until now been his fiction's primary mode. Its final section is only speech—simultaneously confessional, therapeutic, and testimonial—as if Lerner needed a form detached from the single mind. We are left just with voices, and those voices, in the novel's subtle and canny repetitions, begin to merge with one another, becoming polyphonic. Phrases and images from earlier in the novel return, echoed, no longer assignable to particular individuals.

It's a way of capturing the tremendous de-selving of the networked world. In this novel, one generation will depart before needing to adjust to it. One generation will never have known anything else. And one generation might be able to record its happening, to serve as the seismograph of a cognitive-technological shift. This is what one recalls of *Transcription*: not an action, not even really a scene, but a situation—the feeling of becoming less and less of a person. It's a hollow feeling, but strangely also a feeling of heightened sensitivity to almost everything, including your own disappearance. In all of the novel's layered voices, one can hear the trembling of elegy.

Early in the book, Lerner's protagonist recalls a visit to the famous glass flowers in the Harvard Museum of Natural History: small, painfully fragile artifacts, mimicking nature with hallucinatory detail, suspended carefully from wires. He notices—or imagines; it is impossible to tell—that they are "vibrating imperceptibly." He thinks, "The flowers were recording instruments of exquisite sensitivity." They are like seismographs, but also like phones, like data stored in the cloud, in the air—"air looms," Thomas jokingly puns at one point. The world, in *Transcription*, is becoming air: the depersonalized, dematerialized, impalpable crossing of digital signals. The glass flowers, however, suggest that art can still respond to fluctuations in, and of, the air. Lerner's novel comes as close as we can yet imagine to honoring their delicate way of registering a change that is everywhere around us—and that is making nonsense of the difference between inside us and outside us. *A*

Nothing captures the force of technology better than an enchantment that removes it, however temporarily.

Nicholas Dames is the Theodore Kahan Professor of Humanities at Columbia University and the author, most recently, of The Chapter: A Segmented History From Antiquity to the Twenty-First Century.



BOOKS

Who Is Black Comedy For?

A new book is nostalgic for the '90s. But the era of crossover success was not necessarily the pinnacle of Black comedic achievement.

By K. Austin Collins

Early in his career, before he became a household name, Dave Chappelle attempted to get a series off the ground at Fox. It was 1998, and the network had already welcomed Black comedies such as *Living Single*, *Martin*, and *In Living Color*—shows that implied a vested interest in Black taste. Chappelle might have expected to find a receptive audience when he presented the pilot for *Dave Chappelle*, a sitcom based on his life as a young Black comedian. What he reportedly got instead was a roomful of white executives with a familiar set of complaints. There were not enough white people on his proposed show. It was not “universal” enough—meaning it was too Black. Swap out the Black female lead for a white one and add an additional white character, he was advised. All of this despite Fox being, as Chappelle put it at the time, a network that had “built itself on black viewers.” He refused to cooperate, remarking that the incident “tells every black artist no matter what you do, you need whites to succeed.”

Chappelle was caught up in a whirlwind of change in the TV landscape. The successes of Black sitcoms in the 1980s and '90s had made new shows marketable for mainstream (read: not just Black) audiences, but that marketability had come with a catch. In the late '90s, there was a broader push for multiculturalism, which came to be defined, in a great many cases, as whiteness-plus: white protagonists with their Black, Asian, and Latino friends; Blackness not as a set of experiences in itself, but as proof positive of the white hero's ability to learn. Jokes that might offend or even just confuse white audiences became harder sells, and safe crossover appeal became the norm. A few years prior to Chappelle's pitch, Keenen Ivory Wayans, the creative force behind *In Living Color*, had left his show, over issues that reportedly included censorship from Fox.

Fast-forward half a decade to the now-famous story of *Chappelle's Show*, the sketch series that began in 2003 on Comedy Central. We live in the comedy world that Chappelle conquered, through the Miss Cleo parody, the racial draft, and “I'm Rick James, bitch!” He mastered a comic style that highlighted the absurdity of racism by taking it to its extremes, while also leaning on and exploring Black in-jokes without translating them for white viewers. His bits became memes before most of us knew what a meme was, and—taking advantage of Comedy Central's comparatively lax rules—he insisted on using the N-word liberally.

This Chappelle show was everything that the 1998 concept couldn't be. And ironically, though the show made no effort whatsoever to be “universal,” it nevertheless won a rabid and diverse audience.

Opposite page:

Early in his career, Dave Chappelle worked on a sitcom concept with Fox.

In 2005, Chappelle walked away from a reported \$50 million contract he'd signed with Comedy Central the previous year. Most people were baffled by his decision, but in interviews, he explained that the fame and pressure had weighed on him, and that the show's popularity—especially among people who were ostensibly the butt of the jokes—indicated that his work had not been received as he'd intended. In the end, Chappelle followed the logic he set for himself early on in his career: Mainstream approval was never more important than the integrity of the material, or of its maker.

CHAPPELLE'S ERA of comedic dominance is the denouement of *Black Out Loud: The Revolutionary History of Black Comedy From Vaudeville to '90s Sitcoms*, a new book by Geoff Bennett. A *PBS News Hour* anchor, Bennett traces the trajectory of Black comedy, beginning with the long backstory of its arrival in the network-TV mainstream. The first of the book's two sections is a series of historical profiles of Black comics, from the minstrel-era performer Billy Kersands through Eddie Murphy. Bennett then turns to several landmark Black television shows of the '80s and '90s—series in which, as a youth, he could “see Blackness represented in a way that felt real and expansive.” The book concludes with *Chappelle's Show*.

In Bennett's resolutely progressive view, the story of Black comedy in America is of “a steady march toward fearlessness.” But Bennett measures progress mostly by the ability of Black comedy to break barriers and achieve crossover appeal. The effect is to render Black comedy that doesn't go mainstream—that remains just “Black,” and thrives not in scripted shows on network television but on tours and in comedy clubs, specials, films, TikToks, and Instagram Reels—less relevant. This framing casts the grand lineage of Black comedy as a vehicle for racial reconciliation.

As Bennett tells it, the struggle that persists down the “ancestral line” of Black comics is to courageously and cannily resist stereotypes, each generation less fettered than the one that came before it. That process begins with blackface, mammies, and Stepin Fetchits. Next come the winking subversions of those archetypes by the likes of Moms Mabley and Hattie McDaniel. They in turn lay the groundwork for the later, far more brash subversions of Redd Foxx, Dick Gregory, and in particular Richard Pryor, who perfected a singular brand of self-dissolving, linguistically nimble storytelling.

Black Out Loud is an account of successive generations of Black comics gradually persuading white audiences to see beyond caricature and accept Black characters as people whose stories are worth paying

For Chappelle, mainstream approval was never more important than the integrity of the material.



Left: Richard Pryor's controversial stand-up routines made way for a new generation of comics.

Below: *Family Matters* was one of the longest-running sitcoms with a mostly Black cast.



attention to. In the '90s era of peak Black sitcom, Bennett sees, on the one hand, a reflection of America's begrudging acceptance of Black culture, and on the other, the realization of Black viewers' demand for sitcoms that offered authentic representation. Sitcoms made for Black audiences prior to the 1990s were rarely under Black creative control, and even 1970s-era classics such as *Good Times* and *The Jeffersons* offered up imperfect or stereotypical simulacra of Black life. With more Black creative input shaping successors such as *The Cosby Show*; its spin-off, *A Different World*, set at a historically Black college; and *The Fresh Prince of Bel-Air*, however, the stories subtly poked at the rhythms that had been familiar to Black TV. For example, when, on *The Fresh Prince*, Will and Carlton are detained by racist cops while driving a Mercedes, the officers' presumption that the car must be stolen doubles as commentary on the show's popularity and on Black upward mobility generally: *We're not supposed to be here.*

It's a little strange, though, to lurch, as the book does, from the bawdy confrontations of Pryor—who tested his audience's comfort with brash profanity and jokes about racial violence and graphic sex, including gay sex—to the wholesome fare of *Family Matters*, in which someone spray-painting the N-word on Laura Winslow's locker and telling her to go back to Africa was the subject of a Very Special Episode. Strange, that is, to fashion the era of Urkel as proof of a clear advancement from the era of Pryor. Progressive views of 20th-century America are right, in many ways, to give us a sense of the cultural politics that were pushing the country forward: more rights, more opportunity, more representation. But the approach stumbles when it too eagerly smooths over the equally characteristic setbacks, divots, and reversals.

Still, Bennett is compelling in his insistence that what unites the various threads of Black comedic genius is an overarching trend toward Black comics getting to be themselves. His reporting on Wayans's self-described "dictatorship" as *In Living Color's* creator, for example, highlights how, even at the risk of seeming irreverent or disrespectful, Wayans tried to fend off network meddling in achieving his singular vision. That doggedness helped chart a path for many of Bennett's subjects, including the rest of the Wayanses. This book is a genealogy, yes, but also a relay, stretching from performers hiding—literally—beneath layers of burnt cork to, a century later, Chappelle donning a blond wig and

beige makeup to play a delectably too-white news anchor who's even funnier for looking not quite right (or white).

The satire cannot exist without the real. The history of blackface is what makes the cutting humor of Chappelle's whiteface possible. In that respect, Bennett's vision of Black comedy's evolution as "a steady march toward fearlessness" makes undeniable sense. How did we get from Bert Williams and George Walker—two extraordinary comic talents whose artistic legacy is complicated by their association with blackface—to Black comedians being afforded the leverage to turn that shameful history into an epic in-joke? Part of the answer is the work of people like Hattie McDaniel, who is said to have quipped that she'd rather play a maid than be one. Bennett's effort to track this history incrementally, through heroes whose symbolic cultural wins had measurable impact on what came after, makes for a buoyant and agreeable book.

Where he errs, however, is in holding up the era of crossover appeal as the apex of Black comic achievement. To dwell on '90s network sitcoms—on Black television playing on white networks in general—is to gauge the progress of Black comedy in terms that are not always those of Black comedians themselves. We can see the success of shows such as *In Living Color* and *Family Matters* as proof that the American experiment, with its promises of integration and acceptance, has finally worked. Or we can acknowledge that the promise has always been contingent: *You can tell jokes about race, but ...*

LATE IN HIS LIFE, the great Dick Gregory argued that Black people should never turn to entertainment expecting liberation, and that white comedians were not burdened by these unrealistic hopes. "Bob Hope ain't never changed nothing," he said. "Fred Astaire ain't never fixed it so little children could eat." But, as *Black Out Loud* makes clear, Black popular entertainers are charged with needing to stand for something: Liberation by way of representation has long been a demand. Chappelle put it plainly. "White people, white artists, are allowed to be individuals," he told *Esquire* in 2006, defending his choice to leave his show. "But we always have this greater struggle that we at least have to keep in mind somewhere."

Of course, Chappelle did return after his hiatus, and the trajectory of his comeback is one of quite a few inconvenient truths that Bennett's book, interesting as it is, cannot account for. His relentlessly progressive arc struggles to explain the present: when Chappelle is controversial for jokes not about white people but about trans people and Jews; when networks seem to have short leashes for the few Black shows they

do green-light; when audiences are atomized and moving away from television altogether, and toward comedians who make their bones on self-produced short-form videos; and when jokes about race land differently, given an openly white-supremacist administration in the White House.

Bennett scopes his inquiry to focus on the form that most interests him—and, likely, that makes for a manageable book—but the choice constrains his vision of fearlessness to one that mostly involved speaking to white audiences in a decade of multicultural awareness, and through a network-dominated medium that would soon be on its way out. What if fearlessness, though, has nothing to do with white audiences or gatekeepers? If Chappelle himself represents the pinnacle of Black comedic courage, then maybe his most important contribution to the canon isn't the Netflix specials or the Prince sketch, but the famous moment when he turned to a camera—and implicitly to Black viewers—and cried: "This racism is killing me inside!"

Whether or not you subscribe to the idea that a Black artist's job is to change the world, a history of that responsibility that sticks to the mainstream hardly paints a full picture. The real legacy of revolutionary Black comedy might lead us not just to *Family Matters* and *Chappelle's Show*, but also to the terrain claimed by Black comedy that primarily serves Black audiences—the way things were for the likes of Gregory and Flip Wilson, and for comedians such as the late Paul Mooney and Patrice O'Neal and the still-kicking, still-hilarious Katt Williams.

As much as I've missed *Chappelle's Show* since it went kaput, I've missed shows such as *Def Comedy Jam* and BET's *Comic View*—the latter of which launched the careers of D. L. Hughley and Cedric the Entertainer—even more. These shows produced a generation of comics, actors, and presenters who are famous among Black audiences but relatively unknown in white pop culture. Wary as I am of calling the often-aggravating work of Tyler Perry "revolutionary," the bulk of it, by and large, still appeals to Black audiences. And only to Black audiences. The longest-lived Black sitcom, by episode count, is not *The Jeffersons*, *The Cosby Show*, or *Family Matters*, but *Tyler Perry's House of Payne*, which aired its 400th show this year. The aspirations of *Payne* and its ilk are not to cross over, nor to reify the values of the Black middle class, but simply to be funny. And Black. All on their own terms. What's a revolutionary history without that? *A*

K. Austin Collins is a film critic and programmer.

BLACK OUT
LOUD: THE
REVOLUTIONARY
HISTORY OF BLACK
COMEDY FROM
VAUDEVILLE TO
'90s SITCOMS

Geoff Bennett

HARPER



ART

The Art of the (New) Deal

What the murals of the Wilbur J. Cohen Federal Building can teach us about patriotism, propaganda, and beauty

By Judith Shulevitz

To forge a new social contract is one thing. To explain it to people is another. The bureaucrats of the New Deal understood that very well. They also knew that art and architecture could be powerful spreaders of political ideas. As it brought America out of the Depression, the Franklin D. Roosevelt administration built or funded courthouses, post offices, town halls, gyms, pools, auditoriums, and much more—tens of thousands of public buildings and facilities—and its arts programs employed as many as 10,000 artists to decorate them.

The Wilbur J. Cohen Federal Building, originally the Social Security Board Building, exemplifies New Deal art and architecture at their best. It's the "Sistine Chapel of the New Deal," in the words of the founder of the Living New Deal, an organization dedicated to documenting and preserving the history and culture of the period. In 1935, Roosevelt's Social Security Act changed the covenant between the American people and the state. Social Security enshrined a new right to be protected against economic vicissitudes, reversing the assumption that Americans would scrape by on the strength of "rugged individualism"—a phrase made popular by Roosevelt's predecessor Herbert Hoover, who was being blamed for America's woes. Seeking muralists and

U.S. GENERAL SERVICES ADMINISTRATION



Ben Shahn's mural on one wall of a corridor in the Cohen building portrays unemployed men before the advent of Social Security. On the opposite wall, he painted his vision of bustling life afterward.

sculptors to work on the new building, the office in charge of the most prestigious commissions, the U.S. Treasury's Section of Fine Arts, held competitions and published an essay that effectively provided the theme. Its title was "The Meaning of Social Security."

The result is an uncommonly lovely New Deal mission statement. The Cohen building (it was renamed in 1988 for the first professional employee of the Social Security Board, who later became the secretary of health, education, and welfare) is a 1.2-million-square-foot edifice covering a city block across from the National Mall in Washington, D.C. The architect, Charles Z. Klauder, gave it strong, modernized classical lines and Egyptian Revival and Art Deco flourishes. It is a vision of big government rooted in the past and reaching toward the future. The interior proclaims the beauty of efficient bureaucracy. Once inside the door, the presumed public servant is led straight to bronze-clad elevators and escalators, and from there whisked to his duties. Green marble covers the walls, rounding corners with sinuous Art Moderne curves.

Ben Shahn and Philip Guston, who went on to join the ranks of the most-renowned American artists of the 20th century, won plum commissions on the ground floor, as did Seymour Fogel, a respected

muralist. (Ethel and Jenne Magafan, Colorado painters, collaborated on a mountain landscape for the fifth-floor boardroom.) Shahn got the most prominent assignment: two murals, each roughly 70 feet long and 24 feet high, on either side of a central corridor. One wall is a somber portrait of Americans suffering the effects of child poverty, old age, and unemployment. The other is a paean to life after Social Security: basketball games, public works, a bountiful harvest. Shahn named the murals simply *The Meaning of Social Security*. He considered them his best, and many critics agree.

Now, however, the building may be sold, and quite possibly demolished. If so, Shahn's and Fogel's murals, painted directly onto the walls, would be very hard to remove. Last year, the Cohen building was added to a list of federal properties marked for "accelerated disposition," meaning fast-tracked sale. Living New Deal is leading the campaign to save the building, but the battle will be tough. According to sworn testimony, the Trump administration is already soliciting bids to tear down the Cohen and three other federal buildings, bypassing the usual reviews. Meanwhile, the regulations meant to protect historic buildings are being weakened.

The current president is just as adept as Roosevelt was at using public space to define the state. That is why Trump razed the White House's East Wing and plans to replace it with a huge gilded ballroom; wants to erect a triumphal arch; and has announced that his overhaul of the Kennedy Center will take the structure down to "the steel." We don't know whether Trump would be involved in putting up another building should the Cohen be leveled, but he is clearly not finished remaking Washington in his image.

CULTURE MADE by government fiat is generally labeled propaganda, especially when it promotes unpopular ideas. In a liberal society, it is an article of faith that only totalitarian regimes force artists to shape public opinion, airbrushing this, glorifying that, especially the great leader. Critics dismissed New Deal art as propaganda in its day, and for decades afterward. The complaints came from the right (the art was Soviet-adjacent) and from the left (it glossed over harsh realities and shored up capitalism). Later, criticism also came from arbiters of high modernism, such as Clement Greenberg, who wrote off New Deal art as kitsch for the masses.

Such sweeping judgments went too far. The huge body of work produced for arts relief programs during the Depression varied widely in quality. Among the most experienced muralists were the Cohen building artists, and the phrase *social security* held out untapped possibilities for invention. The gist seemed simple: By

Arbiters of high modernism, such as Clement Greenberg, wrote off New Deal art as kitsch for the masses.

safeguarding citizens against penury, the good nation ensures that they flourish. But flourishing comes in many forms. If you're looking for *the* meaning of social security, you won't find it here.

I visited the Cohen building on a sunny day in February to see for myself what it had to say. Four delicate bas-reliefs in granite embellish the pediments over its four entrances. Sunlight bounced off the snow and the building's monumental limestone facade, and the friezes almost disappeared in the glare. I paused to study one called *Family Group*, by Emma Lu Davis, an unusually domestic tableau to see on the exterior of a public building. A worker holding a lunch box places his free hand on the shoulder of his seated wife, as if to say goodbye for the day. She looks up at him, and the toddler at her feet looks up at her and tugs her dress, and the three form a circle. But the story doesn't end there. They are in turn encircled by a thin line, which I realized after a moment is the profile of a man. He bows his head in thoughtful concern, and I understood that he represents the benevolent paternal state; he holds the family in his thoughts. A rather claustrophobic image, I felt, until it occurred to me that during the Depression, being held close by the government would have come as a relief. Like any historical artifact, the Cohen building demands that you enter into the spirit of the past.

The building in its current state was disturbing. The main entrance is now closed, so I went in through another and found myself in a cramped, dim vestibule. Still bedazzled by the bright, hopeful exterior, I felt as if I had entered a much-diminished present. The main hallways were wide but silent and empty. When I toured the upper floors, I grasped the dimensions of the emptiness. One of the building's longtime occupants, the Department of Health and Human Services, has been gutted by the Trump administration. The other occupant, Voice of America, the federal news agency founded to combat Nazi propaganda, has been slashed by the president, who has called it "a total left-wing disaster." All but a few of its radio programs have shut down, and those few barely operate. (A federal judge has since voided the VOA layoffs.) I opened doors into unlit newsrooms and broadcast studios. In some of them, the equipment had been ripped off the walls, leaving cut wires dangling and bits of plastic scattered across desktops and floors. Occasionally, I passed a clump of engineers and, more rarely, a lone broadcaster talking into a microphone.

What sense of life remains in the building radiates from the murals on the ground floor, especially Shahn's post-Social Security mural. In the foreground of an urban scene, young men leap into the air, vying for a basketball. They're slightly oversize,

I opened doors into unlit newsrooms and broadcast studios. In some of them, the equipment had been ripped off the walls, leaving cut wires dangling.

as if almost too close to us, and their muscular heft is underscored by smaller figures playing handball in the background. Nearby, men drill the girders of a bridge; the iron beams make bold crisscrosses, moving the eye diagonally. Farther along, the frame of a house and the carpenters reaching to hammer its beams sweep the eye upward. The mural fills the entire wall, punctuated only by three doors, and Shahn cleverly integrates their lintels into his narrative. Bricklayers build a wall on top of one. In another scene above a door, a mother seems to have brought a baby and two sons to watch some construction workers. One of the sons leans on the lintel; behind them, an older man—their grandfather?—gets ready to kiss the baby.

By contrast, the opposite wall, which shows America before Social Security, is divided into separate panels, and its figures are still. In one panel, children maimed or exhausted by labor stare out bleakly; in another, unemployed men in a small industrial town sit or stand around. This mural ought to feel static, and yet here, too, Shahn creates a sense of motion. Behind the children, we see that a door opens onto a vista of men working in a mine. In another panel, a man and child walk away from the town along a railroad track that curves up and to the left, and then disappears. The jury that chose Shahn liked his entry because of "the variety in the tempo and texture."

ART-HISTORY ENCYCLOPEDIAS generally associate New Deal art with Socialist Realism, a dourly idealizing style identified with Soviet communism, but it was only one influence among many. Artists took imagery and iconography from Regionalism—think Grant Wood and Thomas Hart Benton—which leaned toward heartland nativism. German Expressionism and Surrealism, deemed degenerate by Nazis and Soviets alike, show up in stylized figuration, spatial distortion, and a dreamlike atmosphere. Shahn, Philip Guston, and Seymour Fogel also learned from the masters of an older generation of revolutionary Mexican muralists. Shahn and Fogel assisted Diego Rivera on his doomed Rockefeller Center project in 1933 (the Rockefellers destroyed it when he would not remove Lenin's face). Rivera produced monumental, socially conscious murals, but he borrowed exuberantly from other sources: Aztec art, Renaissance frescoes, Cubism, and more.

The subject matter of New Deal art was more constrained and at times boosterish. According to John P. Murphy's excellent introduction, *New Deal Art*, Edward Bruce, the founder of Roosevelt's arts programs, prided himself on giving artists their freedom—as long as they eschewed abstraction, nudity, and overtly political proselytizing. What he wanted to see

was “the American scene in all its phases”—city and countryside, farmers and factory workers, fields and recreational spaces, mines and railroads. The packet that Bruce assembled for the Social Security competition stressed that government support shored up the traditional family the way that pioneering families had helped one another; the effect was to associate the new policy with the American frontier, rather than radical collectivism.

Shahn more or less ignored the hint. The only family in his murals was the one squeezed atop the lintel. His interest lay in society and its diversity—a very familiar notion today, but not back then. Murals commissioned by the Section of Fine Arts (especially in the South) tended to shy away from the realities of Black life, and Black people were often shown in subservient roles. Shahn didn’t make a big point of integration, but his people are Black and brown as well as white. Their bodies are squat and bulky, tall and alarmingly skinny. The beneficiaries of Social Security don’t exhibit fake cheer—they aren’t sad, but they don’t smile, either; they are intent on their work. Those still in need of assistance are grim but have their dignity. In a nice touch by Shahn, a swarthy man in a fedora who assumes a proud, defiant stance—his arms are crossed and he scowls, as if to say, “Show me!”—appears in both murals unchanged. In the before scene, he waits in a line of unemployed men. In the after, he waits in a line of men signing up for Social Security. He’s a skeptic; he’ll wait and see. That’s his right, and Shahn respects it.

Shahn’s realism extended to noting Social Security’s flaws. To win votes from Southern Democrats, Roosevelt had agreed to deny Social Security to agricultural and domestic laborers—excluding a large percentage of Black workers. Laura Katzman, an art-history professor at James Madison University and the curator of a recent Shahn retrospective whom I spoke with, pointed out that Shahn made sure to include farmworkers and a caregiver in his cast of characters. In one of the pre-Social Security panels, a woman holding a child “looks Latino” and is probably a nanny, Katzman said, observing that “the child is very blue-eyed” and has red hair. I noticed later that the woman’s white dress resembles a maid’s uniform.

Fogel’s murals, two frescoes just inside the original main entrance, weave a streamlined Futurism and bright Mexican Modernism into their Socialist Realism. *Wealth of the Nation* depicts a utopia peopled by broad-shouldered heroes of the new economy—a scientist, an architect, two construction workers, and, in the background, a giant, half-naked proletarian, back muscles popping as he strains to pull the

lever for two huge cogwheels. *Security of the People* demonstrates what the wealth of the nation is for: to provide respite to the nuclear family, shown outdoors engaged in leisure activities.

On further inspection, though, the mood changes. In both murals, each figure occupies a separate space. Nobody looks at anybody else, with one exception: In *Security of the People*, a woman holding a naked child gazes balefully at a man immersed in his newspaper. In early studies for the project, Fogel had depicted Dickensian insecurity (a starving woman, homeless men, a punishing workplace). The dystopian gloom seems to have infected the new Eden. Perhaps Fogel, a fervent leftist, chafed at having to celebrate the family, that bourgeois institution.

Guston’s *Reconstruction and the Well-Being of the Family*—a triptych on wood panels—is mounted on the stage of the auditorium and dominates the hall like an altarpiece in a nave. The painting is erudite; it packs in allusions. The father stretches out his arms, Jesus-like, evoking the Last Supper, and the mother holds a toddler on her lap, face forward, the way the Madonna might present the Christ child. The side panels show men at work, one digging in a surreal desert, two breaking Cubist-looking rocks. All of the figures have elongated limbs, Picasso-style, and they gaze into the middle distance like early-Renaissance saints (Piero della Francesca was one of Guston’s favorite painters). In the early 1940s, as Guston was painting this mural, he had begun to turn away from political art to introspective easel painting, and one wonders whether the religious references idealize the New Deal family or half-mock its idealization.

COMPARED WITH the other muralists in the Cohen building, Shahn comes off as the ultimate New Deal artist. He is the least subversive, the most sincere. And yet his murals have aged the best. His individuals are truly individual; they have an unquenchable vitality and collectively convey an adamant humanism,

A postcard from the 1940s shows the Social Security Board Building shortly after its completion.





Philip Guston's triptych, evoking the Last Supper and a Madonna and Christ child, has the aura of an altarpiece in the Cohen building's auditorium.

a subversive ideology in its own right. Shahn had worked for an art journal with Communist Party ties in the early 1930s, but he turned against the party after Stalin's show trials and pact with Hitler later in the decade. And Shahn had just spent three years working as a photographer for the Resettlement Administration, later the Farm Security Administration, traveling around the country in the company of Walker Evans, Dorothea Lange, and others to document the American people. The job changed both Shahn's politics and his paintings.

The trips brought him into contact with the particulars of a reality that was beyond his imagination. He met idiosyncratic characters he couldn't have made up, and saw suffering he hadn't understood before—perhaps because he had prioritized political theory over direct experience. “Everything I had gotten about the condition of miners or cotton pickers I'd gotten on Fourteenth Street,” he said in a 1965 interview, presumably alluding to his own neighborhood, New York's Greenwich Village, then home to many radicals. Photography made him abandon Social Realism for what he called “personal realism,” he wrote in his book *The Shape of Content*.

Shahn had a radical's take on political art, though. He refused to accept that art is not art if it is propaganda. All that claim meant, he said, is that the art had social content. And even if it was intended to persuade, that didn't make it bad. “*Propaganda* is to me a noble word,” Shahn said in a 1968 oral history. “It means you believe something very strongly and you want other people to believe it; you want to propagate

your faith.” No one claims that European art was the worse for having propounded Christian theology, he continued. “When Giotto did the frescoes in Assisi, you know, that was as propagandistic a work of art as there was.”

By 1940, when the Social Security competition took place, the New Deal was already coming to an end. Shahn and his partner, the painter Bernarda Bryson, who collaborated with him on several projects, set out for Washington to begin the murals on December 8, 1941—one day after Pearl Harbor. Instead of the Social Security Board, the War Department

moved into the building, which got so crowded that desks filled the corridor where Shahn was painting. Conservators later found burn marks on the walls where people had stubbed out their cigarettes. Perhaps the air of gravitas evident in all the building's murals, and the ambivalence hinted at in Guston's and Fogel's, reflects the anxieties of the time. While Shahn was working, people came up to him and said that what he was painting was what they were fighting for.

Over the course of the early '40s, funding for New Deal arts programs dried up. Shahn's *The Meaning of Social Security*, completed in 1942, were his last murals for the Roosevelt administration. The painters who became Abstract Expressionists—many of them former New Deal artists themselves—rejected the sentimentality of “American scene” art. Then again, they did their work after the war, when democracy seemed to be winning the day. Eight decades later, as nations inch toward despotism, an art animated by democratic impulses makes a stronger case for itself. It proposes a mutual bond between Americans and their government—a vision of the security we are due and the loyalty we owe in return. That reciprocity remains very much an unfinished project. Right now, government is being torn down, rather than built up. If the Cohen building is not demolished, it could remind future generations what patriotism looked like. *A*

Judith Shulevitz is a staff writer at The Atlantic.

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ESSAY

On Losing a Daughter

*The people we
were died at
the exact moment
our child did.*

By Danielle
Crittenden

My husband, David, hates Valentine's Day. He once called it "New Year's Eve with nuclear weapons." I pretend not to care. Still, when the day passes entirely unremarked on, a woman can't help but feel overlooked. ¶ On Valentine's Day 2024, David found a way out. He booked a speech on February 14 that required traveling from our home in Washington, D.C., to Toronto. I couldn't object—he



was getting paid. Anyway, I had my own plans: an “anti-Valentine’s Day” dinner hosted by one of the foreign embassies.

As I got ready, I called our oldest daughter, Miranda. She answered from her Brooklyn bathroom, getting ready for her own party. She propped her phone up beside her sink and laughed when I told her about her father’s strategic Valentine’s Day escape.

I asked what she planned to wear. She sent a selfie: It showed her looking at her bathroom mirror; her straight rose-gold hair bobbed along her jawline. A strapless black top exposed her pale, delicate shoulders. (*Too pale and delicate*, I worried reflexively, maternally.)

“Stunning,” I texted back.

It was the last communication I’d ever have with her.

Two days later, I was coming down the stairs when David’s voice shattered the morning. Words tumbled out in fragments: Miranda’s best friend calling from the apartment. Found unconscious. Not breathing. Maybe—

I seized the phone from David’s shaking hand. I could hear a police officer’s radio chatter, the soundtrack to all urban tragedy.

“I’m sorry—” a voice began.

What is the opposite of giving birth?

I HUNG UP and stepped into my bathroom to pack my toiletry case. David was slumped in a chair, face in hands, moaning, “No, no, it can’t be.” I rummaged through my drawers, frantically pulling out pajamas, my medications, a toothbrush. My overwhelming instinct was to get to New York right away, to Miranda right away. I suppose I felt that I’d be able to straighten this all out somehow, as I had straightened things out for her so many times in the past. David was still in the chair: “No, no, no.”

I wrapped my arms around him. “We have to get to Brooklyn.”

We were waiting for our flight at Reagan National when the medical examiner called from Miranda’s apartment. He was matter-of-fact. Miranda had been found face down in her bedroom by her housekeeper around 9 a.m. The cleaner called Miranda’s friend—another client—who called the police. Based on body

temperature and other physical evidence, the examiner estimated Miranda’s time of death to be approximately 3 a.m.

The examiner’s first thought was overdose—pills lay everywhere. But they were just her daily medications, scattered when she collapsed. Watching planes take off and land, I numbly shared Miranda’s medical history. Five years earlier, she’d had a nonmalignant brain tumor successfully removed. The tumor had damaged her pituitary gland beyond repair—but this was not a problem. The surgeon had assured us that medication could do everything the gland once did.

Lately, Miranda had been fighting what she assumed was a stubborn cold. When she was ill, she was supposed to take more cortisol, the stress hormone that her body could no longer produce. But cortisol came with a price: It bloated her face, thickened her waist, and made her feel unlike herself. I knew she’d been playing with her dosage to minimize these side effects.

The examiner said that people with compromised immune systems could sometimes present with flu-like symptoms that turned deadly if not treated.

A hundred questions charged through my mind: How could Miranda have been that sick without knowing it? How did *we* not know it? Had any of her doctors told her she risked dropping dead if she got her cortisol levels wrong?

But these were not the most urgent of my questions at that moment.

“May—may I ask you something ... as a mother?”

“Of course.”

“I just need to know—” I had to run at the sentence a few times before I could get it out. “Would my daughter have been in any ... pain ... when she ... ? If this was how she ... ?”

“No,” he replied quickly, his voice softening. “She would have fallen unconscious before her heart stopped beating. She wouldn’t have been aware of anything.”

“Thank you.”

The examiner passed the phone to a police officer. “When do you think you’ll get here?” he asked abruptly.

My brain struggled to refocus. Maybe by four?

“I’m not sure if we’ll be here by then.” That afternoon the police would have to seal the apartment, and Miranda would be moved “to the examiner’s office downtown.” The officer gave me a case number and other details we’d need for what I would come to call the Bureaucracy of Death.

There was now no getting around the truth. “The examiner’s office downtown” was not some place where our daughter was going to receive urgent medical care. It was the morgue.

By the time we made it to Brooklyn, the apartment had been sealed. We checked into a hotel and grabbed Ringo, Miranda’s beloved dog, who had been in the care of her friend. We took an Uber to the medical examiner’s building in outer Brooklyn—a fortress of brick and concrete, its grid of windows glowing fluorescent against the dark. The doors were locked. We stood there anyway, as close to Miranda as we could get.

The February night was bleak. David and I sat on the icy curb with Ringo between us, the confused dog seeking warmth from both sides. David opened his phone to search for Psalm 121. We began to recite it together into the darkness. *I lift up mine eyes unto the hills ...*

I lifted my eyes up to the building. Somewhere behind those windows lay our daughter, in a refrigerated drawer.

Years before, on a bitter winter’s day, I’d asked my stepfather if we might get snow. “Too cold to snow,” he replied. It was such a Canadian response, I laughed.

I realized now that “too cold to snow” perfectly described our emotional state. Too shocked to cry: that would be our personal weather report for days to come.

LESS THAN A WEEK after Miranda had sent me that selfie, I sat in front of my computer while a funeral director and I shopped online for coffins. He swiped through about a dozen. Which would suit our daughter best?

I thought back to all of the times Miranda and I had exchanged links for clothing, seeking each other’s advice: “This would look great on you!” We settled on a simple coffin made of pine.

Miranda’s body was transferred to the funeral home, where our surviving

children met us. Our son, Nat, and his wife, Isabel, had flown in from Los Angeles. Our younger daughter, Bea, a junior in college, had returned from a semester abroad in France. Now we all gathered wordlessly in a waiting room until we were allowed into the chapel that held Miranda's body.

Nothing can prepare you for the sight of your dead child. My first view when we entered the room was of the crown of Miranda's head, the only part of her that wasn't covered by a blanket. If some piece of me still refused to believe that Miranda was gone—if some corner of my mind clung to a final fantasy of error by the medical authorities—there was no mistaking that swirl of spun-rose-gold hair. I'd smothered that spot in kisses when Miranda was a baby. I'd stroked it through countless illnesses. It was the first part of her I'd seen when she'd emerged from brain surgery—on a gurney being raced to intensive care.

Now she lay before us on a gurney once more. I kissed the crown of her head one last time. Her hair felt dry, the scalp beneath frigid. I remembered how much she hated being cold.

The usher asked if we wanted him to pull the blanket from her face. We nodded. My mind has blocked many details of that moment, but I remember that Miranda was disfigured by her fall, her right cheek bruised and indented. When I rested my hand on her blanketed torso, she felt as stiff and lifeless as a tailor's dummy.

I stroked her icy brow. I told her how much I loved her. After that, I don't know what I thought or said. I rested my head on her chest, wrapped my arms around her, and wept.

WE ARE NOT the first people to have lost a child, obviously. One of the first shocks was discovering how crowded this alternate universe was. We met people living parallel nightmares. The parents of a teenager—an only child—who'd committed suicide. A couple whose daughter died giving birth. A father who'd watched in horror as his 7-year-old boy was struck by a car at the bottom of their driveway.

However unique and precious your own loss feels, you realize that you've simply

joined the limping thousands—millions—whose lives have been devastated by the routine catastrophes that befall someone, somewhere every second of every day. From them we learned what to expect: There would be no "healing." No return to who we were. Those people died at the exact moment our child did.

Their wisdom was far more helpful than the advice I got from the happiness hucksters of TED Talks and TikToks who promised us "stages" to climb through, some sort of "acceptance" glimmering at the journey's end. My social media overflowed

Believe it or not, there is no shortage of people who think that the worst thing that can happen to you is actually an opportunity for growth.

with soothing quotes, burbling streams, the idea that grief is a "gift." Believe it or not, there is no shortage of people who think that the worst thing that can happen to you is actually an opportunity for growth. They kept feeding me a bastardized version of a line from the 13th-century poet Rumi: "Sorrow prepares you for joy. It violently sweeps everything out of your house, so that new joy can find space to enter."

To which Miranda would have joined me in saying: "Fuck off."

Miranda's death was not my spiritual gain. Nothing better would grow in her place. My "truth" was that my daughter was dead.

In those first days, I had no tolerance for bullshit. We buried Miranda in Canada, near our cottage on Lake Ontario, where our kids had spent every summer of their lives. David and I had discovered the cemetery when we'd shopped for our own burial places. Pity the immigration official who detained me at Dulles airport on my return. My U.S. passport was being renewed when Miranda had died; I'd had to travel on my Canadian one. I hadn't known the rule: Americans must enter America as Americans, even those of us with dual citizenship.

I was ordered to a holding room; David was allowed to accompany me. We waited for more than an hour, exhausted, debilitated by grief. Finally, an officer called me to his desk. After confirming my identity, he asked me why I was traveling on a Canadian passport.

"My U.S. passport is being renewed," I replied.

"I suppose," he said sarcastically, "you must have had a *very good reason* to leave the country on a Canadian passport, right? It was *so* urgent that you couldn't wait for your new passport to arrive?"

"Yes."

"Well, what was the reason? I'd *love* to hear it."

"I had to bury my daughter."

David said afterward that it was as if I'd flung a bomb at the man. His body all but flew back and hit the wall.

Red-faced, he handed me my passport. "I'm sorry for your loss."

UNFORTUNATELY, my no-bullshit period did not last long. It soon yielded to deep and hopeless depression.

Miranda was dead. Miranda no longer existed. Every thought about her had to contend with this untenable fact.

Friends asked if I was able to sleep. Yes, miraculously, I was. I slept the way an exhausted soldier passes out in the trenches while shells whiz overhead. Sleep wasn't the problem. Waking up was the problem. Every morning, consciousness brought the same first thought: *Miranda is still dead.*

Sometimes the grief hit me in a general way: *My beautiful girl, no, no, no. My beautiful baby girl.* Other times, sharp and specific: *She would have loved this recipe, but now I can't share it.* Small or large, it didn't matter. Every thought had the power to punch me to the floor.

The first time I went grocery shopping, I passed Miranda's favorite items: almond milk, edamame, those awful energy drinks she loved. Suddenly my chest seized. The floor tilted. I raced out of the store. Reminders of Miranda were everywhere. I'd unlock my phone and there, without warning, would be a carousel of AI-curated memories: "Family Fun,"

"Furry Friends," "Portraits"—Miranda's face glowing from every frame. My car's Bluetooth kept offering to "connect to Miranda's iPhone." The very ordinariness of these shocks underscored the fact that I hadn't lost just a daughter, but a whole life.

One night, a jagged pain in my chest woke me up. It was just past 3 a.m. I felt the impulse to vomit and stumbled to the toilet. My left arm tingled. I struggled to breathe. I Googled *female heart attack symptoms* and then called 911.

At the hospital, I was taken to a quiet exam room. Somehow, my blood pressure was fine and my heart was in perfect condition—mechanically speaking.

I told the cardiologist that my daughter had just died. Maybe I was having a heart attack, despite having a healthy heart? I had read about broken-heart syndrome, in which the body can mimic cardiac arrest from grief alone. Rarely fatal but terrifyingly real.

After expressing her condolences, the cardiologist explained what was actually happening: a medical-grade panic attack. She instructed a nurse to pump some sedative into my IV.

Back at home, my heart kept on aching. I mean that literally. The pain simmered in my chest like a covered pot. Several times a day, it would boil over. My knees would buckle. The wails would begin in my throat, and gradually descend deeper and deeper into my gut until no noise emerged at all. The weeping would continue even after my voice failed. I'd continue to convulse in terrible silence.

During these eruptions, the same vision always came to me: Miranda's body in the ground. I imagined myself crawling down to join her, settling into that deep, cool, peaceful earth. How comforting it would be to lie beside her. *Please let me go there; please, please let me be with her again. I can't keep living with this.*

In my previous life, suicide had been an abstraction—something I could grasp intellectually when others spoke of depression or terminal illness. Only now, writhing on the floor, did I understand it from the inside: The promise of eternal nothingness seemed preferable to relentless suffering.

I turned to the literature of grief—the scientific self-help manuals by Elisabeth Kübler-Ross, the memoirs of Joan Didion and others—to answer one urgent question: When would the pain stop?

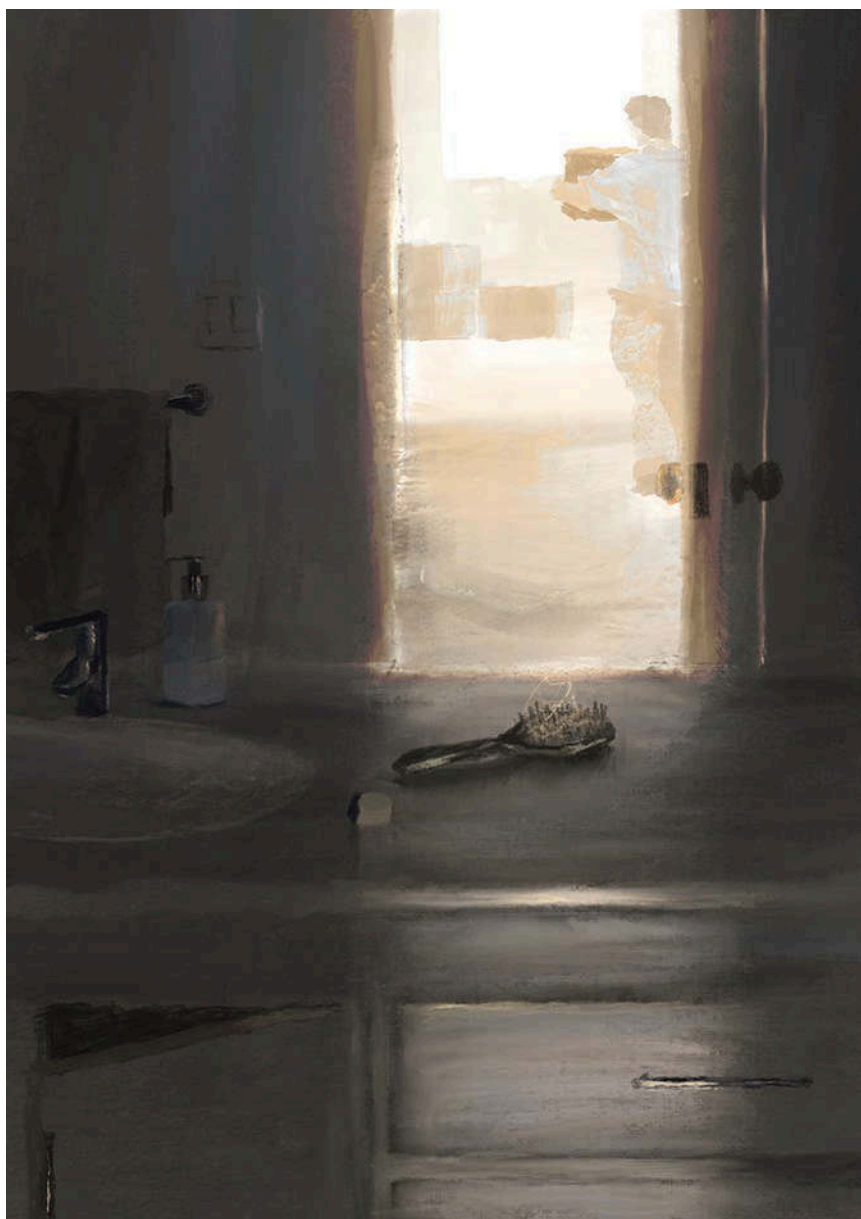
Never, was the consensus. Grief must be "gotten through."

The grief books were not going to tell me what I needed to know. I was simply pawing through them, searching for the spell that would bring Miranda back. But as an acquaintance who'd also lost a daughter warned us, "That's not on the table."

So what was on the table?

A tasting menu of pain, madame. Might we suggest the suffering sampler?

Maybe it was time to look into therapy.



FINDING HELP when you're desperately depressed is harder than you might think. My primary-care doctor sent me a list of grief specialists, but they either weren't taking on new clients or had endless waiting lists. No one I called could see me for months. I needed help *now*. I called a local center that offered "crisis response." A voice recording asked me to leave a message, but warned of a yearlong waiting list for treatment. *If this is an emergency, please hang up and dial 911.* After the beep, I said, "Hello, I recently lost a daughter. I'm really struggling and need help. I don't know what to do. Please call me back." I left similar messages at other practices, my voice cracking through each one.

Then I remembered a psychiatric center not far from our house, one I'd passed countless times while running errands. I drove there straight away. I was hyperventilating by the time I was buzzed into the lobby. A receptionist sat behind a wall of glass. "Can I help you?"

The words tumbled out between sobs: *daughter dead, so much pain, was there someone, anyone—?*

"Do you have an appointment?"

"No."

She made a call.

"The person who would handle this isn't picking up."

Just over her shoulder was a cheerful poster boasting about the facility's support for women.

"I'm really in a bad way. Is there no one I could speak to?"

"That would be the person I just tried."

"Can I make an appointment to come back?"

"You would have to speak to them first."

I took down the person's name and number and left. Later attempts reached only the receptionist or rang into nowhere. Finally, someone answered: The person no longer worked there. No, there wasn't another person. If this is an emergency, you should hang up and dial 911.

Apparently my only option was to walk into an emergency room and say the magic words about self-harm. The idea of being heavily medicated for days sounded like paradise. But sooner or later, they'd discharge me, and my daughter would be no less dead.

Googling treatments for acute grief, I came across eye-movement desensitization and reprocessing, a therapy for post-traumatic stress disorder. I'd associated PTSD with combat veterans, but I learned that it can encompass all trauma, including sudden loss. In EMDR, a patient revisits a trauma while the brain receives bilateral stimulation—their eyes track a dot on a screen, or they hold buzzers that alternate pulses in each hand. The idea behind the treatment is that some events are too awful for our brains to properly categorize as memories, so they float in limbo, omnipresent. Activating both sides of the brain while remembering the trauma seems to help neutralize it, so it no longer feels ever-present. I found a nearby therapist specializing in grief and EMDR who—miraculously—had an opening that week. During our appointments, she had me describe with forensic precision incidents that would usually send me to the floor—the phone call confirming Miranda's death, that first glimpse of her body. Every session left me emptied, raw, surrounded by sodden tissues. And somehow, also, lighter.

MY BIRTHDAY ARRIVED in April, on the fifth anniversary of Miranda's tumor surgery. Miranda had been planning to mark this milestone with a characteristically irreverent party, including signature cocktails she called "tumor-tinis." We'd all blocked off the weekend to celebrate with her. Instead, I wrote to the caterer: *Party canceled. The hostess died.*

My family took me out to dinner for my birthday. Halfway through the meal, Bea gently led me to the car. I'd broken down sobbing at the table.

I knew that Nat and Bea were suffering too, and at first, I felt useless. How could I do this to them, weeping and wailing in their presence? It felt like abuse. No child should have to witness this. Yet I couldn't stop.

Mothers are often criticized or belittled for acting selflessly; it's seen as weak and self-abnegating. But the ability to set aside your own fears and pain to protect those you love? That's the maternal superpower.

Mine failed me when I lost Miranda, but it slowly flickered back to life. I

learned to recognize when Nat or Bea needed me to be their mother, not their fellow mourner. The only energy I still possessed came from that dwindled superpower. Even if I wasn't interested in living for myself, I knew I must stay alive for my family.

David and I made a pact not to retreat into what he called "silos of grief." At first, he'd tried to process his sadness alone, afraid that sharing it might send me spiraling further. But when he spoke about his grief, I didn't spiral. Instead, I felt the relief of recognition—we were the only two people on Earth who understood exactly what the other had lost. No matter how hard the day was, we made a point of sitting down together at the end of it. David would open a bottle of wine and I would cut flowers for the table. We instituted a "dinner dress code"—abandoning sweats for proper clothes. "Like British colonial administrators donning black tie for dinner in the jungle," David joked. If not quite black tie, at least we showered, changed, and pretended to be human.

One morning, a friend called. "How are you?" Before I could answer, she caught herself. "Oh my God, I'm so stupid. Sorry. What a dumb question to ask."

I surprised us both by laughing. "You meant 'How's the abyss today?'"

"Yes, exactly." She laughed too. "Any daylight visible yet?"

"Not much," I replied. "A pinhole in the distance."

I was still crawling, but crawling upward.

LONG AGO, my friends nicknamed me "The Minister of Fun"—always orchestrating adventures, karaoke nights, impromptu dancing. After Miranda died, I retired from that position. My calendar opened only to days of blank space.

Many old friends vanished. During a career setback years earlier, David had offered a cheerful thought: "At least we know who our true friends are." I replied that I'd been happier when I didn't know. Now the joke turned bitter. The absence of once-close friends hurt and surprised me. Perhaps they had no capacity to let someone else's suffering into their world. Or possibly our tragedy exceeded their

emotional vocabulary. All anyone needed to do was squeeze my hand and ask how I was doing. But rather than risk saying the wrong thing, many people said nothing. They disappeared.

Casual encounters could be awful. You never knew who remembered. I'd see the flash of recognition, then that terrible calculation: *Do I acknowledge it?* Some asked to be reminded how Miranda had died.

"Consequences of a brain tumor."

"Oh, of course, how terrible."

I'd watch the relief pass across their faces: *That couldn't happen to my child. Can tick that box off on my list of worries.*

David and I began calling another type of reaction "The Undertaker's Stare"—that moment when someone spots you across a room, freezes mid-laugh, and rearranges their face into professional sorrow. *I'm so sorry for your loss.*

Some acquaintances avoided the topic completely, as if tragedy could spread like a virus and they didn't want to be contaminated. Imagine walking into a crowded room wearing a shirt that has a fresh bloodstain spread over your chest—yet everyone is determined to keep their gaze above your shoulders. You talk about the weather, a sports game. Their gaze might fall for a moment upon the blotch, but they catch themselves and continue: *Our son is now studying econ. We just returned from a trip to Spain.*

I'd leave these encounters feeling annoyed, and then annoyed by my annoyance. What did I expect? They'd never entered the alternate universe. They didn't speak its language.

Of all the reactions, the worst was the griefsplaining. *Time heals. When I lost my great-aunt ...*

At a party, a man I barely knew came bounding at me wearing the Undertaker's Stare. He grabbed my hand. "Danielle," he implored. "Listen, you must understand, you *will* get better. It *will* get better. Please believe that. *I know.* It will just *take time.* Trust me on this."

Some of these encounters turned darkly comic. Weeks after Miranda died, we were finally allowed legal entry into her apartment to pick up important items. Bea and I agreed to go together. The night before, we checked into a hotel. The reception

clerk beamed at us, his hospitality smile cranked to the maximum.

"Why, hello, ladies! What brings you here? Business? Pleasure?"

So soon after Miranda's death, we hadn't yet developed poker faces for the unwary.

"Personal business," Bea said quickly.

"Got any great plans while you're here?"

"It's not that kind of visit."

"Not even a show?"

*Maternal grief
seizes the body
differently from
other sorrows.*

Impatient to end this friendly inquisition, I said: "My daughter died recently." I explained that we had to deal with some things in her apartment.

The man's smile remained fixed. "I'm so sorry to hear it!" He handed me back my credit card and ID. "But at least your daughter—what was her name?"

"Miranda."

"At least Miranda's in a better place now, right?"

"She was already in a good place," I replied, so astonished that I now smiled myself. "A one-bedroom apartment in Brooklyn Heights near the promenade."

New Yorker that he was, the man conceded the advantageousness of the real estate.

"Can I send you ladies something up to your room?" he asked. "Some champagne, maybe?"

"We're not really celebrating."

"What would you like, then?"

Oh well, I thought, what the heck. "White wine?"

"A bottle's headed your way. You ladies have a great evening."

IN MAY, the court probated Miranda's will. We could now empty out her apartment and prepare it for sale.

The night before the movers came, I invited Miranda's friends for a final gathering. The same housekeeper who had found Miranda dead returned to clean. I was grateful to her, knowing that she would do the work with sensitivity and care. When we arrived, the apartment looked as if Miranda had just stepped out. The housekeeper apologized for two streaks on the carpet that she'd been unable to remove: the marks from the gurney's wheels.

I arranged everything the way Miranda would have: olives and almonds in small bowls, flickering votive candles. David fetched her favorite wines. The evening felt ghostly, yet I was comforted to be among Miranda's friends. Near midnight, they decided to climb to the roof deck one last time, where they'd celebrated New Year's Eve just months before. Bea went with them. David wanted to return to the hotel. "I'll tidy up and follow," I told him.

Alone, I poured myself one last glass and sank back into her sofa. I must have drifted off, because when I checked my phone it was 1 a.m. and I saw worried texts from David. I wrote back that I was fine, and that I wanted to stay the night.

I washed my face with Miranda's cleanser. The mirror that had framed her last selfie to me threw back a ruined version of my face—sad, swollen eyes; grief etched everywhere. I found pajamas in her dresser and climbed into her bed—the last place her living body had rested. I clutched her pillow and murmured prayers until sleep took me away.

The next morning, efficiency arrived in the form of moving men. They boxed everything and loaded it onto a truck bound for a storage facility in New Jersey. Three hours to dismantle a life.

A small pot of C.O. Bigelow lip balm indented by a finger.

A crumpled boarding pass, LAX to JFK, seat 8A.

*A hairbrush clotted with rose-gold hair.
A set of keys.*

A black satin evening purse.

What to do with relics for which there is no reliquary?

MORE THAN TWO YEARS have passed, but Miranda's absence never ceases to shock me. It retains the power to hit me anew each day. *Why is she still not here? Haven't we suffered enough? Don't we deserve to have her back now?*

Part of my recovery, my therapist says, will be to develop a new relationship with her. Little by little, her voice seeps back into my head. I smile at things she'd say: *I think you can find that same type of dress in a more flattering shape.* I try to summon what it was like to be with her: her impatient tone with naughty Ringo, the reward of her throaty laugh.

It's common to compare grief to a heavy stone, but that's exactly what it feels like. I carry it everywhere. Now and then, I'm able to set it down and enjoy a moment of beauty: the sparkle of winter sun on freshly fallen snow; a full moon's silver path on the lake. Sometimes a joke makes me laugh so hard that I drop the stone. Soon enough, I will stoop to pick it up again. Those who have walked before me assure me that the stone's weight will lighten. I'm not sure I want it to. Sometimes I miss the intensity of early grief—it meant I was closer to her in time; I could almost touch her still. That intensity has been replaced by something harder to name. Not acceptance, never acceptance. Resignation, maybe. Adjustment—better.

I still face the what-ifs: What if I'd urged Miranda to see the doctor? What if I'd been more insistent about how pale and thin she looked? What if, what if ... But I know that these questions run up against the truth of Miranda's forceful will. She lived her life passionately, bravely, sometimes recklessly. Her regal indifference to authority haunted every report card and drove us half mad. Looking back, I realized there was not a single day of Miranda's life when I didn't worry about her.



The author and her daughter Miranda on vacation in 2018

You might well wonder: Was it worth it? Would I still have chosen to bear and love Miranda, if I'd known I was going to lose her?

A close friend who'd never had children asked me exactly this, a few months after Miranda died. Not callously—he was genuinely trying to understand. I'd just confessed to having suicidal thoughts; here now was this stable, happy woman he'd known for years, utterly destroyed.

"My only regret is that I wasn't the one who got sick," I told him. "I would make that trade in a heartbeat if it would bring Miranda back."

His eyes reddened. "I envy you," he said.

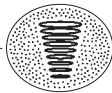
He explained that he'd known many forms of love, but never one so absolute that he'd choose death over living without

it. Yet that's exactly what a bereaved mother feels.

Maternal grief seizes the body differently from other sorrows. The attachment to our child begins at conception. Fetal cells migrate during pregnancy, taking up residence in the mother's brain and organs. The child's cells can remain in the mother for as long as she lives. They can help her fight off illness, recover from surgery. I find this infinitely comforting: Even after death, Miranda remains alive within me, her cells woven through my brain and blood. *A*

Danielle Crittenden is the author of the memoir Dispatches From Grief: A Mother's Journey Through the Unthinkable, from which this article was adapted.

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CALEB'S INFERNO

By Caleb
Madison

Warning: This crossword puzzle starts easy, but gets devilishly hard as you descend into its depths. See which circle you can reach before you abandon all hope.

ACROSS

- 1 Trendy
- 4 Mistreat, maybe
- 7 *Kill Bill* actor Thurman
- 8 Reject, as an idea
- 9 La Brea ___ Pits (Los Angeles landmark)
- 10 Angriness
- 11 Top floor of many homes
- 13 Material for much raver clothing
- 15 Science-fiction sequel that has a plural title
- 18 Touching interaction at the airport?
- 20 What a tube top lacks
- 21 Hindu scripture
- 22 "Say cheese!"
- 24 French philosopher Simone ___
- 25 Spirals
- 29 More or less
- 30 Ideal amount of stress in one's life, for some
- 31 Steps on a scale?
- 32 Sound from an upstairs neighbor, maybe
- 34 Out of the blue?
- 36 Things that might get hatched in secret
- 37 Frays or frazzles
- 38 *The Ambitious Stepmother* playwright Nicholas
- 39 Fly over Central Africa?
- 42 They can take you from Harlem to Far Rockaway

FOR HINTS AND
SOLUTIONS, VISIT:

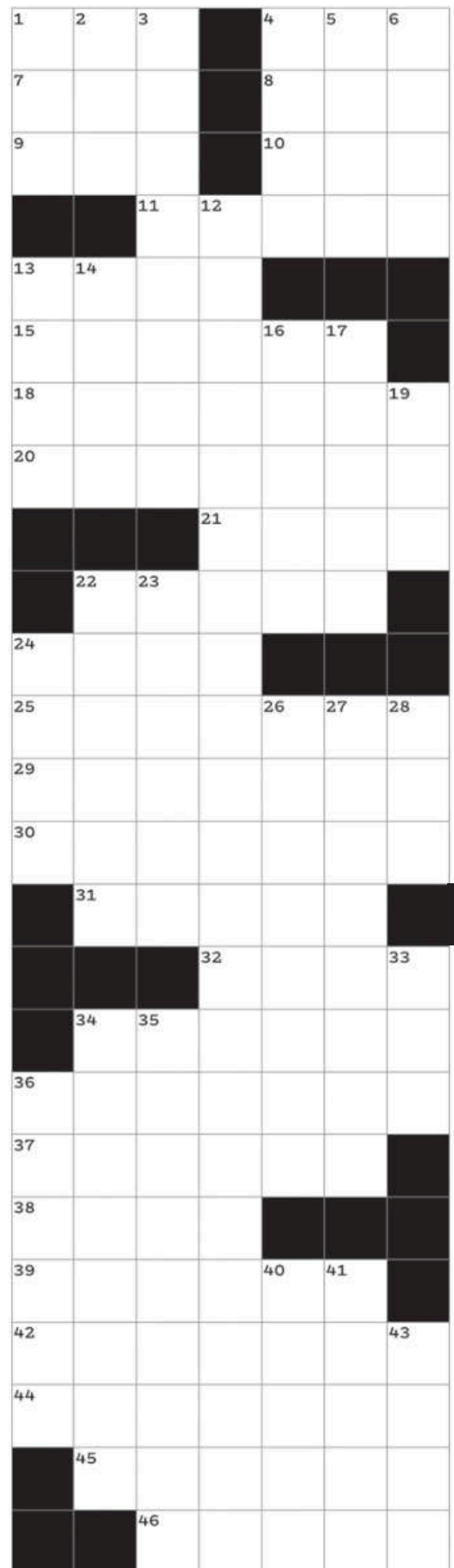


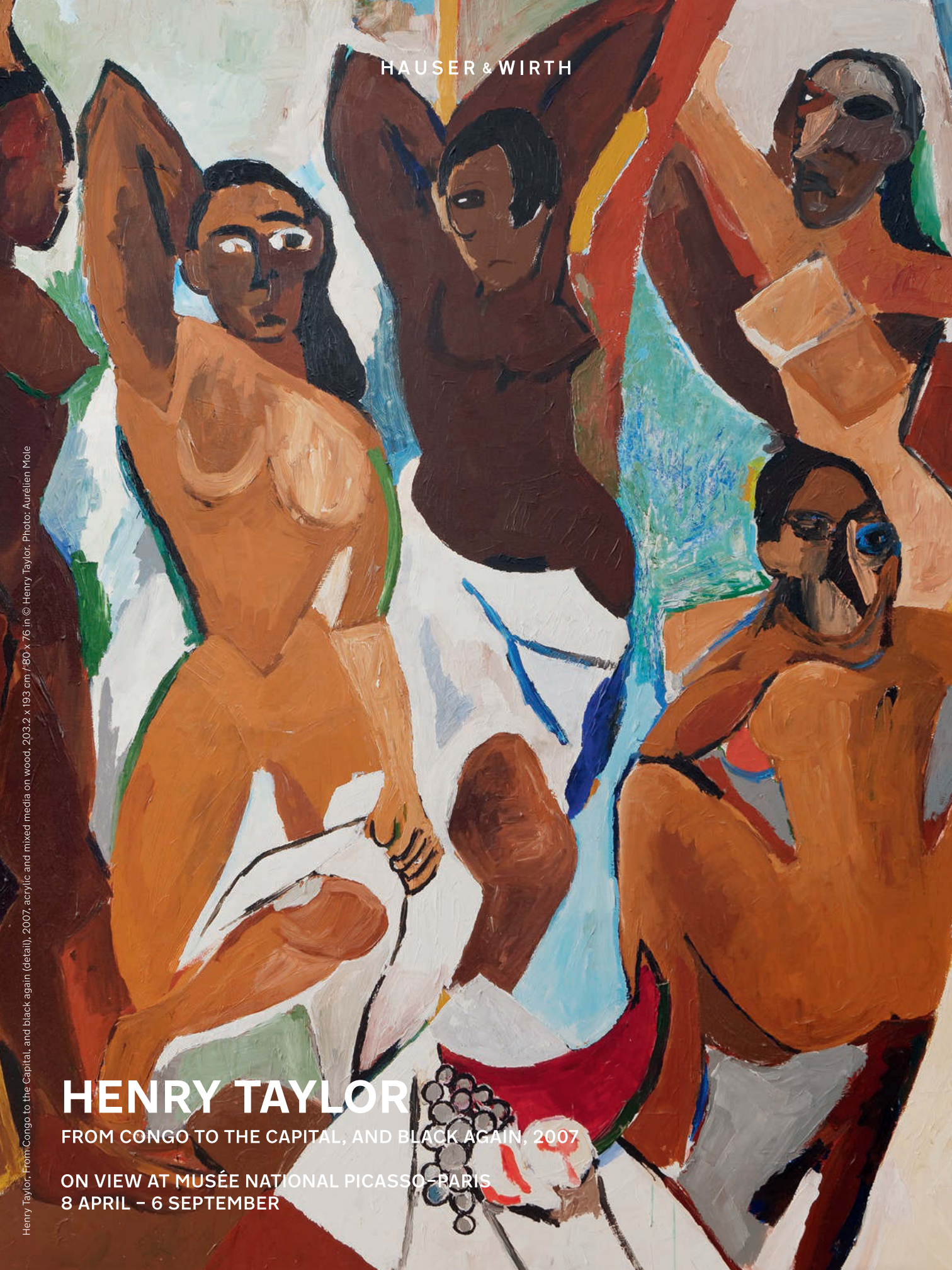
TheAtlantic.com/inferno

- 44 *Un'isola* near the "toe" of *Italia*
- 45 "The bible of opera," per Bernstein
- 46 "... not!"

DOWN

- 1 Pizza ___ (chain that has a Meat Lover's trademark)
- 2 "___ little teapot ..."
- 3 Organism that survives off a host
- 4 Inch or mile, e.g.
- 5 Digital assistant that uses Apple Intelligence
- 6 C-suite member
- 12 "First impressions can be deceiving!"
- 13 Some trailhead displays
- 14 "Skyward," in Hebrew
- 16 "What a ___ idea!" (jokey potential response to a book announcement)
- 17 Any member of ABBA
- 19 Org. responsible for the Dishfire program
- 22 Deem appropriate
- 23 Pepperidge Farm cookie that has an Italian name
- 24 "Guess ___?" (question from a pedant)
- 26 "Your family misses you" plea
- 27 Struck pieces of evidence?
- 28 Home of the Blues: abbr.
- 33 *Boulevard ___ capucines* (title of two Monet paintings)
- 34 How secret messages might initially be concealed
- 35 Piece of bathroom headgear
- 36 Perfect Sleepers, e.g.
- 40 Like a zero-gravity experience?
- 41 Computer built at Penn's School of Electrical Engineering
- 43 That's a wrap!





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